The Runaway & The Gadgeteer

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/21167579.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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Catra/Entrapta (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra)

Characters:
Entrapta (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Seahawk, Mermista (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

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by vase

Summary

Catra has to escape before its too late, but even if that is possible, where will she go, what will she do and who might she meet?
(What if Catra was forced to flee the Horde before Adora ever found the sword, a canon divergence. Inspired by LadyGretchen's Shattered Destinies.)

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

The Escape

Hands and paws tense, claws being bared at every sound only to be painfully retracted back before they could scrape along metal. Each breath so low it made her heady, as the painful mix of toxins and acids that permeated the Fright Zone were pumped into the air-ducts and assaulted Catra's senses.

It was overwhelming, it hurt, her insides twisted and burned from hunger and the poisons filling the air, but fear kept her moving. Fear was stronger than pain or disgust; not of death, but of what would happen before it. How much it would hurt in ways she couldn't put into words as her head pounded, and her chest ached whenever she tried.

Shadow Weaver was going to kill her.

She'd said she would, one day, if Catra ever went too far, ever dragged Adora down, and never once,not since she was little, did Catra doubt her.

But she never realized how much it would 'hurt!' when the day finally did come.

There was no build up, no warning, it had been an accident, like so many things that left her trapped, lashed or bruised had been when she was little. Before she learnt how to roll with the strikes, or to escape notice through distance and distractions.

‘Not so clever are you now, idiot!?' She wanted to screamed, finally letting out a pained heave as the guard rotation passed, fists shaking as her claws dug into her palms.

Had it been anger, or fear, she didn't know, maybe she hadn't slept right, or was getting sick, Catra wasn't sure. But something pushed the wrong button and she fucking malfunctioned! Pushing back when she should have given in and accepted the usual

punishment, then slink away and lick her wounds until Adora found her with bandages and a snack like always.

But she hadn't, she’d yelled, she'd spat and she slashed.

Shadow Weaver's screamed still echoed in her ears, resounding in her skull, a piece of her masks red crystal had been embedded under Catra's claws before she'd retracted them. Racing to Shadow Weaver's side she'd pleaded, apologized, begged!

But it was too late, a hand lashed out and struck her cheek, hardly the worst she'd ever gotten, but then Shadow Weaver was screaming for guards. They came in, taser staffs and cannons flashing and she was sent screeching into the air, over the lockers, bouncing off a wall and out the still open door, barely taking the time to seal it shut with her tail.

Then the alarm sounded.

Teeth gnashing Catra hissed, watery eyes glaring into the darkened air-ducts; and it was only the noxious air making her eyes water she swore to herself and not the idea of Shadow Weaver finally forsaking even the pretense, the potential of care, and finally killing her.

Chest shaking, fur bristling, Catra pushed on, crawling through the ducts like any of the other bottom feeders that made the vents their home, the pads of her feet not making a sound as she moved.

Shadow Weaver might rule the Horde in Hordak's name, but Catra lived it, had called it home for sixteen years. She had made it a playground as a child, when something other than mocking laughter could escape her lips, finding and creating refuges everywhere. She could survive as a shadow on the walls for weeks or even months and never be found.

But toxic yellow lamps buzzed and wavered, causing a shudder to

run through Catra as the darkness increased, her heart racing!

'Shadows are exactly the problem.'

She didn't know how long before Shadow Weaver's power returned, but if it could, it would be soon and then it wouldn't be listless guards and dull witted bots seeking her, but the very darkness itself. The Fright Zone would become a beast capable of swallowing her whole if she didn't get out now!

But there was a thin ray of hope, as dopey as she felt to think as such Catra had always had some hopes, some dreams and right now, she was on her way to one, knowing if it proved false, it would be the last mistake she ever made.

'But it's Adora, Adora won't let me down, she never has!'

Or so Catra told herself. Memories of disparate treatment and jealousy mingled with love and gratitude before she bit back those wrong, nasty emotions and thought only of the good one's, of their promise.

With the note and instructions covered in Adora's hand writing in her back pocket, Catra pushed on through the vents.

When she had finally left the air ducts she was forced to skulk along walls, beams and jump in and out of closets before finally arriving at the scrapyard, lightly guarded and still possessing some natural dirt against all odds. Even if it was lifeless, it didn't glow with a sickly pallor and wasn't dead mortar or cold metals fused together in haste to cover sink holes and decay.

Paws pad lightly as she slips over an entry port, when she catches a scent on the breeze-

'Adora!'

Vaulting off one roof to the next and crawling down the pipes, Catra's eyes widen at the sight of a freaking Skiff resting against the wall. It was battered and old but even her rudimentary mechanic skills could see it worked. The dim blue steel deck had a full kit waiting for her as well, a duffel bag with an outright taser outlined against the synthetic material!

Catra freezes at the ensuing rush of other familiar and most unwelcome scents, Rogelio, Kyle, even Lonnie all stick to the supplies, faint but present.

"Did Adora steal these?" brow furrowing, she realized Adora likely just needed to ask and was helped, but before bitterness could rear its familiar head, Catra smiled.

'I didn't even have to ask her.'

Tearing the tarp from the Skiff, Catra saw a note carved into the steel and blinked.

"When the lights go, run. Be safe."

Was... that it?

It shouldn't hurt, the plan made sense, it was more than Catra expected, more than anyone would say she deserved. The fact Adora took the time to write her at all said so much but still...

It hurt. The sudden emptiness at the thought of a life outside the only world she knew, one without the only warmth she could remember.

It hurt. The lack of a familiar presence at her side, that left her feeling an unfamiliar loneliness.

It hurt. To be so weak, but she still wanted to pounce on her, to smell her, to hug Adora. Her Adora.

'If she stays, Shadow Weaver will know she helped me, she might hurt her, we should be leaving together, she could even bring the mook brigade!'

‘But would Shadow Weaver really, ever hurt her golden child?’ Some part of Catra wondered.

A low growl grumbled in her throat and reverberated across the Skiff.

If she stayed she would die and Adora's rebellion, her first ever rebellion against Shadow Weaver would be for nothing.

If she left, Catra knew Adora or even the others would face Shadow Weaver's wrath, somehow even the thought of the others replacing her as Shadow Weaver's punching bag didn't settle right inside her like most things did...

The watch lights vanished, Catra's ears snapping up at the familiar fading hum that accompanied blackouts as the scrapyard dimmed.

If she didn't leave now, she'd be caught by the guards, they'd be five minutes slothful at best and-

'Shadow Weaver would never hurt Adora, and the others, they just packed a bag so she wouldn’t even know. She’ll rant and she’ll rave but she won’t do anything too rash... This is... This is fine...'

Powering up the Skiff, Catra tugged back on the guiding rod and felt the aging engine thrum beneath her paws as the tarp fell away. With a push on the lever a fierce, fiery burst launched her over the scraps and towards the the wastelands surrounding the Fright Zone.

Catra looked back the entire way, looking for... She wasn't sure what.

She told herself this was the best option possible, that it might not last, that it was fine, because it had to be fine and that Adora would be fine and one day they'd find each other and work everything out.

She was right about one thing, Shadow Weaver did not 'hurt' Adora.

She merely took something away.

And the Horde continued its endless march of conquest.

Princess & the Runaway

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I hate this place." Catra growled over the seething and sputtering of her Skiff's engine.

Surrounding Catra on all sides were trees, trees, and more trees, along with bushes, vines, grass, and rocks. All of soft colors, but rough, strangely ridged textures, alien to the metal walls and stone of the Fright Zone.

Even with her finer senses, and moonlight unobstructed by toxic haze broke through the tree canopy, she was struggling to find her way around. As it was, with the trees seemingly alive and strange animals everywhere, it was all Catra could do to keep her stupid Skiff steady!

'And the fuel situation is bad to!'

She had maybe enough for a day and that was assuming her clunky machine didn't break down or crash in that time.

Catra cast a glance over her shoulder as she eased the Skiff onto a flat patch of grass in a densely packed clearing, balancing it atop a stone slab and earthen mounds.

She saw no soldiers or beasts following her, and so flopped onto the deck, her tail lashing unhappily as she growled, ration bars not sitting well after hours upon hours of flying and stress.

'I hadn't eaten in a day though….'

Groaning her head thunked against one of the more comfortable steel pipes to let her look up at her surroundings while still lying down. It stung a bit but she barely noticed.

Even as she tried to rest, tried to catch some train of thought that could be of use to her, the woods failed to cooperate. The trees and bushes rustled, grass wavered, animals chittered and cawed from every corner until, teeth gnashing she smacked her palm against the deck, a gong ringing out across the forest.

"Shut up and let me think!"

Snarling and rasping she flopped and rolled around, thumping on metals and dragging claws through her hair.

"Why did it have to be the Whispering Woods?" She asked, already knowing the answer.

A forest that Horde strike teams rarely came back from was an ideal place to hide. So long as she didn't fall victim to the same fate as the raiding soldiers.

What was worse, to avoid being seen by Horde bases, she'd needed to enter at one of the Rebellion controlled points of entry. With the lands outside being miles of wasteland before the warfront and the various bases of the Horde's "Glorious march of civilisation" could be seen.

Catra didn't know the specifics of why this area was so 'un-invaded' though she assumed it had to do with limited resources and the Rebellion. The Horde likely wanted to focus on closer more passive kingdoms to cut off the deeper forest dwellers from potential allies and then encircle the survivors. It made sense. But it did mean she'd wandered straight into enemy territory.

"Hah… Well nearly everywhere is enemy territory now…The more things change the more they stay the same I guess..." Catra mused.

Finally throwing herself back up to sit cross legged, Catra brought her foot up and scratched her overly twitchy ears, growling under her breath.

The Horde wasn't safe, Adora couldn't even offer limited protection and the Rebellion was…

"Hahaha," she had to laugh at the thought, not of them accepting a Horde traitor as foolish as that might be but the idea of them being safe.

'The rebellion is doomed and I don't want to fight Adora or,' she shuddered, 'Shadow Weaver.'

Shaking those horrid thoughts off, Catra glanced to her bag with interest. Humming she unzipped the duffle bag.

"There must be a map in here somewhere, maybe there's some island chains or another continent I can go hide out on till I die of old age."

'There you go Catra, have big ambitions!' she wanted to joke, but the uncomfortable feeling in her gut wouldn't go away at the prospect of such an empty future.

"Ah!"

Snapping her hand back, Catra hissed at the faint sting of a cut, not unfamiliar but always unpleasant.

Snarling she pulled the bag open and shoved aside the clutter and-

She froze.

At the bottom of the duffle bag was a torn up sheet of metal, the weak kind used in barracks beds, dark green and familiar for what was on it.

Two cheery little smiles in faded colored chalks, her and Adora, side by side, the way they always had been, were always meant to be…

Those two little faces stared back at her with cheer and Catra's head flooded with memories, of them smuggling away the chalks, drawing it and a menagerie of other pieces. Nearly all destroyed by older cadets while Shadow Weaver hovered in secret nearby, Catra had smelled her.

She remembered races through wiring tunnels and the piping system, covering for each other when one was sick so they couldn't be punished or heaped on for being weak.

She remembered that for all the pain the Horde inflicted on her, for the myriad of scars left on her body, it was home, it was familiar, it was not this strange alien place with too many unknown sounds and scents that never seemed to stay the same.

The Horde was where Adora was and now…

'I'm really never going to see her again…'

Catra's body shook, it shuddered, and finally she doubled over, a wretched scream tearing from her throat as tears spilled from her eyes.

Claws dragged down the metal sheets; the metals clanging as she dented aged steel with each enraged strike.

But just as quickly as it came, the flood of emotions stopped. Sealed up like a cell door and holding back the furious beast within that wanted to keep screaming, keep crying and more than anything keep feeling.

But Catra was a child of the Horde and weakness like that… Well that couldn't be allowed to exist.

With a shaky, shuddering breath, Catra drew herself back up, teeth gnashing as she looked out around the alien woods.

'They're getting thicker, I have to move.'

Careful not to let the precious mural to her past get scuffed or even a scrap of chalk get wiped away, Catra sealed up the Duffel bag and powered up the Skiff.

It sputtered and heaved but eventually did come back to life and finally take off.

Angling herself up enough to break the tree line just for a moment, Catra scanned the skyline and picked her path.

'The mountains, plenty of caves to hide in and figure out my next move, and there's meant to be mines and junk around there too. I can probably steal some weapons, stuff to trade…' She glanced down at her self styled Cadets uniform and grimaced, 'New change of clothes,' she added absently.

Catra flew off towards the mountains, wishing she could escape the pain in her chest as easily as she did the Horde.

"Exploration day three, no day four, it passed midnight..."

Entrapta glanced down at her com-pad, hair tapping keys as she cycled through several layers of energy readings, maps and seismic calculations before she was greeted with a blank screen.

"Ahaaa," she keened, "I was right, it passed midnight… five hours ago, making this the second day I have gone without sleep on this expedition!"

But how could she sleep when wonders of the ancients awaited her discovery, well anyone's really, but in this specific case her, because she was the only one here, or so Entrapta assumed.

She glanced around the Whispering Woods.

As usual there was that familiar glitter sheen to the air, more common in the more mystically inclined areas she had noticed,

likely correlating to the presence of First One’s in her experience.

However, standing out against the overgrown trees and bushes of the ever shifting landscape were ruins. First One Ruins, clearly so for the intricate patterned lines and dots of their language lining the surface of nearly everything, like wires that went to nowhere.

‘Ooooh I bet they woven their code into their very buildings, if only it wasn't all broken down!’

Shaking her head, pigtails swishing as she placed them onto the ground. Hair folded, stacked and coiled with a familiar rustle as she lifted herself into the air. Legs dangling, Entrapta grinned at the sight before her.

It didn’t look like much on first inspection, semi-crystalline polymer in the shape like a trap door jutting out of the ground at a slight angle. But the door was still sealed, cracked and radiating a subtle energy Entrapta’s scanners had barely picked up.

“With the First One’s ruin located,” she continued into her recorder, held up by a few strands of hair as her hands busied themselves with blowtorches and explosives.

“I have determined that while the energy level is low, the ruin is extremely secure, meaning it has not been pillaged and may not have collapsed either! If my hypothesis is proved correct, then I will have a whole new series of relics to catalog and study, huhah hahahaha!”

With that said, she flicked down her welding mask and clicked her welding torch to life, lighting her masked face burning red and blistering purples.

“Open up~” she sang, lowering herself and placing her blow torch against the door.

Grunting, Catra tossed the last torn up branch across her Skiff before stepping back to admire her work.

It was parked beneath a rocky, overgrown outcropping, tree roots cracking the stone, and had clearly torn away at much of the base, but it made for perfect Skiff cover.

“Or a campsite,” she muttered, rubbing her stomach.

Sniffing the air, Catra drank in the alien mix of scents, so unfamiliar she didn’t even have words for them as they tickled and enticed her in every direction.

Then a frown spread across her face and fangs bared as she glanced down at her feeble attempt at map making.

‘Either this dump is moving around or I am just terrible at making maps!’

She somehow was hoping for the former.

Spinning on her heel, Catra squatted down and check the rigged up timer and alarm system. It wasn’t much, but if she hadn’t found her way back in an hour, the insistent and increasingly loud ringing would hopefully alert her. Either by driving the animals away or reaching her ears.

‘It's the best I got right now,’ she sighed.

Padding away from her camouflaged Skiff, Catra looked towards the nearby mountains, all washed out greys and surrounded by black clouds. It was familiar, but without the toxic green tint it did not feel like home.

Scoffing, Catra turned her attention to the fort sitting upon a high ledge, It was still a mile or so away but she’d need to be careful of guards and patrol.

‘Still, a fort means people, and people means supplies, once I’ve hunted up a dinner, I’ll scout it out and rob that backwater before anyone even knows I’m here.

With that, Catra growled and leapt into the tree branches, dragging a single extruded claw across the underside of a branch to mark her way before she disappeared into the thick and mysterious woods.

As the smoke cleared, Entrapta let out a giddy cheer.

“Excavation log, the explosives worked, the doorway is now open! Thrown open in fact, as though opened from the inside, did I trigger a mechanism?” She asked herself.

Staring out through purple lenses a surprised hum escaped her lips, “Huh, it appears as though this temple has been explored, recently so judging by the dirt. I wonder who-”

A violent, flickering screech that sparked like a broken bot stung her ears and Entrapta slammed her hands and hair over her ears, “Don’t like that!” she whined, glaring up at the source of the noise.

Wavering before her was what looked like a mechanically ridged snake with a beetle's head, hewed from metal and with antenna, and cold, glowing eyes.

“Faaaascinating…”

Red crystalline eyes stared at her, no pupils to be seen, but it clearly followed her surprised swaying with interest. Plates of metal had been torn off, dented, there were several weapons jutting out along with wiring like that of the First One’s tech she’d discovered!

“I see I see!” Entrapa cheered, “This bunker has some sort of guardian droid, a real life example of First One’s tech! Judging by the damage done to its body and functions. I wonder why it was damaged!?”

Instinct saved Entrapta as the guardian let out another jittering, glitchy screech and slammed its gaping maw in her direction.

“Aaahaaaa!” Entrapta barely weaved out of the way, cringing at the torn shreds of hair caught in the guardians teeth that were torn out of her head as she flipped and fell into a role.

The guardian jittered, and then snapped its head back and roared, a dispenser in its throat twitching and sputtering but releasing nothing.

The creatures antenna snapped like whips and it began slamming its jaw open and closed like a compactor before blurring towards Entrapta, ripping through her workstation-

“Hey, rude!” Then again, she did blow up its door, she supposed, so fair was fair.

The guardian’s tail flicked up and Entrapta barely dodged in time, watching as the guardian rounded on her, tearing through trees and stones like they were nothing.

“Edit to log, a tactical retreat appears to be in ord-aaaah”

Entrapta fled.

Catra’s ears twitched and her tail began to lash violently, stamping hooves, thumping paws and screeching animals filled her ears.

Leaping from her stony perch and leaving a scratch behind, she landed on a branch, growling low as the stampede tore through the undergrowth below.

‘Is it a tank, troop movement, damn it better not be a fire,’

Squinting as she glared through the alien sparkling lights of the forest, Catra’s brow shot up as a new sound reached her ears.

A person, screaming and shouting scattered questions as if having some kind of hysterical fit that trapped them between terror and curiosity.

‘Bandits maybe?’

Catra screeched as a tree came crashing down in the direction of the screaming and a deep, rumbling hiss that sounded like scraping metal tore through the air.

She should just leave, she should get back to her camp, she shouldn’t put herself at risk…

But Catra was a curious person and leaving some monster running around the woods she was forced to call ‘home’ did not sit right with her.

Baring her claws with a hiss, Catra kicked off from the branch and rushed into the woods.

‘This had better be worth my time.’

Entrapta’s hair was tangled and matted, clogged with twigs and leaves as she used it to swing herself through the forest canopy.

Her pursuer was always in close pursuit, a stinging, bloodied leg, and chewed off hair said that much.

Another roar filled the air.

“I hear you, stop screaming at me!”

She couldn’t think with that kind of racket!

Its shadow loomed, and Entrapta shrieked as she threw herself to the side, a spray of dirt battering her as the Guardian slammed into the ground and sent a shockwaves through it.

Its red eyes focussed on her and Entrapta span, fleeing deeper into the woods.

‘There’s a cliff near here, I just have to get a little further and-’

Just as another rumbling hissing roar filled her ears, metal screeched and the bellow was cut short by a confused ‘gurp?’

She didn’t want to turn but as a rough voice called out, “Stay put!’ the words practically snarled, Entrapta spun around.

‘I’m saved!’ She grinned, as a red blur bounced off one of the tree, dodging the clumsy Guardian with a laugh before dragging black claws over its cheek and ripping out a tooth.

“The tail!” Entapta shouted, but she was met with a laugh.

The Guardian's tail had already started moving and the flipping feline warrior slipped around the tip and snagged herself on its scales.

As the Guardian whirled and tried to throw her off, she leapt free with a spin.

The Guardian blurred toward them, maw open only to get kicked where its nose should be, the metal ringing out with a clank and the entire jaw hood came flying off!

‘The first attack I heard must have gotten the other jaw hinge!’

Falling into a roll, the feline fighter lazily weaved around the next diving strike, a dismissive smirk on their orange furred and browns triped face. Their wild mane of brown hair was barely held back by a crimson mask as they lunged backwards as the Guardian tore its head from the dirt and charged them again.

“Come and get me!” the fighter roared, jumping up and kicking off a tree trunk just seconds before the Guardian struck and ripped it from the earth.

Bare feet clanging against the Guardians head, the fighter curled their claws and with a snarling roar tore into the Guardians red eyes.

Glass shattered, Entrapta's eyes nearly popped out of her skull at the flash of blood that went ignored by the warrior. Instead they just growled, digging their free claws into the thrashing Guardians head they began to tear, wires, tubes and scratch runes.

Soon the thrashing became disorentiend, wild and clumsy, before a final glitchy hiss died from its broken mouth, before it hit the ground with a dull thud that kicked up a wave of dust.

Entrapta stood in, awe? Yes, she thought, awe was the right word. To see an ancient marvel of the First Ones brought low should have horrified her, but given they may have saved her life she wasn't going to complain.

'This is much better than leading it off a cliff!'

But more, she was, she thought again, in awe a little that a warrior could destroy such a thing with claws alone.

'Faaascinating…' She thought, limping, and then using her hair to race forward, before remembering the proper response to a life being saved.

"Thank you for the assistance, you were most helpful!" She cheered as the dust cloud abated.

And she found herself alone with the ruined Guardian.

"Uuuh, do you have natural camouflage?'" she asked. That would be interesting!

A rough snickering echoed from the surviving tree walls surrounding her as the figured blurred from one branch to the next.

No camo then, a shame.

"Just fast, little forest dweller," the voice echoed as the leaves continued to rustle.

“Much faster than you or that silly little robot,” they laughed.

“I can see that, it is very hard to see where you’re going… or coming from… Anyway thank you again for helping me! Now I am alive and I can study this First One’s artifact! Is there anything I can do for you in exchange? That seems like the right thing to do.”

She smiled in the general direction she thought the creature was hiding and was surprised to see the leaves rustling as though the speaker had tripped up.

When they spoke though they seemed fine.

“Yes… Yes there are some thing you could do for me, first.. What is your name?”

There was a strange tone to their voice Entrapta couldn’t place.

Humming she answered, “Oh I’m Princess Entrapta, I live in Dryl, that nice city state up on the mountain!”

A sharpy ‘A princess!?’ hit her ears, before the figure spoke again, sounding more calm.

“Really? And what is a princess with all your sparkling baubles, dresses and armies,” they snarled while Entrapta just smiled, “Doing way out here?”

“Oh I don’t have much of an army, there’s some security forces I guess… I think anyway.” she began to tap her chin at that thought.

“I usually only leave my lab when there’s research I can’t do there. That’s what I was doing out here! Researching the First One’s lost technology which..” she chuckled,” I guess you made much easier!”

The ensuing silence lingered so long Entrapta started to frown.

“I uh… didn’t creep you out did I? I heard I do that sometimes, from, uh, people... “ Her machines automatic recorders and overheard chatter at parties and her castles vents specifically.

“I didn’t mean-”

“I was thinking,” the voice cut in, sharply for a moment before growing into a soft purr radiating from behind her.

Entrapta made to turn but a single hand on her cheek and another on her shoulder held her steady as the hand on her cheek gently rubbed back and forth a few times before sliding into her hair to toy with it.

Entrapta’s hair bristled as she tried to catch up to her own thoughts on this development.

“How much of me… DId you see?” the voice asked.

“Uh, um… orange fur, red mask, brown stripes, brown hair… Red clothes I think. Or is that part of your furr?”

The voice chuckled, sounding somehow exactly like what Entrapta thought a cat would sound like if it laughed.

“No… Is a uniform… A Horde uniform,” they added roughly.

Entrapta’s head tilted to the side as she mulled that over.

“OK then not fur, got it, ooh are your claws synthetic, or maybe there is something in your diet that makes you as strong as you are?”

The tracing in her hair stopped and the voice noted dully, “You really don’t care that I'm a Horde soldier do you?”

“No?” Entrapta had heard about the Horde but never thought about them much really, had they gotten close to Dryl? She thought she might have heard about that.

The voice chuckled again and spun her around, letting Entrapta see her savior for the first time.

Sharp features, sharp fangs, sharp ears even, with sharp mismatched blue and yellow eyes with dark slits.

Yes her savior was very sharp in all the ways, even their fur, smooth as it was looked somehow bristly and ready to cut.

Entrapta felt those claws that tore up a Guardian press on her skin but was far more distracted by the cute little brown dots on their fur that looked like freckles.

“How about now?” they asked quietly, huskily maybe?

Entrapta shrugged, “No… Am I meant to be? I feel like you are trying to be intimidating, is that right? Because it doesn’t work very well after you saved me.”

The feline fighter snorted and nearly doubled over laughing.

“That a good laugh right, not the, uh, at me, kind?”

“Because of you,” they answered firmly, “Not at you.” Before looking up at her with a smirk.

They gestured towards the Guardian and said, “That thing seemed pretty important, and I did just save your life too.. So as for paying me back… Some new clothes, some food, travelling supplies and equipment, maybe even a new Skiff if this backwater has them. How’s that sound?”

Entrapta’s eyebrows shot up as she grinned excitedly, and grasped the feline fighters shoulders, “Yes, easily, I can do all of that! Except the Skiff, but if yours needs repairs I can do that too. I love fixing things and I never got to experiment with Horde tech before!”

She then gasped so loud and so deep she felt lightheaded, “You can stay at my palace, it will be like a sleep over, I always wanted

to have one of those!”

She tugged on the stunned feline’s wrist and turned towards the Guardian, “I just need to harvest this Guardian for tech and check my camp. If we can still find it, the shifting woods can make research a real pain! But then we can grab your things and head back to Dryl, I promise everything is super fun there!”

She did not see the stunned, oddly hopeful look on her conversation partners face,or the flicker of cunning intent that followed.

“Well, if we’re already so close, how could I refuse. But please… Call me, Catra.”

“Is that your name then?” Entrapta asked as she began rooting around in the Guardians eyes.

“I, yes, of course it is.”

“Sorry I wasn’t sure cos you said ‘call you’, well ‘call me, Catra’ actually, and so I wanted to make sure that was why. It would be fine if not though.”

Catra blinked, once, twice, three times before shaking her head and shrugging.

“Why do you want to strip this bot for parts anyway. I know your rebellion must be hard up, losing all the time, but this thing would struggle to give Horde training machines a fight.”

“Oh Dryl isn’t rebelling we just don’t work for anyone.”

Entrapta smiled a little at the pleased chuckled that brought from Catra as they squatted down, next to her and helped pry off the eyelid with a flick of their claws.

“Thanks!” Entrapta said, before continuing. “Anyway it isn’t its combat capabilities that interest me, though I imagine it was ferocious once! But there might be code, or data crystals inside

that could help me unlock the secrets of Etheria's lost history! Or at least, you know, some interesting things, I'd love to see how this works, but those Horde bots sound interesting, do you have one with you?"

"Just the Skiff and some other junk, you might like it though, but I can't guarantee I'll share."

"Aw?!"

"I never said I wouldn't," They added, "But we should focus on the here and now first. Harvesting whatever important bits that can be carried back on my skiff and whatever your bought out here."

"Oh I just walked, like any good scientist I carry everything I need on my person!"

"'Cept a means to defend yourself."

"Well, yes, that may have been a good idea, but you're here now, so everything is fine!"

She looked at Catra and smiled before returning to her work, so she missed the stunned look on her face, as Catra's gaze became contemplative as she pried off another sheet of metal to let Entrapta at the creatures brain, watching the purple haired princess with intense curiosity.

Soon enough, and with Catra grudgingly carrying more than she wanted, despite convincing Entrapta to leave the majority of the Guardian behind to be hopefully found later, they set off towards her Skiff.

Entrapta's voice filling the air with her theories and postulation about the design and function of the Guardian robot to an intrigued, if desperately trying to keep up, Catra.

And thanks to Catra's line of scratches and keen senses being tormented by her alarm system, it only took them three hours to

find her Skiff, over the usual day or two it would take a regular person.

With their supplies loaded up, and Entrapta having re-wired the flagging engine to make sure it could survive one last intense run up the mountain, they were off to Dryl.

Neither knew what the next day would bring, but both were a little brighter than they had been the day before.

Chapter End Notes

I would like to thank Roman Around for their help editing this piece!

So this is the second chapter of the what if AU story, and I hope people enjoyed it and found the direction I am taking things interesting!

If you have questions, comments or critique please feel free to share! This was originally going to be two chapters but I didn't like the idea of breaking this up as it felt contrived and so just pushed through!

Quick aside, the idea here is that this event for Entrapta could have happened in canon, she was planning to lead the Guardian off a cliff, before Catra showed up.

Arrival at Dryl

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The trip towards Dryl had been uneventful, much to Catra's relief, with Entrapta filling the lack of action by excitedly chattering about the broken robot as she inspected the remains.

Catra had listened intently, even when she didn't understand, because peppered throughout were many slivers of useful information that helped her get a fuller picture for who Entrapta was.

Which was in part why they had needed to make a brief stop for Catra to better disguise herself. Horde duffel bag traded for one of Entrapta's, a torn blanket and tarp mangled together made for a cloak and scarf that fit perfectly with her chosen persona.

"Remember," she said as they approached the city, "I'm Catra a-"

"Rogue scavenger who saved me from a robot, I remember!"

Catra hoped she did, otherwise she was driving the Skiff off a cliff and hoping she could make a landing when the pitchforks inevitably came out.

Shaking her head, Catra turned her attention to the fast approaching city.

Much like Entrapta the entire place radiated various shades of purple that Catra couldn't name. Unlike the ruined villages she'd passed by though, Dryl was not made up of clay or wood, but some vaguely familiar material like that of metal.

She could see lavender crystals acting as lights, or maybe cameras, and a few scattered pipes leading in and out of the city.

‘*Waste disposal or water pumping.*’ Catra guessed, before focussing on the city’s shape.

Barring the pointed tower, it was not a high rising place like Horde structures, and what buildings she could see looked sturdy but faintly curved.

Upon the fairly high walls there rested several mobile turrets, weaker than those she knew from the Horde. The fact they had several barrels meant they likely would be a nightmare to regular soldiers but useless against tanks.

Entrapta started giggling excitedly as she waved at the guard who returned the gesture after a moment or so of confusion.

Catra’s hackles stood on end as they came to a halt outside the strangely patterned gate.

“I’m back!” Entrapta cheered.

“Welcome back, Princess!” One of the guards, a blonde satyr with a long face answered, waving behind him with some unfamiliar signal.

“We shall open the gates momentarily princess!” he added, before jumping into a lift and disappearing.

Catra arched a brow at Entrapta who was watching the gate eagerly.

“You don’t have someone on the other side?” Catra asked.

“Oh, probably, that one is Typha I think his name tag said? He probably went to tell the Security Chief and Foreman I’m back!”

“Before opening the gate?”

“I guess…” Entrapts hummed as the gate thrummed to life and slid open with a mechanical hiss.

Rising to her feet with a spin, Entrapta cheered, "Welcome to Dryl!" She pointed towards the slick city streets and added, "Things are always really fun around here."

"Well, wouldn't want to miss it then, would we?"

"We wouldn't, so let's go!"

Catra nodded and eased the Skiff through the gates, ignoring the sputtering of the engine and odd stares of the populace. Entrapta waved giddily and got many waves in return, though all seemed bereft of… Something, Catra wasn't sure, and the city seemed emptier than it should be.

'*Still though*,' she thought, purring. "I like your city, very synthetic." It felt familiar, closer to home than the forests or clay huts.

"Thanks! Dryl has lots of mines scattered around these mountains, so we always have lots of materials to build with, especially when chemical solutions are applied to stone." She grinned and slapped a nearby pillar. "It can be made tough and smooth like metal but from melted stone, turning it into a strong polymer!"

"Huh, nifty," Catra mused, some back part of her brain idly wondering if the Horde used similar methods.

"Ooh there's my palace!" Entrapta cheered, "Careful of the booby traps, I turned them off, mostly, before leaving but who knows if they got turned back on!"

"Are traps normal for rebellion cities?"

"Maybe? I don't think so, I just like them and Officer Dylayle is always asking for more traps in case bandits or the Horde attack."

With that little snippet filed away, Catra drove through the arched gateway and eased the Skiff to a sliding stop in the small courtyard of Entrapta's tower-palace.

Typha was there along side a more ornately dressed soldier who saluted and shouted in greeting.

“Welcome home, Princess Entrapta!” said a sharply dressed elf, with pale blue hair done up in a tight bun. They wore two earrings and a necklace in the long pointed sigil of Dryl bedecking their outfit, an armored grey vest, with silver capped shoulders and flexible pants with a lazer saber and water canteen attached to the belt.

Catra tensed as the soldiers eyes fell upon her, taking in every detail as she too did to them. She shuffled her mess of a cloak to ensure it hid any signs of her Horde heritage and stepped back to let Entrapta handle the talking.

“Hi Dylayle!” Entrapta answered back, “was everything OK while I was gone?”

“Yes,” Dylayle answered quickly, before focusing on Entrapta’s bandaged leg.

“Princess Entrapta, your leg!? We must see you to the infirmary!”

“Hmm? Oh that! No its fine, just a gash, Catra already treated it and besides,” she gasped, “I have so much to study and share, you wouldn’t believe what I found!”

“Ah, yes, your companion… Catra was it?” Dylayle answered, turning away from Entrapta, cutting off her ramble before it could begin. “How did you come into contact with the princess and why are you within Dryl’s borders?”

“Shouldn’t you be heeding your princess?” Catra scoffed, “I heard you guard types were all about formality.”

“This is formality, I am making the acquaintance of my princesses'… companion. When did you meet?” They turned back to Entrapta at that question.

Entrapta blinked away her disappointment and answered quickly as Catara held her breath, hands still on the controls.

"Oh, this is Catra she said she's a scavenger who travels around, that's how she got this baby!"She enthused, patting the Skiff. "It was really damaged so in return for saving my life she asked to stay at the palace while I fix it up and I agreed!"

Dylayle's eyes flicked between Entrapta and Catra before they answered.

"Princess Entrapta, I do not believe that is wise, for your safety we should impound the Skiff and investigate this scavenger, or at least house them at the barracks or an inn. Just in case they pose a threat to you-"

"If Entrapta's safety is such a concern, why didn't she have guards?" Catra interrupted. At the glare she twitched her ears playfully, "Just saying, your priorities seem skewed."

Dylayle's answer was sharp, "Dryl must be protected at all costs- and, the princess ordered us to stay here, despite the risks," they amended awkwardly.

Catra could see Entrapta was grinding her teeth as she looked between the two and so forced herself to relax, or at least look the part, a skill she was well practiced in. "Well, then, Princess, I suppose it is your decision if I am worth the risk."

She hid a smirk behind her scarf at the bit back curse on Dylayle's lips at being outmaneuvered by her own words.

Entrapta nodded and answered, "I'm not changing my mind, Dylayle, thanks for worrying though! Oh can you and some of the others help get this…" she waved vaguely at the Skiff and assorted robot scraps, "into my lab?"

"Princess-" Dylayle started, only for a weak cough to break the tension, as a red haired figure in loose pants and shirts that looked like something softer than Catra could name wandered

onto the scene. He looked like a human, his cheekbones were high, and his eyes soft; the new arrival bowed grandly to Entrapta and spoke.

“Welcome home my princess, I am so glad your trip was, mostly, safe and fortuitous!” He clapped his hands and called, “Staff, attend to her majesty!”

Several strangely dressed people with all manner of hairstyles raced out of the palace hallways, one in a white coat, another in a purple suit and the last in a green dress.

Entrapta kicked her feet and using her pigtails lifted herself off the Skiff, while Catra gingerly hopped down, careful not to let her robes catch too much wind and reveal her uniform.

“Thanks foreman Stanley!” Entrapta said cheerily, before blinking and turning to Catra. “Oh right, I should do the uuuh, official introductions… right?”

He waved her off, “No need to trouble yourself.” The redhead turned on Catra and grinned, bowing with a hand across his belly, ”I am foreman Stanley, Overseer to the mines of Dryl, their workers and the treasury.”

Catra merely arched her brow and nodded, as his introduction continued with only a minor stumble as he gestured to Dylayle.

“And of course you have met our fierce Security Captain, Dylayle, and have even earned the trust of our dear princess. We must thank you, wanderer, for aiding her.”

His gaze snapped to Entrapta who shuffled her feet and suddenly Catra felt her claws starting to edge out.

“Princess, this injury really is too much, such risks for one such as yourself,” he tsked. “If this 'Catra’ had not been around well… The kingdom of Dryl would be lost without you.”

“It wasn’t that painful and I had a plan to deal with it, Catra just defeated it so I could bring its parts back, rather than lead it off a cliff!”

“Be that as it may,” he said with a wave. “Surely we can simply bring you whatever supplies you need princess, rather than leaving you to wander into danger in the wilderness.”

Entrapta mumbled, biting the inside of her cheeks and looking away.

“Not her fault no one else can keep up,” Catra chuckled, drawing all eyes to her.

“Par-” Dylayle started sharply.

“-don?” finished Stanley.

Rolling her shoulders, Catra let out a sigh, “Even if I explained it, you two certainly aren’t going to get it,” she then sent a smirk towards Entrapta, “now then, I believe I was promised a meal?”

Brightening instantly, Entrapta grabbed her cloak and began to tug, “Right, I did! Come on I can show you my traps and my lab, um-”

As she was pulled away Catra made sure to grab her duffel bag before following Entrapta’s insistence.

“Staff,” Stanley clapped, “Please prepare the princess and our guest some food, and ensure a medic inspects the princesses' leg.”

“Uh thanks Stanley!” Entrapta said awkwardly as she pulled Catra through a side door, rather than the front one.

Catra’s ears twitched as she listened to the attempted whispering between foreman and security chief before the metal came slamming down.

“So you are gonna punish him, right?” Catra asked, as an unusually quiet Entrapta pulled her down the lavender synthetic halls.

She stalled and asked, “What!? No, why?”

“You must have noticed,” Catra answered briskly, “I saw it was getting to you, in the-” she waved a hand, “Scavenger community, what he was doing totally undercuts your authority as a leader, same for that Dylayle. You can’t just let that slide.”

“Oh is this a Hord-” Entrapta was muffled by Catra’s hand.

She started to hiss, “We agreed-.”

Only for her hand to be pushed away, as Entrapta gasped, “Oh you have toe beans on your hands, so cute!”

“Entraptaaaa,” Catra emphasized.

“Huh? Oh no worries, no one will hear us, the staff are in the kitchen, everyone else is outside, and I control the security cameras.”

“Well at least you control that much,” Catra mumbled, glaring behind her, “Those two were undermining you. You shouldn’t trust them.”

“They’re just looking out for me, its their jobs after all. Anyway, come on, I wanna show you my lab!”

Sensing Entrapta wanted the matter closed, and not wanting to tick off her host, Catra let the subject drop. Instead she followed Entrapta through the, to most others, dizzying and confusing maze of halls, portraits, shifting doors and secret passages.

Catra would have been disoriented, but with the flow of air and a claw mark left by her toes every now and again, she was confident she could find her way around in case she needed to escape.

Spying a massive metallic jaw that, given the smell, likely doubled as a trash compactor when not squishing intruders, she hummed, "Nice traps, and here I thought Princesses were all about sparkles."

"They're great right!? And I know what you mean, I'm one of the only princesses without magic, but who cares, I have my machines and traps," she giggled. "The traps were actually Dylayle's idea, well kind of. I used to play board games as a kid and I wanted to try making some of the little machines seen in them on a biiiiig, scale!" She said, arms raised high.

"Board games?" Catra asked.

Gasping, Entrapta grinned, "They're games you play with friends or family, sometimes both, they are meant to be very fun, I played with lots as a kid and based some of my early traps on them. Like my giant funnel mouse cage trap."

Catra had no idea what that meant, but given it involved trapping mice, she approved.

Entrapta continued, barely taking a breath. "Then Dylayle said she wanted more to defend the castle so I got to make more, it's been going like that for years and it's great!"

"Well," Catra chuckled, "You certainly know what you're doing. These 'board games' must be pretty brutal to inspire people mashers."

"Oh not so… Well, actually, huh, yeah some actually are, I know, we can try some out tonight! I never had another organic friend to play with."

She led Catra into a foyer that broke off into six different directions and she spotted a framed picture of a beaming child Entrapta standing before two… robots? Feeling the tension in Entrapta's hand, Catra shrugged, "Sure, sounds interesting, but food first maybe? I have barely eaten in the last twenty four hours."

"Of course, it'll be delivered to my lab! Once Soda Pop finds it anyway; he can get turned around in here sometimes, even with the map I gave him! I've been thinking of trying to build a robot to make it easier on him, but I need more Data Crystals to make them work."

'*More robots*?' That was interesting, very interesting, but it also reminded Catra of something.

"Speaking of machines, my Skiff? What are its chances?"

"Oh, uh, not good and kind of not terrible I guess? The external chassis just needs to be buffed and reshaped, but the engine… Wow, are all Horde vehicles like that?" she froze in thought.

"No, wait, you said it was stolen from a scrap heap, carry on." And so she did, "The engine was leaking, the power core malfunctioning as a result and basically it was cooking itself while you flew, it's amazing it got as far as it did. Horde technology gives me far more to work with than I realized, I'll need to find or buy more! But anyway, I should be able to build you a new motor, I have enough parts lying around!"

She then added awkwardly, "It might take a couple of days though."

"Well I'm in no hurry to leave," Catra answered, and was a little surprised, yet at the same time not surprised at all to feel Entrapta squeeze her hand more tightly as she led Catra through a hissing steel door lit by a purple orb at the top.

"Then welcome, Catra, to my lab!" Entrapta cheered, spinning around and dancing on her hair strands into the center of a massive chamber, easily larger than even Shadow Weaver's domain, stuffed to the brim with screens and robotic husks and machine parts.

Drinking in the familiar scent of steel, thrumming machinery and engine fuel, Catra purred, and smirked, "Happy to be here."

Chapter End Notes

Notes:
Another chapter done, I want to thank Roman Around for their help again with editing this, 100% a life saver!

Also on the OCs, the Security Captain and the soldier are based off the two characters who watched Dryl get taken by the Horde and then ran off to tell the rebellion, while Stanley was originally based on a silhouette we saw when first visiting Dryl who was hiding in their house though I made them human over an elf cos we already had an on screen elf.

Anyway I hope this was fun, and whether you like it or not, please feel free to offer some feedback, be it questions, critique or comments. The more wild shenanigans and chaos begin soon :D

Also tried to add in italics for thoughts, hope it worked, we'll see if I can do so later as the chapters all get bigger after this.

Also I was given the idea of none robot staff being more common at this stage thanks to someone on another website, so thanks!

Palaces & Schemes

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Catra, can you pass me the six-one spanner? it's the- Ah thanks!" Entrapta said cheerily, as Catra passed her the spanner. Leaning back she let the princess return to the engine she was building from scraps and several disassembled robot prototypes she had been working on.

Catra was not a tech genius like Entrapta, but she wasn't a slouch, having done well in her field engineering courses. Admittedly, if only because she disliked the idea of being stranded somewhere or her weapon crapping out on her because there wasn't a mechanic.

This meant she had been able to at least sort of follow Entrapta's ramblings, instructions, and requests as the princess bounced from project to project.

'*When she's working anyway*,' Catra mused, looking over the rows of half finished robots lining the chamber, her Skiff, her partially taken apart Taser Rod. Then taking in the sight of the remains of several days worth of snacking, trays, plates, crumbs from sweet squishy cakes, and empty glasses once containing bubbly and frothy concoctions Catra couldn't even describe!

The mass of computer consoles provided much of the light and had been playing music during the brief periods when Entrapta slept. Usually while Catra slinked off to skulk in the vents to catch twenty minute naps then check her surroundings again before catching another nap, her toes unconsciously tapping to the sounds.

And finally of course stacks of board games, some packed up, many not and one overturned after they had somehow 'both' lost and declared it a traitor to the crown.

It had been an… interesting, and dare she say it, amusing couple of days.

Good food, fairly comfortable clothes in the form of purple 'exercise shorts' and a grey 'tank top'; along with lots of space for her to prowl around during the off hours. Plus Entrapta was easy to get along with, compared to the constantly on edge and ready to punch her down company she usually had to keep in the Horde.

Catra's stomach turned at the thought of Adora as she looked at Entrapta linking up a power converter to the engine.

'*She's no Adora, but…*' Catra looked over the synthetic walls, felt the bright light of the screens, smelled the tasty foods and engine scents and of course the robots and well…

'*I could do worse… This is definitely better than some cave or nowhere island,'* she mused. Of course the Rebellion was doomed and Entrapta was rebelling whether she realized it or not, but… There was no need to rush off just yet, Catra felt.

'*So long as no one gets in my way,*' she thought, reflecting upon the irritating and frequent 'visits' from one staff member or another, be it the butler, medic, or guards just 'checking in'. The vents above let her hear them coming but when things got too noisy she sometimes missed them, and Catra didn't like that one bit.

"Aaand done!" Entrapta cheered as the convertor whirred to life.

"This is to charge the engine with a new power source right?" Catra asked, inspecting the boxy device Entrapta had linked up to the rebuilt, squeaky clean engine.

"Yep! I wanted to add in a First One's crystal to see how it interacted but you said you didn't want even a nominal AI on the Skiff, so I left it. Probably for the best, I still need to work out some kinks with the code."

‘*Ah yes, the First One’s,*’ Catra thought, glancing back at the glowing crystals embedded in different robot prototypes that all together reminded her far to much of Shadow Weaver’s crystal and magic in general. Entrapta might insist it wasn’t magic, but the difference was lost on Catra.

She’d been surprised the Rebellion had robots at all and frankly, was equal parts impressed and disturbed by what Entrapta had been able to pull off even as a child! They weren’t as smart or dangerous as the Horde bots, being slow and relying in part on the First One’s crystal for power and ‘interpretation’ as Entrapta put it.

But the fact she made them at all, let alone as smart as she did with the limited resources she had access to, made Catra wonder what she could do with Horde tech. The new engine would apparently run more efficiently and last longer and that was with scraps!

“Fuel is still going to be a problem, the stuff we have here isn’t as potent as Horde fuel and I’m not exactly a chemist, so synthesizing more with so few samples would be,” she cringed, “hard.”

“Hey, I’m in no hurry to leave,” Catra said jovially, drawing a grin from Entrapta, even as her gaze slowly turned towards one of her ‘other’ projects.

Catra gestured towards her taser and added, “Go for it, I have two.”

Squealing in excitement, Entrapta returned to her half done analyse of the taser, having only had time to start taking it apart before the engine parts were ready and her ‘Chief of Security’ became ‘insistent’ that she work on it now.

As Entrapta began to take recordings and ramble happily, Catra took to the rafters, listening with half an ear as she bounced and rebounded off the metal, silent as could be.

She'd grasp one beam and send herself into a somersault; caught herself on the next with her legs to curl up into a sitting position before kicking off again.

What could she say? She was feeling a touch cooped up.

'*Besides, weakness is not tolerated*,' she reminded herself. Loathsome as the Horde was, Catra understood the importance of strength, because it was the only thing that kept you safe, be it your own power or someone else's.

Prowling around the rafters she came to hover a little ways above Entrapta. The purple princess hunched over the traser, welding mask on as the power supply crackled and hummed in response to her ministrations.

"Edit to log," she said, not pulling away from the crackling buzzing weapon. "The method the Horde uses to generate these electrical, energy pulses is truly ingenious! The level of power is out of this world compared to anything else I have seen outside of First One's tech. If I could combine them they could, one day, maybe potentially be a source of unlimited power!"

She began to cackle gleefully as a low rumbling purr ran through Catra at that idea. Overly optimistic maybe, but certainly pleasant, she thought.

Entrapta pulled back her welding mask and looked around, her tone growing worried as she murmured, "Catra?"

"Up here, princess," She chuckled, lazily waving a paw from up above.

Grinning, Entrapta asked, "Oh you were watching from up there!"

"The view is nice," she shrugged. "Seems like you enjoyed that taser?"

"I did, I do, I want more!" Entrapta enthused. "Horde technology looks like it could give me so much to work with all on its own,

and what you've shown me aren't even the most advanced devices available! I must find a way to purchase some."

A smirk spread across Catra's face as Entrapta turned back to her work, noisy sparks stinging her ears a little as she spoke.

"I doubt you'll be able to purchase much of note, the Horde usually destroys all it can and they aren't exactly losing this war." She began inspecting her claws, and chuckled. "Fortunately…" was she really doing this?

Reflecting on her life in the Horde, how comfortable the palace was and the fact Adora wouldn't be on the front yet anyway and… Yes she was definitely doing this.

"Fortunately?" Entrapta asked, letting her machines quiet.

"Fortunately you have an insider informant into how the Horde runs and operates," she pointed a single dark claw at herself and smirked. "And I might just be willing to help you get your hands on all sorts of Horde tech, if I get to stay, consider it my way of… earning my keep?"

Entrapta's jaw nearly unhinged as she gasped, "You want to stay?"

Catra shrugged, "Sure, why not, your thoughts on the deal?"

"I- Uh, yes, yes a thousand times yes!" she cheered. Her hair tails shot up and Catra grunted as Entrapta pulled her down into a brief excited dance that she hardheartedly tolerated before Entrapta took to spinning herself around.

"This is perfect," she said, twirling in place, "With your help things will be even more fun around Dryl and I bet, knowing the Horde as well as you do, I'll have so much more to work with in terms of advanced tech!"

The door to Entrapta's lap opened with a deep hiss as the green suited butler, Soda Pop entered, carrying their lunch and several

drinks while looking… terrified. More so than usual.

'*Shit, shit shit!*'

"Your, uh, meal, Princess, and guest, I'll just be… on my way," He stammered before fleeing out the door.

Entrapta tilted her head and muttered, "I really need to build that assistance butler for him, he'll be less stressed then." Shrugging she dropped down next to the dual silver platters and said, "Want to eat!?"

"Sure, sure, I just gotta deal with something," Catra said, already leaping into the air and racing across the metal beams and into the air ducts, "Back in a sec!"

"OK, have fun!" Entrapta answered absently.

Catra moved as a blur, the patterns and pathways already growing familiar to her and the butlers frantic steps echoing in the otherwise quiet halls.

'*I already know this place better than you, idiot*!'

Growling she threw herself forward, slipping from one of the openings left by her past exploration and trailed after the pink haired man.

Catra liked to be up high, it felt good, it felt safe. She recalled Shadow Weaver calling it a trait in 'primitive species' and animals. She'd imagined tackling her and smashing her mask in at that.

People who couldn't climb didn't get it, wanted to drag her down to lurch around on the ground like them. So afraid or stupid that they didn't understand exactly how devastating a well timed pounce could be.

A fact she demonstrated handily when she shot from the railing and slammed down right in front of the butler, his mouth opening

in a scream only for her hand to clamp around his mouth as she pressed him against the wall, reducing his call to a muffled whine.

"Now listen here-" he started thrashing, and she pressed her claws into his cheeks.

"Calm- calm down," Snarling she drew back her free hand to strike and froze when he locked up, eyes wide with terror.

She began to crouch so she was lower than him, eyes going lax and soft like when she'd tried to make Shadow Weaver- It didn't matter!

But the tremor than ran through her, maybe it helped… Her ears drooped and she spoke, voice soft.

"Its OK… I'm not gonna hurt you… I'm a runaway, it's why Entrapta took me in, it's why I helped her…" she looked to the side as if embarrassed. "I never really fit in… Back there I mean, and eventually, well… " She swallowed, ears and tail limp, "If you don't fit the mold they break you."

He was looking at her now, or more, the idea of her she'd put in his head.

The fear was still there, the distrust and more, but it was mixed, confused and uncertain.

Pulling her hand away she made a show of letting him pass, stepping away and back into the hall.

"I can't stop you from leaving, or reporting what you heard," she could and would.

Rubbing her arm and looking down at the ground she added, "But if you are gonna tell them I'm here… Can I have some warning to pack my things or at least a running start? The Horde at least gave me that much." She chuckled without humor, but smiled inwardly at the way he cringed.

So soft, everyone out here was so weak.

“I mean…” he murmured, “The Security Chief wouldn’t harm you, she’d-”

Catra flinched back as if struck, she bared her claws but didn’t move to strike, instead looking wild and wary.

“She.. She looks dangerous, like one of the Force Captains who…” she faux choked on her words. “Look I can be out of here soon, I just need to make sure I don’t upset Entrapta OK?”

She could see him umming and ahhing about it before biting his lip, running his hands through his hair as he sighed, “I won’t say anything for now, but-”

Catra ‘eagerly’ clasped his hand, “Don’t worry sir, I won’t let you down!” She said, so much false cheer and eager to please attitude she probably even sounded like Adora!

“Ah, well, very good then!” He stammered awkwardly, tugging at his collar and giving her good reason to let his hand go, bouncing on her feet as she watched him go with a wave.

The moment he vanished her expression soured, she spun and jumped onto the wall, kicked herself off it and into the air ducts, she rushed back to Entrapta’s lab, barely suppressing a growl as she went.

‘I need an out, oooor… A fix?’

Flipping back into the room with a perfectly executed somersault, she found Entrapta eagerly tinkering and recording her findings.

Strutting up behind her she began to toy with a few locks of hair, giving the friendliest smirk she could as Entrapta glanced up at her with an unsure but eager smile on her lips and ended her recording.

“You’re back!” she cheered, leaning into Catra’s touch, such vulnerability and trust so fast… “Hey Catra can you pass me the samoflange?”

Catra chuckled and continued to toy with her hair, “I could, but remember how we were discussing how much potential you see in Horde tech?”

“I do!”

She rewound her recorder and their voices played back and Catra let it play, gently brushing back Entrapta’s hair as it came to an end and she tested a hand on the princesses cheek as it finished.

Before she could even speak, Entrapta added, “The engine and tasers have so much potential for energy transference, storage, and expression. Aaaaah I wish I had more to take apart!”

“Right,” Catra amended awkwardly, before padding over to Entrapta’s myriad of consoles and punching in a few commands, the princess curiously trailing after her.

“Well, I think I have an idea for how you can get more. Lots more,” she sent Entrapta a smirk as a map of the border sprang up on the screen. Symbols marking the Horde flashing in an angry red.

Brushing a pigtail over Entrapta’s shoulder Catra purred, “We just money need to purchase some more “research assistants”.”

Entrapta’s split into a wide grin as her hair coiled around Catra’s wrist and she dragged her away from the console, “I know just where to look, follow me!”

Finding out that Entrapta had a storage box, or a ‘safe’ as she called it, had not been a surprise. The idea that it apparently held a decent amount of valuable trading tokens like gems and ‘money’ however had been, and a pleasant one at that.

Pushing herself forward a little, Catra made sure to keep pace with Entrapta's speedy steps. Though Entrapta did not let go of her wrist and Catra let it slide. No reason to offend her host after all.

As they approached a rounded, heavy and multi-layered grey steel door that jutted out of the middle of a hidden chamber, Catra knew they had arrived.

"This is where you keep it all?"

"Uhu, yep, I save it up and spend it on things like First One's artifacts!" She cringed and added, "Are you sure we can't ask Captain Dylayle?"

"I am," Catra said as Entrapta's hair starts punching in the code, nearly three buttons at a time that she could only memorize half the damn thing!

The safe hissed and clanked as locks and electric defenses came undone and the massive doors grinded open.

"I'm not exactly meant to open this without the foreman around to advise me, you're sure this is the only way?"

"Yes, Entrapta, I am." Hand resting on her hip she added, "if we took this idea to her, she'd want to know how I know what I know? She'd say it was unsafe, probably try and take over the operation and not allow it at all and that Foreman guy would back her up. It shouldn't matter given your their princess, but this is just easier, you aren't upsetting anyone if they never find out after all. And for this kind of dirty work you need people who'll do what they're told, and not ask questions."

Catra's eyes gleamed at the three tiered shelves, one stacked with different cards and coins she knew to be currency, the next with gems, and above that what looked to be brilliantly designed and likely very expensive items like meticulous crafted containers, jewels, and a portrait.

“I guess, she can be pretty controlling at times, especially when it comes to how Dryl runs. I appreciate it but…” Entrapta shook her head and waved towards the open vault as Catra toyed with a golden gem stone. “Will this be enough? I usually have other people place bids on things for me so I don’t really uuuh…”

“Oh yeah,” she chuckled, “I can work with this. Trust me.”

Hastily stashing the most valuable and tradable stuff into a duffel bag, Catra grinned and hoisted it over her shoulder.

“Ok, there’s a few more things we’re going to need,” she started, fingers held out to count off as Entrapta was now the one trying to keep up with her.

“Uhu?”

“First we need my Skiff.”

“I can have it done before sunrise!”

“Perfect. Secondly, I need my weapons and bombs.”

“I have some explosives lying around, do you want pressure sensitive, remote triggers or a surprise?”

“All three, also might I add, I love that you have bombs,” Catra chuckled .

“Next we’ll need to hire the help.”

“But where will we get them if you don’t want to use anyone from Dryl? I guess I could bring some bots but they don’t need to be paid and aren’t very fast… Yet,” entrapta added, rubbing her chin.

Already seeing a tangent starting, Catra brushed a lock of hair out of Entrapta’s hair and tickled her ear to capture her attention.

“It just so happens that several rants and rumors I’ve overheard all spoke of a port named Seaworthy, a bastion for privateers,

mercenaries, and thugs who sometimes aided the Horde for the right price…" She rolled her neck and purred contentedly. "But usually get hired by the rebellion, illegal merchants, or smugglers to undercut the Horde. It shouldn't be too hard to get a few to help us, not with the plan I'm preparing."

Her smirk faded as she grew somber.

"Finally, we need that Soda Pop guy out of here." At Entrapta's worried expression Catra hastily added, "For awhile, just so he doesn't raise the alarm. I think he suspects, well…. My background."

"Oooooh, and that's… bad?"

"Very."

"Hmm, OK, well I… Huh you know I have had a detection based trap and alarm system in the works for awhile. If I linked that up to a recording that plays whenever he enters the room…"

"Entrapta that is genius, he's always in such a hurry to leave we'll be days away before he knows what's happening!"

"So I am coming with you?" Entrapta grinned.

"Naturally," Catra said smoothly, "You want to be first on the scene for all that new tech, right? Besides, I doubt I could get back in without you given the security." She could, but probably not without several assaults and getting blood on her claws.

"Oh, they're not that mean, still though this is great, when do we tell them we're going?"

"Ah, well that's the tricky thing… Tell me, how good are you at hiding in small spaces?"

"Can I get out yet?" Entrapta squeaked, half stuck inside the Skiff's frame, half inside a bag with a hole in the bottom and lying

flat on her face.

“Soon,” Catra answered, “I’m worried they might have a spyglass on us, probably didn’t think I’d just up and leave while you were asleep and so they think something is up! Just stay down foooor, a while longer yet!”

“This Horde tech better be worth it,” Entrapta huffed.

Chapter End Notes

As always thanks so much to my amazing beta reader Roman Around for being generally amazing and very patient and to all of you who reads, as always any thoughts, questions or feedback are most welcome!

I sort of went against my usual instincts to detail every little scene here and so indulged in a time skip, I hope it worked out and I tried to work in certain suggestions and ideas that had been thrown in so far as well, IE Catra’s clash with Soda Pop.

Also the image of Catra in casual clothes amuses me for some reason, XD

Anyway, that is all for now, I have started on the next chapter “Seaworthy” but also have another project that needs my attention, hopefully there will be plenty to discuss here in the meantime though!

Thanks for reading!

Pirates, Horde Soldiers & explosions, oh my!

Chapter Summary

> Having finally arrived in Seaworthy, Catra must marshal disparate crews of mercenaries and an adventure seeking rapscallion with a shiny mustache into at least some semblance or organization if her plan is to succeed, meanwhile Entrapta has some observations that simply must be cataloged.
>
> Welcome to Seaworthy!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Entrapta didn't get out much when not investigating First One ruins, and even that was a treat her advisers rarely allowed.

She usually didn't mind this, much, but she couldn't deny travelling around, seeing new things with the promise of new tech, alongside a… She hoped…friend, was new, exciting and had definitely been worth cataloging!

Such as Seaworthy, a fascinating place she'd never normally visit with so many different hover ships, not all as well cared for as they should be, but all so sleek, pretty and aerodynamic!

"Seaworthy Log, Entry Seventeen, my research partner and I discovered that the large curved towers near the coast serve the dual purposes of storage and rest areas. The sailors there apparently don't like to be interviewed, and so we were directed to a local tavern."

The skiff hummed beneath her as Entrapta glanced over at Catra. Her body was stiff, her brow knitted together and her tail was

lashing, Entrapta could even see Catra's fangs as if she was seconds away from growling. The feline looked over the stone streets they flew by as water crashed against the mountainside below.

"Seaworthy is bigger than I expected," mused the feline. "No Horde ships though, so they and the locals must still not be on speaking terms after the last mercenary contract fell through. That's good for us. How's the fuel situation?"

Tapping the gauge, Entrapta grinned, "Thanks to the new system and careful gliding we are holding at over sixty percent!"

Cata purred, "Perfect, that will get us where we need to go and we can refuel there." She hummed a little and finally parked the skiff having done three cycles along the docks, "Finally a spot near the taverns opens. Grab the line."

"Right!" Entrapta answered, reaching out with coiled strands of hair she latched onto the steel cable and helped bring the Skiff into dock.

"Hold it carefully," Catra said, passing the controls over to another set of hair hands as she quickly took the cable and sharpy tied it off.

"This shouldn't take long so keep her ticking-"

"Ticking?"

"Running, and parked," Catra said quickly, as she snagged up one of the two duffel bags of valuable for trade and whispered "Shh" with a wink. Before leaping from the Skiff and striding towards the tavern where squeaky, sharp music filtered out into the streets from behind the pale back curtains that acted in place of doors.

Entrapta touched the small, sharp cornered crest Catra had given her, one of two she possessed that acted as signals and receivers. Though she had explained it as, "The Horde doesn't like not

knowing where its people are. The trackers gone, but you can probably do something with it."

And she had, pressing down she heard a slight crackle and the sounds of music and then the two hard, sharp claw taps next to the microphone.

"It works!" She cheered.

Catra didn't respond, too busy looking around the tavern, which was fine, Entrapta had her own observations to make as she looked over Seaworthy.

It was… Big. Bigger than Dryl actually, well the city at least.

Carved from rich pink and purple stones and ancient coral, dozens of cave homes and raised streets lined the mountainside, while a massive dock stretched into the ocean. All of it was extremely curved and flowing, kind of like waves she guessed.

Entraptra usually preferred to work with metals, but she could appreciate the sheer skill it took to carve an ocean city on such a scale!

What's more, there were patterns and carved figurines all over, though none were very cute. Entrapta thought a few of the symbols might have taken inspiration from First One's script, though maybe she was being too optimistic?

Her observations were interrupted as Catra's voice crackled in, alongside a loud thumping noise, causing Entrapta to snap her gaze towards Catra, squinting so she could see what Catra was up to.

The feline was off near a wall in front of a wooden table and she had just deposited all of the trade goods on it before shouting as the music quieted.

"I'm hiring for a job, low risk, high reward." She held up one of the shiny gold crystals and added, "So step on up if you have a

ship that can traverse land and don't mind the possibility of a little fighting!"

Catra looked around and several figures seemed to be edging closer to her, only for most to stop when a spiky green fish-folk with no shirt stepped up, flanked by a smooth skinned purple fish-folk and a human.

They slammed their hand on the table and said.

"Better idea, you pay for all our drinks with these pretty trinkets, hand over that nice 'Horde; Skiff you have parked and-"

They stopped talking as Catra held up her hand and leaned around them slightly. "Hey owner, you mind if there's a fight in here? Given as this one is trying to rob me?"

The pink, muscular woman tending bar shrugged, and held up a sign.

"Not too much mess? I can try~"

The two crew members stepped back as the bulky fish-folk swung at Catra.

What happened next was a blur.

Catra weaved around the blow and kicked off the wall. She slapped her palm on the table and flipped over the stunned fish-folk who tried to race back only for Catra to flip and slash her claws across their face.

"My eyes!" they wailed, collapsing to the floor.

The purple Fish-Folk lashed out with a saber only for Catra to drop low and sweep their legs out from under them while the pale human was sent reeling from the saber almost striking them!

Entrapta didn't see the scuffle over the blade but Catra evidently won it, slashing the saber through the air when the human tried

to make off with the trade stuff and Entrapta saw a splash of red before they ran screaming.

"Get Her!" Screamed the purple fish-folk before Catra kicked their face into a wall and they went limp.

A few more raced at Catra, but she whipped out her taser rod and blasted the furthest to the ground in a flash of green. The other leapt around, trying to get behind her, but when they went in for a grab she caught their arm. Entrapta hissed as she heard a crack and a scream, followed by a snarl as she hurled them to the ground.

Brandishing her tazer she shocked another who was trying to sneak around low and zapped their head.

The big green one was back up and roaring, right up until she slipped the stolen saber right into their open mouth and a little way down their throat.

Terrified, they started to back up, but Catra's snarl made them freeze.

Silence reigned, all the music had stopped, and finally a rough voice emanating from a tall, purple, fish folk with spikes and tattered fins cut in.

"All right, all right, we can all see you mean business, but you can let Malitheis go now. He won't cause any more trouble, especially not with his eyes all messed up. Will you, Malitheis?"

Entrapta didn't hear what was exchanged next, but Catra did lower the sword and 'Malitheis' stumbled back and leaned against the bar, cheeks puffing up as they gasped for breath.

"You interested in the job then?" Catra asked.

Laughing they answered, "I think most of us need more details, but given you aren't no ignorant landlubber I think you'll be heard out. Captain Dhashi of the Marina."

Another figure moved in, wearing bright blues, a human, “and I am Captain Seahawk, the most vaunted captain in the-”

“That’s great, you both have crews?”

Marina gestured, “Two ships of the line and a Skiff.”

Seahwk bellowed a laugh, “Seahawk has room in his heart for only one ship and one woman, but you’ll find none finer, just like my shanties!”

“OK then. Well the job is pretty simple. I’m going to have several explosives set in a Horde camp and blow its defenses to oblivion. You lot then race in guns blazing and scare off the troops.”

“And you know they’ll retreat how!?” Barked Malitheis.

“You’re still here?”

“He asks a fair question,” Dhashi cut in with a shrug.

Catra rolled her shoulders and groaned, “No one in the Horde fights a losing battle. They aren’t loyal to Hordak, or the Horde, it’s just what they know, but when things look bad, personal survival always trump’s orders.”

“I imagine you know a lot about Horde soldiers,” mused Dhashi, eyes focused on her taser baton.

Catra spun it in her hand and gave a low rumbling growl. “Plenty of experience making Horde Troops run away you might say.”

“Still,” she continued, shrugging carelessly and strutting around the table. “If they, for some reason, don’t run, their defenses will be in tatters, same for their armory, and you’ll have the element of surprise. You’d be paid extra. If there’s a fight. Otherwise, I need you for intimidation and moving the Horde equipment to my… employer, who lives in Dryl.”

“Adventurous seafarers to act as mere muscle and movers!?” Seahawk cried, sounding as scandalized as Lani did when someone suggested breaking a rule.

“Paid muscle and movers, yes,” Catra answered bluntly.

Seahawk stared her down silently, a strangely intense look in his eyes as his shiny mustache bristled.

“Ugh,” Growled Malitheis, “I’m going to need the cash to pay off my damage tab, my crews in.”

Dhashi stepped up and said, “My crew’s on board, provided you’re as good as your word. There won’t be any problems, and don’t worry.” She smirked at Malitheis and added, “We’ll make sure things run right and proper.”

Seahawk hummed before finally saying, “Very well you’ve convinced me, but I want this!” He scooped up and just as quickly lost when she snatched it back, the most precious gem in the bunch.

“After, you do the job, and you only have one ship for this mission, so no.”

She wasn’t sure she liked his gleeful smirk, or the groan running through the tavern.

“I shall acquire that gem for my dear Memrista, even if I must sacrifice the very vessel she blessed for me! For you see!” he jumped up on a table with a thunk and pointed to the roof, “I will go the extra mile, I will take any risk, I-”

“Spit it out!”

“Will set my ship on fire and crash it into your enemies. For that gem… And one of the Horde Skiff’s so I can get home.”

Catra felt her jaw nearly unhinge before she ran a paw down her face and sighed, “Fine, go for it.”

“Magnificent, you won’t regret this, and as we sail, my shanties shall bring us all joy, hahaha, Seahawk I am, I am!” he cheered, racing out of the tavern.

Catra glanced to the other gathered ship crews and said, “Taking bets, who here will wager half their pay that he dies?”

Many hands went up.

“Perfect, well let’s get going, I’ll explain the other details on the way,” she said, snatching up the jewels into her duffel bag and strutting out the door, several crews of mercenaries following obediently at her back.

It felt good.

The air whisked by Catra’s ears and the engine hummed with a sharper, smoother pulse than she was used too for Horde tech, while the metal thrummed beneath her feet.

Entrapta lay on the deck keeping the map in Catra’s view while making notes, theories and observations to herself.

“It looks like we’re getting close!” she said.

“We are, it should be over the next ridge,” Catra answered, her nostrils already tingling from the familiar acrid toxins in the air.

The coast’s faded pinks and soft browns were growing sick and lifeless. The once hardy stone bore hairline cracks, and there were dark clouds in the air that promised rain, but Catra knew they would never deliver anything but acid.

“You lot!” She pointed sharply to her right and left, “Break off, set down and place a lookout on the hills! Then wait till I strike and come flying over the hill shooting!”

“Aye aye!” Captain Dhashi called as she and her crew broke off, their less well mannered company doing the same without a

word.

“And I!?” Seahawk called, his voice tinged with a manic laughter.

“You wait twenty minutes and then cycle around! Take to the air, when the first blast goes off, you know what to do!”

“Indeed I do!” He sang.

Turning to Entrapta, Catra’s brow furrowed as she spoke, “I want you to keep the engine running, and be ready to break if the pirates try anything or this plan goes down poorly. Got that?”

Entrapta frowned, even as she slowly coiled her hair tendrils around the levers. “What if you aren’t here?”

Catra paused in her gathering of the explosives, tail and ears flickering before she shrugged and answered. “I always find a way out, just focus on yourself.”

Hearing Entrapta’s unhappy hum, Catra wasn’t sure whether to be pleased, suspicious or contemptuous of such a thing.

All the same, instinct took over and she leaned against Entrata, brushing her mane along Entrapta’s cheek making her still and breathe a little faster. Purring she vaulted off the Skiff and landed silently on the cracking stone before taking off in a blur.

All Horde camps were laid out the same. Catra had joked it was because the average grunt and even the people in charge weren’t smart enough to memorize different base layouts.

‘Almost lost an ear for that one,’ she mused, as the ear in question pressed against her skull.

Still, while there might have been some truth to that and to the Horde’s justification of ‘efficiency’, it always seemed to Catra to be more about the Horde’s desperate desire to squash any kind of free thought.

‘Which does suit me,’ she mused, pressed up against the walls of the Command Center, hidden behind a particularly large pipe, and she was easy to miss when curled up in the shadows. The evening light was perfect to further obscure her. Meanwhile guards milled about, or stood stationary on their rotations.

The base was old, and just as it tended to happen in the less busy areas of the Frightzone, it was clear to see many of the guards had grown… comfortable.

‘This place was just another border and re-supply point from what the files said. Seaworthy isn’t worth the trouble of taking yet so the soldiers here just move stuff around, guard the border, and occasionally get shipped off to sea when the numbers are low.’

Which was perfect for her, because a garrison to reinforce soldiers usually had more droids, tanks and tweezers than it needed and the flotilla of forty idling tanks on the Eastern Wall agreed with her assessment. Meanwhile the command center was where the Droids resided and easily the most dangerous place.

‘If the Droids get activated then this entire plan goes down. Soldiers run away, tanks take time to turn on, but robots don’t quit until they’re dead.’

She pressed an ear against the wall, hearing the power generator thrum and distant, very distant footsteps and voices.

‘They’re on the other side, meaning this is where the Droids are.’

A rough chuckle escaped her throat as she pulled out her second detonator, the first being embedded in the dirt next to the Eastern wall she had used to sneak in on when the guard rotated.

With a faint beep that characterized all of Entrapta’s creations, Catra activated the grey and purple studded mine, then slapped it against the steel wall behind the pipe.

She’d need to circle back around for a final strike on the command centre but for now she needed to move. Claws bared, she readied

to climb up the walls and crawl across the roofs across the camp.

‘Now, where to next?’

Scarpering into the shadows beneath the main-base and the armory, Catra heard the crackle of energy that made her fur bristle. Before any words even escaped their mouths or a shot was fired, instinct took over.

Catra dropped to the floor, claws spread wide and avoided the first shot.

Already moving she launched herself from the dead earth and onto a wall, before kicking off and avoiding a second shot.

Shouting could be heard, but she had only one bomb left and wasn’t stopping now!

“Freeze!”

She did not.

The third shot was charging, more soldiers racing towards them.

Catra landed and lashed out, sending the taser-mace’s shot into the air and blasting out the high windows of the Command Centre.

“Thanks.”

She avoided the retaliatory swipe with a jump, kicking off the Command Centre’s walls, she armed the bomb and tossed it through the broken window.

As it sailed through the air, and laser shots missed their mark, Catra went into a roll, covering her ears and taking the chance to flick the remote detonator with her tail as she went.

The blast struck as she sailed over the armories roof, the wave of shrapnel that screamed through the air sailing harmlessly over her as gouts of purple flame burst into existence around the camp.

The air was burning hot and painful ringing filled the air. Pushing herself off the wall, Catra felt gangly and uncoordinated. It was nearly driving Catra to her knees as teeth ground and claws dragged down the metal wall in a bid to drive out the pain! Absently she realized she was lucky everyone else was as much of a mess as her if not worse!

'They'd better come over the hill soon!' she thought, as soldiers on the surviving walls let loose blasts upon her.

Catra launched herself into the crowds and debris; ducking, weaving and skidding between or behind soldiers to interrupt the guards aim, while tripping them up as she went.

'This can only last so long!'

The soldiers were rallying, or at least some were, she could escape but-

"Oof!" A thick scaly tail lashed out from a corner and drove the air from her gut, sending her crashing to the ground.

Catra barely rolled away from the next wave of blasts as several soldiers raced off a nearby tank that had skidded to a halt in the center of the camp!

'Crap, they must have been on patrol!'

"Traitor, you'll-"

"Ship incoming!"

Everyone froze and Catra grinned at her would be captors as she subtly readied to move and Seahawk's voice struck the air, never had she been so grateful for something so dumb.

“Adventure!” his booming voice echoed, mere moments before a violent, flaming shock-wave struck the camp, metal screamed and crackled before smaller blasts began filled the air as engines burst.

Catra wanted to laugh until she heard a familiar cackle accompanying Seahawk’s nonsense, Entrapta’s.

Catra snarled as she launched herself at the lizard-folk and drove her knees into his visor smashing him to the ground as she went in for a roll and slapped her palms onto the ground and vaulted out of the other guards sight.

Her gaze snapped to her Skiff, now driven by Seahawk as he weaved between shots and Entrapta waved at her, blissfully uncaring to the danger she was in.

A voice crackled across the speakers.

“All forces, to defense positions, we are under attack! We are under attack! Defend the base in Lord Hordak’s name!”

Catra’s gaze snapped to the walls, as did everyone else’s, and she chuckled.

The ships spilled over the hills, horns booming and engines roaring as they let loose cannon blasts upon the walls, while the crews readied blades and guns, raising them high.

Seeing dozens of visors on her, Catra simply began rolling on the balls of her feet as the blasts rained down around her and the ships sped towards the broken base, a wicked smirk on her lips.

Finally, someone broke, “Re-retreat, retreat!”

Screams of terror filled the air as soldier after soldier called for retreat, a few possessing the mind to leap upon the surviving tanks and Skiffs before they went, others piling on as they took off and the rest just running.

Some lingered or hobbled, slowed by their injuries or carrying wounded comrades, the Force Captain was hissing over the loudspeaker for perhaps a minute before the line cut out and she watched him scarper out the back door, running for one of the breaches in the walls.

"Catra, it worked!" Entrapta cheered as the Skiff flew behind her.

The princess launched herself at Catra and for once, she was on the receiving end of a tackle hug and she braced for it as poorly as Adora always did, by going "oof!" and hitting the ground with a thug while Entrapta hung over her with sparkling eyes.

"What were you doing there, you could have been hurt!?"

"Well yeah but I wasn't, and I thought Seahawk didn't have a parachute," Entrapta stilled and added, "he didn't."

"I would have been fine regardless! But am even better now for the fact I won the bet on my own survival!" cheered the sea captain as he landed the Skiff.

Catra groaned and let her head thud against the floor, as the other ships came to a halt inside the base, raucous cheers filling the air.

"Well," she sent a smirk Entrapta's way and said, "We won."

Once one learned to tune out Seahawk's singing, their work became fast and efficient. That did not stop the man from singing of course, he was very happy to have not only gotten a bonus but won the bet on his life. Catra was lucky Entrapta had bet on him as well, but it made it only slightly more bearable.

Dhashi and her crew had loaded up the six surviving tanks and their own ship with the few cannons that survived the attack.

Seahawk had claimed his own Skiff and several stacks of weapons.

While Malitheis and his crew were stuck with the leftovers, broken robots or those shutdown through Entrapta's skill or a well placed claw.

The hustle and bustle was dying down when something teased Catra's ears, a fearful scampering and Malitheis's stomping feet. Leaving Entrapta to the last few containers and their Skiff, Catra took off after the amphibian.

A metallic thud rang out, followed by a pained groan and a chuckle.

Catra rounded the corner and saw the fish-man looming over a wounded Horde soldier, one leg broken and their arms limp as their chest heaved and too small breaths slipped through a cracked visor. They were a pathetic sight to behold as they pressed themselves against the wall as if trying to shrink in a way that made Catra grind her fangs.

"Seems we have a survivor, how lucky you are, Hordie," Malitheis growled as he brought up his stolen taser mace.

As it blurred down, Catra felt scales against the pads on her hands and her muscles strained to keep Malitheis in place as she caught his swing and leaned out of the way of his free hand's back handed strike.

"I knew you couldn't be trusted you-"

Digging her claws into his arm she snarled, "You were hired to be scary and move bots, if I didn't pay for bodies I don't want bodies. Or is the concept of basic instructions lost on you?"

Fins flapping as wildly as her tail lashed, he bared spiky teeth to match her own and let out a low rasp, "Not getting paid for this, so piss off."

"You have a job to do, and I'm not paying you to take breaks."

His fists balled up as he pushed away and fell into a fighting stance, less cocky than the one from the pub. Catra crouched low and bared her claws with a low growl when she heard dirt scuffing behind her.

"Uh hey I need um, lots of hands, yes that's it, lots of hands to help me load up my Skiff, come on you two!" Entrapta said with a fumblingly rigidity.

"In a min-" Malitheis started.

"Now. Unless you want to ignore the princess of Dryl and lose any chance of new business, you are going to follow orders."

His milky eyes flew open as his 'lips' popped in thought before he stashed his taser mace and shoved his way past her with guttural grumble.

Catra tapped one of the poles on the wall and with a snarl tore it free with a clang before dumping it at the wounded soldiers feet. "Splint your leg and hide in the bunker, you're a disgrace."

With that she turned on her heel and stalked away, pausing only briefly to force a smile on her face as she looked at Entrapta to show her she'd done right, causing the princess to let out a sigh of relief.

With that done, they were soon on their way back to Dryl.

Catra's mind already a whirl with plans and schemes as she watched the mercenaries' ships from the back of the convoy, Entrapta tinkering with a cyber-brain at her side.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks as always to my wonderful beta reader/editor Roman Around for being an absolute champion!

Sorry this chapter took awhile, finding motivation was tricky and I ran into a stumbling block with some drama I thought

of included but decided didn’t make sense after talking it over with someone.

Most of the pirates are based on people we saw in the Seagate episode, I just used a fantasy name generator for sirens, mermaids ETC to steadily generate up with some names.

Next chapter should solidify how the world is going to develop from here-on but consider this a prelude (ominous cackling)

I always have a piece of art commissioned for this fic which I am hoping to share soon!

Anyway thanks for reading, if you have any critique, questions or feedback they’d be most welcome!

Power Plays

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Dylayle's boots slapped against the synthetic floor, fists clenched so tightly that her knuckles were white as she paced around the Foreman's *elegant* dining room.

The early morning sun was streaming in through the balcony, a sign that neither had slept since the butler had come to her last night looking ready to have a breakdown on her doorstep.

Said butler was sitting, nearly curled up in a corner, as all the exits were guarded by wary looking security officers and Stanley was seated at the ovular table, incessantly tapping his mug.

"Stop it," she growled.

"I'm stressed, this is stressful, I tap when I'm stressed," he snapped back.

"I need suggestions not tapping, Foreman!"

Hands ran through his long locks, "What can I suggest, we lost-"

She hissed and he omitted *her* name, "Well, you know…" shaking his head he grumbled, "We can't exactly get her back at this late stage and it would be too dangerous. At this point I am merely-"

"Thinking of how to protect your wealth?"

"Thinking of how to keep things running," he bit back. "With no weapons to trade our economy will take a hit and without the pretense of *her* presence we would just be absorbed by Queen Angella's rebellion like every other lost state."

“I will not see Dryl dragged into that senseless war of hers!” Dylayle countered.

“Princess Frosta then?” She was meant to be powerful, and young as she was she might be looking for a suitable steward to watch over Dryl in her name.

“And take orders from a child?” Dylayle gestured in the direction of the cowed butler and growled, “Look how well that turned out!”

She pinched the bridge of her nose, “This is a disaster, a Horde spy luring the princess away. Our ability to bargain in her name is shot, our new weapons are down the drain-”

“And she may end up building for the Horde, I wouldn’t want to be on the receiving end of her creations,” Stanley bristled.

“They’ll most likely just kill her, what we need to do is…” She hummed and huffed before two blunt words rolled off her sharp tongue, “Carry on.”

“Carry on? How exactly do you intend us to do that?” Stanely asked, smacking his empty mug against the table.

“The people barely saw Entrapta even before this, we can cover it up for sometime before anyone even suspects, let alone acts.” She said with a wave. “And the recordings she used to trick this,” she spat, “Idiot into thinking she was still present may be a blessing in disguise. None of my technicians have her skills, but she is just a child and they are soldiers. They will find a way to make use of it to aid us in this.”

Stanley stroked his chin, humming, “The Horde is far away from us, it would take them years to get here, plenty of time to figure out a more long term strategy.”

“Exactly, or for you to line your pockets at least.”

Stanley raised his hands in surrender at that, “Accuse me all you like, but I only take what I earn.”

Dylayle dismissed that notion with a huff.

“Still,” Stanley continued, “We can make this work, for a time at least. I trust your soldiers but him…” His gaze turned to the butler who began to shake.

“I- I’m sorry I thought I could trust her- Please don’t do anything to me-”

“I’m not going to execute a citizen of Dryl to keep a secret Stanley!”

“I never said execute,” he countered airily, “but something must be done, banishment maybe?”

“A prison cell,” She countered, glaring at the frail servant, “For criminal negligence and corruption.”

Fizzy Pop opened his mouth to defend, but a sharp glare made him clam up.

“Now, lets see about-”

The speakers scattered across the city began to crackle and hum; Entrapta’s voice rang out, bringing a smile to the butler's face and a fearful start to those in the chamber.

“Is this thing on? Yes, yes, it is, very good!” She cheered.

Dylayle, Stanley and the guards raced to the balcony that granted a view of Dryl and much of the forests below.

‘Where are they!?’ Her eyes widened at the sight of several ships of the line, but none bore the Horde insignia. ‘*Pirates*!?’

“Good morning everyone, this is Princess Entrapta, hiiiiiii!”

There was a slight ruffle of fabric and Entrapta continued.

“I am just using the speakers to announce some great news for everyone! My new friend Catra and I went out on a-” she faux

whispered, "-Secret Mission and took down a Horde camp with some very friendly volunteers from Seaworthy! They'll never know it was us, so don't worry there-"

"Who prepared this script for her?" Stanley wondered.

"That Horde Cat must be whispering in her ear," Dylayle snarled.

"But in return we have gotten a load of new goodies, from Skiffs, to tanks, to robots that I'll be using to make Dryl, three hundred and sixty four percent safer!"

"That's a very specific number," Cut in the rough voice of the feline.

"I did the calculations on the way back based on our defense analyse!" Entrapta chirped.

"Anyway, just wanted to let you all know and to tell you to not get scared when the Skiffs arrive, cos they are now, arriving that is. And thank you Officer Dylayle and your security forces, I wasn't willing to leave Dryl unprotected, so they stayed behind to keep everyone safe! Anyway that's all, we're coming up on the main-gate now, have a good morning everyone!"

Dylayle dashed to the South balcony and glared out over the walls, where the cocky cat stood atop a Horde Skiff, arms crossed and tail all too relaxed as she looked up at the gate and bellowed.

"Open up, your princess has returned!"

Those mismatched eyes then turned from the gate as it slowly began to glide open and met Dylayle's own, that smirking visage burnt itself into the elf's mind.

"Damn you."

Dylayle's hand crashed against the railing with a violent clang as the procession of stolen Skiffs and hooting pirates rolled into Dryl as though they were a parade!

“We’re going to have to deal with that one,” Mused Stanely.

For once, Dylayle was in unquestioning agreement with the foreman.

Something must be done if Dryl was to remain, orderly, safe and in good hands.

Their hands.

Entrapta looked up from her work with a cheek hurting-ly wide smile on her face at the images displayed all across her monitors.

On every screen was a different sign of people celebrating, socializing and enjoying themselves. It made for fascinating research and had been, well, nice!

‘In small doses,’ she thought, remembering how eventually the partying atmosphere had gotten a bit overwhelming, but she’d taken the time to record and study before leaving. To see how mercenaries and Dryl folk interacted; Catra, her ever loyal research partner always close at hand.

It had been a day since they returned but the crews were still “Enjoying Dryl’s hospitality” as Catra put it and while the party had ended, new security camera footage showed the streets were bustling in ways she rarely observed… When she did observe Dryl at least.

‘There’s always so much to do in the lab after all!’ she thought, grinning down at her work, wire, metal plates and more strewn out before her as she went over the coding on her portable computer.

At that thought the doors whooshed open and Catra strutted in.

“Enjoying yourself?”

“Oh yes!” She enthused, rubbing her hands and hair bands together and grinning.

Catra spun around and casually leaned against the monitors, half watching her, and half watching the screens, “That’s good, the people seemed happy as well when I checked.” She chuckled, “Which is a pretty weird sentiment given where I’m from, but I can adapt,” she shrugged.

Turning her full attention to Entrapta she said, “I hope you didn’t mind my little request?”

“Not at all, I mean I wanna take apart the tanks and Skiffs and computers and tasers and cannons and-”

“I get you,” Catra cut in.

“-But working on four bots one after the other let me try out different ideas on improvements for each one!”

Clapping her gloved hands, Entrapta lifted herself into the air with her twin tails and motions grandly to the four bots whose eyes flared up as they rose to their prongs.

“Let me introduce you to Emily!” She patted Emily, “her sister, Em-C1!” she stroked that bots head, “Sandra!” that one didn’t like to be petted so she just gave them a smile and it beeped contentedly, “and their sister SA-T1!” Whom she gave a big hug!

Catra blinked, eyes wide for a moment before she waved, “Nice to meet them all,” her usual smirk back in place as she pushed herself from the monitors and began to inspect them, each bot watching her curiously.

“I’m glad it worked out, this was important after all. Even ignoring how good it is to have some bots on your side, we need to show that this trip was not just good for a bit of catharsis against everyone’s least favorite faction.” At their shared confused head tilt, Catra looked up and clarified, “The Horde,” before continuing. “But that this can also benefit Dryl.”

Catra ran a finger over Em-C1, much to Entrapta's delight '*she noticed!*' and added, "Maybe we should have them redone in Dryl's colors after a while, if they want a paint job," she quickly amended.

"Oooh good idea, you guys would look great in greys and purples, I promise!"

A chorus of curious beeps and boops followed as Catra padded around them and began toying with her hair, "Anyway, you can tell me all about the upgrades over lunch."

At that the doors whooshed open again and Fizzy Pop rolled in a cart of food with a grin on his face.

"Shall we?" Catra half bowed.

Entrapta could only answer with a giddy grin.

'*Everything is perfect!*'

Stanley sat at the head of his ornate dining table, hands clasped and an easy smile on his face, there were four guards, one for each corner looking alert and wary.

Officer Dylayle leaned over the table one hand resting on its richly adorned surface as she glared at the long hallway before them.

They didn't hear the cat coming before she appeared before them, slinking in like a shadow, half crouched eyes alight with curiosity.

"Hey~" she said disinterestedly, ignoring or missing his motion for her to take a seat in favor of marveling at one of the many shiny trinkets he scattered around the dining hall.

"Welcome, Catra, I am pleased you heeded our call," he gestured to the sole chair before him, "please, take a seat."

She did not, purring as she flicked a crystal wind chime, “You guys invited me over and Princess Entrapta said it would be rude to refuse, so I came.”

Dylayle’s hand pressed against the table so hard it began to creak, “You would have had to come regardless of manners, we called on you, now sit down.”

The cat merely hummed.

“I thought only the princess got to boss me around, I am her research assistant after all and well,” she motioned to one of the guards whose hands rested on his fire blade. “All these armed guards surrounding me makes me, hehe, twitchy you might say.”

“They will not harm you, kill you or even restrain you even if we order them do, Catra, there is no need to fear us. We aren’t the Horde after all.”

No reaction, she merely rolled her shoulders and then leapt through the air like a blur.

Blades were almost drawn but she simply slammed right down in the center of the chair, squatting with her arms resting on her legs as she bobbed up and down.

“Soooo what did ya need?”

“Well we just wanted to congratulate you on your recent accomplishment!” he enthused. .

“Yes,” Dylayle practically seethed, before pushing herself up into a military stance. “Doing the damage you did to a Horde base is impressive, it shows a great deal of knowledge of their operations.”

The feline‘s ears twitched and she rocked back and forth idly, “What can I say, as a scavenger I find myself in all sorts of places in time to observe all sorts of things!” Her cheery voice not even wavering.

Dylayle growled and Stanley signed, “Catra, you must understand, we care for Entrapta-”

“*Princess*, Entrapta,” the cat cut in, cold and blunt.

Dylayle slapped the table and began to pace, “Entrapta is young and naive, you placed her in great danger with this stunt why if-”

The cat already looked bored, inspecting her retracted claws and cutting in, “Given she was never in any danger and came back safe I don’t see your point. But you can bring it up with your princess, as she is the one to give you marching orders after all.”

“Marching orders, a strange phrase,” Dylayle murmured, even as her brow knitted together and her fists clenched so tightly Stanely was sure he could hear knuckles crack.

At the officer's remark the cat's ears dipped and Stanley grinned, “You see Catra, Fizzy Pop came to us with a very interesting story. One about where you come from, where you really, come from.”

“So you know I was an orphan raised to fight for the Horde that was marked for execution after trying to sabotage their war effort and barely escaped huh?” Her words tumbled out but there had clearly been some rehearsing, Stanley thought.

“Something like that, you can see why we are concerned for Entrapta’s safety,” he said gently.

“Princess, Entrapta,” Catra half growled.

“Mind your tongue, Hordling,” Dylayle spat.

“I betrayed the Horde, never even saw active combat and trashed a Horde base for you, if you want to put me on trial for where I was born fine!”

“Don’t tempt me, you-!”

“Now, now,” Stanley waved, enjoying his role as ever in being the gentler of their tag team. “There’s no need for that. I think that we can all come to an… understanding, Catra.”

Gesturing to Dylayle he continued, “You see, the Officer and I, well darn, we’ve been looking after Entrapta,” he ignored the cat's chiding. “Since she was a child, offering her wisdom and guidance and thanks to us, Dryl has flourished under her reign.”

Dylayle cut in, firm and resolute, “But the princess is a child, naive and prone to taking risks. We cannot allow this, her inventions have ensured Dryl's security and helped us achieve a level of economic prosperity and safety nearly unmatched by other Kingdoms. Her traps, the machines we sell, the mining equipment…”

Staneley picked up where she left off, “It all serves Dyl and its people, as do we. You clearly have garnered great influence of Entrapta, in your short time here, Catra. I believe that we can work together, and if not-”

“You can be removed, one way or the other,” Dylayle finished.

“So Princess Entrapts is just your puppet,” she said, a wicked smirk upon her fanged face, “You use her trust to control the kingdom in her name, how.. Scummy.”

Stanley frowned as Dylayle snapped, “She is a child, as are you, and if you won’t accept our rules here then this meeting is done!”

From within cupboards Malitheis and Dhashi and their first mates revealed themselves, the bulky, scarred fish man stepping up behind Catra to settle the score.

“Really,” Stanley mused, “trusting mercenaries, how stupid can you be?”

Malitheis roared as he moved to grab her.

Catra hissed, launching herself from the chair and flipping herself over his head.

The traitor's second moved to attack only for Dhashi’s monstrous little pets to hurl themselves from her shoulders, attacking the first mate.

“What!?”

Catra howled with laughter as she kicked off the wall and drove both knees into the stunned fish man’s face!

Malitheis lurched back and Catra landed on the table, grasped his head and yanked it down until she heard him cry out in pain as the chair shattered and he fell to the ground.

The guards drew their blades and charged, Catra felt the heat from Dylayle’s blade before it struck and ducked low, driving her feet into her and Stanley’s chests, launching them back

Dhashi and her first mate drew their taser maces and squared off with a guard each, the remaining two moved on Catra as Stanley fled out the back door.

Launching herself off the table with only her arms Catra barely avoided the twin blades that slashed through the wood. Twirling around Dylayle’s strike she blurred behind the woman and dragged her claws between the armor drawing a screech of anger.

The officer lashed out and barely missed one of her subordinates and Catra used their stunned instant to kick herself off the wall. A sharp claw tipped side kick across the face and the first guard crashed against the table and went limp.

Dylayle and her remaining soldier charged her as Catra rolled out of the way before pushed off the wall and skirting around them, another slash across Dylayle‘s side as she went.

“Savage little brat!”

Catra just bared her fangs as they charged her.

‘Clumping together, you idiots.’

Each soldier brought their blades down in a high swing that curved around her as if to trap her or drive her back.

Catra dashed forward, driving her claws into Dylayle’s side, her arm freezing mid strike as pain and torn nerves drew her short. Catra snagged the other soldier's arm and dragged them into a headbutt, their heads crashed together and she yanked him behind her, sending him sprawling to the floor.

Dylayle tried to pull back and drag the sword along Catra’s side but it was too late, sweeping the blue elf’s leg out from under her, Catra caught the officer halfway through her fall by the arm.

Dylayle’s eyes widened as she realized too late to act as Catra tugged on her armored arm and drove her foot into the bluenette’s side until she heard the shoulder pop.

She let loose Dylayle as the soldier howled in agony, crashing against the wall, unarmed and cradling a now limp arm.

“Thanks for the assistance, you’ll get more than what they promised,” she said to Dhashi and her first mate, who both smirked as they stood over their defeated guards.

Dylayle spat, pushed herself up against the wall, “You betrayed me, after I promised you double!?”

Dhashi shrugged, “Long term contracts for a proven employer and the chance of a commission seemed like a better deal.”

Dylayle’s eyes were twitching as they zeroed in on Catra who merely strutted around the second guard she’d wounded as he tried to push himself off the floor.

“Don’t look at me like that, no one died, I’m merciful after all,” she couldn’t help but roll her eyes at that as she ripped off the

soldier's helmet and dragged the satyr up in front of her by the horns.

“Now how about you stand down and no one else needs to get hurt,” her claws extended and began to press into his shivering neck as he looked at his commander.

“You’ll pay for this when the rest of my soldiers get here!” With that she turned and bolted out the back door.

Dhashi drew her taser but Catra just snapped, “No.”

Dropping the satyr she strutted towards the same exit, “keep the guards here, don’t kill them, I’ll be back later.”

“You better hold to your end of the deal.”

“Relax,” she chuckled, her words coming to echo around her as she moved deeper into the hall.

“I’ve already proven my word is better than theirs, so you and your crew have nothing to worry about.

Stanley had found his escape cut short.

Six eyes looked upon him, four glowing a toxic, angry green and the final set a familiar crimson pair that he had come to know well but that had never looked at him like… that!

“Princess… I, your companion she is-”

Entrapta’s voice was low and soft as she said, “Please be quiet,” before pulling out a strange unfamiliar badge and pressing it.

Stanley nearly choked as his own voice was repeated back to him.

“You clearly have garnered great influence of Entrapta, in your short time here, Catra. I believe that we can work together-”

“I heard everything, Catra said she had reason to be afraid of you… it seems her theory was correct.”

“Princess, I-”

A few strands of hair came up to Entrapta’s eyes and wiped away stray tears as she shook her head.

“I trusted you, since I was a little kid I trusted you. I thought you were helping me look after Dryl! I thought,” her words caught in her throat, “I thought you were my friend.”

Falling to his knees he crawled forward, “Princess, I am, I was always loyal to you, looking out for you, your interests, your very future. No one cares as much as I!”

Entrapta did not waver, the frown on her face remained firm as she shook her head.

Dylayle staggered out the door and began to let out a yell, only for one of the battle droids to jump forward and knocking her to the floor before retreating to Entrapta’s side.

The cat strutted out of his home and simply folded her arms, leaning against a nearby wall and glaring down at them.

“Princess, this Hor-”

“I heard everything officer Dylayle.”

Dylayle’s teeth gnashed as she glared at the cat then back to the princess, seething as she spoke.

“Everything I did, I did for Dryl. You wouldn’t understand, a child like you could never understand!”

“She does not speak for me princess, I was always loyal to what I thought was best for you!”

Entraptsa's gloved hands were gripped so tightly the material itself looked ready to snap as her words came out bereft of any energy or heat but simply dull and empty.

"If you had actually cared, if you had actually been loyal, you would have tried to make me understand, not run Dryl in secret and never tell me what was going on." Entrapta blinked away a tear, "You wouldn't have tried to kill my friend. You two only cared about me because it let you control things."

"Princess that's not-"

"Enough!"

Stanley lurched back, he'd never heard her yell before!

She sucked in a breath, looking to the Horde agent who merely continued to glare down at them, utterly impassive.

For a moment Entrapta looked lost, uncertain and terrified as her hair coiled itself into knots, the bots pressed up against her as she looked for guidance but found none from anyone she might listen to.

Finally, through clenched teeth she made her decision.

"Leave."

"Pardon?"

"What!?"

"I said leave," she pointed towards his house, ruby eyes set in a hard glare as she snapped. "Take your things, take anyone who wants to go with you and take your severance package, then leave Dryl. I can't trust you anymore, so… You're banished."

A stunned silence hung in the air before she turned away from them, patting one of the battle droids. "Escort them to their residence and ensure they leave peacefully and safely." she

instructed, stroking another one of the battle droids as she passed, each one beeping in response to her command.

"Princess we-" Stanlaey started

"Damn you," Dylayle howled, staggering to her feet. "See how long this city stands without me to protect it and some Horde animal within our walls!"

The feline just chuckled as she inspected her bloody claws. "I've done more damage to the Horde in one week than you have in your entire pathetic career, and I'm just getting started."

Dylayle snarled, lurching forward only to be stopped by one of the battle droids getting between them.

The cat simply began to tut, "Ah, ah, ah, I don't want to have to humiliate you again and Princess Entrapta said you were to leave unharmed, so go on, get."

The droids began to nudge the former Security Captain away from the feline and another was prodding Stanley as if to make him get up.

Meanwhile Entrapta marched away, only slowing for a moment when Catra reached her, wrapping a single arm over her shoulder as they made their way back to the palace.

Stanley slowly, numbly rose to his feet and stumbled back into his ornate home, a battle droids at his back and glowering pirates lounging in the foyer.

Entrapta's arms were hurting as she rested her chin on them and looked over the city of Dryl from one of her palaces balconies. Her hair hung limply at her side, and everything felt so… wrong, she had no other word for it as she watched tiny figures at the gates.

She barely even felt it when Catra patted her shoulder, before leaning against the railing herself and placing a fizzy drink next to

Entrapta's face.

"More people are leaving than I thought," Entrapta mumbled, struggling to lift her head to take a limp sip from the straw.

"Its to be expected I suppose, people can be real cowards," she growled, "Latching onto the familiar, onto authority figures who can act strong but have nothing else. People reject what they don't understand or the people who disrupt what they think is stable or," she scoffed, "Normal."

"Is Dryl even a kingdom anymore?"

Catra stared at her before slowly blinking and pushing off the balcony to stand at her side.

"Dryl is your kingdom now, for the first time in your life," she affirmed, pulling Entrapta from the railing and resting a padded hand on each arm. "Those people down there, they don't matter. If they aren't loyal to you then they don't deserve you, not your land not your protection and not your affection."

Brushing her hair back, Catra continued, "You deserve people who'll stick with you no matter what and not try to mess with your head to keep you under control."

"Can I trust anyone though… Can I trust you?" Entrapta didn't know anymore. People had always been confusing and sometimes fascinating but this just made her want to go curl up with her robots and never have to worry about people ever again.

Catra just huffed, "Have I ever lied to you?"

"Well No, but I wouldn't know if you did but… You always prove everything you claim… Everything," she murmured. "I'm sorry Catra I'm just-"

Entrapta froze as Catra's tail trailed along her eye wiping away a tear.

“This is your first betrayal, it hurts, trust me I know, it hurts. But just like ripping something sharp out of your body or cracking bones back into place it is better this way.” She turned Entrapta towards the city again where Stanley’s caravan was preparing to leave; Dylayle having vanished with more than half the guards and their families on the first night.

“Those people leaving, they aren’t everyone, and with you in charge Dryl is only going to get better. You still have people, mines, technology and soldiers,” she smirked and toyed with a lock of hair, “You still have me princess, and I promise I’m not going anywhere.”

For the first time in twenty four hours, Entrapta smiled.

Then she threw herself at Catra, arms and hair encircling the suddenly stiff feline in a hug, “Thank you,” she whispered.

“Its.. Its fine, Entrapta, everything’s going to be fine,” Catra said slowly, as her body relaxed if only a little in her hold but not entirely until she had pulled away.

“Sorry should I have not-”

“Its fine,” Catra waved, her confident smirk in place. “Now come on,” she pointed into the chambers behind them. “Dhashi and I made sure to collect all the boring paperwork and records those stooges had. Let’s figure out how to run this city over lunch and then we can do something fun like test out those cannons we stole!”

“OK, let’s get started!”

Entrapta raced back into the office chambers with a spark of energy and enthusiasm, her hair scooping up the drink and another tendril grasping Catra’s hand as she went.

Behind her, Catra smiled.

Chapter End Notes

Hi there, thanks as always to Roman Around for editing, due to real life constraints they couldn't spend as much time on the chapter as normal but I tried to fill in the blanks :D

This is the chapter it has all been building up to, I got inspired as to some of this from suggestions on SV, and have tinkered with them to varying degrees with the hopes of striking the right balance between 'canny Catra who schemes her way to the top' without spilling over into 'toxic fake friend' territory.

The idea for permanent contracts for the mercs was something someone else gave me, as I'd originally just intended Catra to offer double, but I feel this works well as I set Catra up as suspecting some sort of foul play.

Suffice to say, as noted, this turn of events with Entrapta the sole ruler of Dryl and Catra at her side is what I have been going for the entire time. I even got art commissioned regarding some of this which I hope to share soon. I have a general idea of where I want to go next and a few scenes and political developments planned out but I lack the connective tissue for it that I had here, so I am unsure how things will go forward at this stage.

As always, feedback, questions and reviews are most welcome!

Chapter 7 Heroes and Treachery

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer and Bow have grown up watching their world shrink as the Evil Horde spreads its evil across the world, and now it seems the kingdom of invention and minerals has fallen to the march of conquest.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Brightmoon was a glorious, towering palace fortress; protected by the resplendent runestone that made the land around it shine and sparkle with an ethereal beauty. The woods surrounding Brightmoon were considered the loveliest in all the land, for just this reason.

Beneath the looming tower of Brightmoon castle and scattered across the winding mountain and hills, were tents and houses, for Angella's ever shifting army of soldiers, scouts and raiders. They also doubled as a refugee camp for those fleeing the Horde until they could be resettled to other towns and fortresses.

A faint rainbow hovered over the great flowing lake that sparkled beneath the the mid morning sky.

'*Angella certainly knows how to surround herself with beautiful things*,' Stanley mused.

His cheek resting in the palm of his hand as he lazily looked out the window of his mechanized carriage, a gift from Entrapta and one she had allowed him to leave with. His assistant sat across from him furiously going over their notes and plans for ensuring their success in Brightmoon.

"Relax, the details are set and the rest is in the works, we have already informed her of our coming via messenger so…" He trailed

off as several familiar colors and armor sets caught his eye.

`*What are they doing here!?*'

Scattered throughout the camp were two platoons of Dryl loyalists, those very same soldiers that left with Dylayle, resting in a camp bedecked in greys and purples of their native country with a banner representing Dryl flapping freely in the weak winds.

"Foreman Stanley!" a rough authoritative voice called, forcing him to poke his head out of the carriage window. The sight of a lavender haired woman in armor with dark skin and a scar running across the bridge of her nose greeted him.

"I am General Grey, her majesty has heard your message and shall receive you in the royal court, please follow me!"

Before he could do more than say `*yes*' she turned and marched away, already too far away for him to try and converse with her to gauge the queen's mood.

Fingers tapping against the wall, Stanley seethed, `*Dammit it all, Dylayle. Why are you here!? What did you say!?*'

"Wait, please listen!" The girl cried, trails of sparkles following in her wake as she teleported in front of Dylayle.

"Move aside, I have done all I can, here."

Dylayle tried to avoid just shoving the sparkling annoyance away, instead side-stepping and racing forward as fast as she reasonably could as the girl and her little friend pursued her.

"Please, if you just stay awhile, I'm sure the queen-"

"I said leave me be you brats!" She snarled over her shoulder, watching them recoil in shock she continued her march out the gates as an all too familiar carriage approached.

"We're trying to help you and Dryl, there's no need to yell!" The princess snapped.

"You children can't do anything to help us and your queen has already made her decision, I'm done here."

Teleporting to her side again the pink haired menace whispered, "But what if we helped you, just us?"

The carriage rolled by and Dylayle turned to glare at the children in full.

"A child princess with nothing but magic to her name and a boy with a dime a dozen weapon, will not win back Dryl from the Horde. Leave war fighting to the adults."

"We've seen active combat!" They snapped.

Lips thinning, Dylayle bit back, "Then your queen is an irresponsible fool."

"You take that ba- ack, let me go Bow!"

"You can't punch her!" he cried, trying to keep the small woman back as she kicked and thrashed.

"Just watch me!"

Shaking her head, Dylayle turned and marched towards her camp.

'*There's no need to stay here, onto the next kingdom*.'

Nothing had gone as Stanley hoped.

Dylayle had arrived and left before he'd even been presented to the queen.

Angella herself, regal and radiating power had looked down upon him from her throne with a critical and intense gaze. She had welcomed them, and offered refuge as he would confess to

hoping, but the queen had already known the details of Dryl. Forcing him to curtail his own telling to try and keep it in line with whatever he imagined Dylayle had said.

'*Not that I expected her to be charitable, but Dylayle does not have a way with words, dammit!*'

As it was, he could already see the wheels turning in her head, for while Angella led the 'Great Rebellion', she was militarily conservative in all things meaning-

"Mom!" The princess cried,only to still as the courts gaze and her stern mothers snapped to her.

"I- I mean, my queen. You can't be suggesting to just leave Dryl in Horde control can you? Um, your grace." she added with an awkward bow.

Failing to entirely repress a sigh, the queen rose from her throne, wings slowly unfurling, sending a subtle wave of light sparkling across the court. A show of divine strength to be sure and one that compelled attention and silence.

"Foreman, as promised you and your followers shall be offered refuge here within Brightmoon, as we do to all refugees, regardless of what conflict drove them from their homes."

Knowing when to try and curry favor, Stanley bowed, "Rumours of your grand generosity were not exaggerated, your grace."

Given the stern look he got, it seemed flattery was not his ally in this arena, a shame, he was so good at it too!

"As to Dryl…" She cast her gaze across the court. "I have every intention of treating this matter with the grave seriousness it warrants. However," she studiously ignored her daughter's growing huffing. "Such behaviour is atypical of the Horde and I see little reason for such a sudden shift in methodology."

"What's more, while there are many similarities in what I have been told, there are some notable discrepancies. That is not to say I do not trust, but I believe all information must be verified and assessed before any, reckless," she stressed, "action is to be taken."

Returning to her throne, "As matters stand, it is not unheard of for the Horde to have renegades thanks to ambition or foolishness. Furthermore, this could be a strategy to lure the rebellion and other territories into an internal conflict, to weaken us and I shall not wage war on another monarch, let alone based on words alone."

In a single grand gesture her voice boomed, "I shall be dispatching diplomats and scouts to observe Dryl, the mines and the forests. The truth, whatever it may be, shall not escape them and from there, we can better determine how to proceed."

'*Dammit all! Damn you Dylayle! Damn you all! Where did I mess up? Was I too simpering? Should I not have tried to play to her ambition or aggression?'*

Even as he thanked the queen and complimented her wisdom, he howled in the deepest recesses of his mind.

'I will not let it end like this, cast down into nothingness! But how do I fix this!?'

Ears twitched as the princess stomped her foot, shot her mother a glare, grabbed her archer-guard and vanished in an explosion of sparkles.

His gaze snapped to Queen Angella and he saw a brief flash of pain and discomfort on her refined visage, before her stern mask re-settled.

'A teleporting princess… Well, that just might work.'

A violent splash of sparkles tore through the air as Glimmer let out a shout, watching the blast crash and scatter against the walls of her room.

"So I take it you need to vent?" Bow asked, voice cracking ever so slightly.

Glimmer's head snapped towards him, brow arched in a half glare before she remembered Bow was not really someone who 'did' sarcasm like that.

Groaning she spun around, arms wide, cape flowing, "What I need is for my mom to take this war seriously! But even when the Horde is eating the Whispering Woods from the inside out, she does what!? What huh!?"

"Um… Observe the situation?" Bow ventured.

"She does practically nothing!" Glimmer through her arms in the air, another wave of magic exploding from her fingertips.

"By the time the guards get there and report back and we can rally our forces, the Horde will be dug in! We should be heading over there right now, not waiting!"

Running a hand through his hair Bow mumbled, "I get where you're coming from, I do. This is especially bad given Entrapta's palace is meant to be filled with all kinds of traps and experimental weapons," He didn't notice the brief grin and squeak as he added, "They're meant to be really cool."

Seeing Glimmer's brow twitching again her coughed and added, "But yeah, that means the longer the Horde has to set up there, the worse retaking it will be."

"Ugh, assuming we even try retaking it, mum has us playing defensive all the time save for some raids on patrols and even those are defensive, eventually there won't be anything left to defend!"

At that Bow could only shrug, as Glimmer found herself running out of steam, impotence and frustration warring to see which exhausted her anger first as her mind flashed with images of ruined villages and the stench of-

A knock rang out against her door.

"Princess, that foreman wishes to speak with you, shall we send him in?" a guard asked through the wooden frame.

"Uh, yes, send him in!"

With that the door slowly swung open and the brown bedecked elf, stepped inside, his red ponytail swaying as he bowed, "My apologies for the intrusion."

Glimmer frowned at the silver masked guards stood at the door, as Stanley looked over his shoulder, flushing nervously.

Waving her hand she said, "Thank you, can we have some privacy?"

"Princess we are obligated to guard you." They answered in unison, Glimmer was sure they practiced that.

Bow interspersed himself between them all and chuckled, "Hey, thanks guys, but I think if anything happens, we can take him."

The guards looked uniformly unimpressed, but did slowly withdraw.

Glimmer sighed, waving Stanley towards the balcony looking over the Whispering Woods. The sun was just beginning its descent as Stanlet looked across the glittering expanse and sighed.

"Brightmoon is truly a beautiful place, we are fortunate her majesty is allowing us to stay but…" he trailed off looking uncomfortable.

Bow placed a hand on the man's back and Glimmer his shoulder, the rich material of his suit almost on par with Glimmer's own wardrobe.

"You miss your real home," Bow said, a pained twinge accompanying his voice that made Glimmer want to ask Bow about his home even though she'd long decided to leave that ball in his court.

Stanley nodded, hands clasped, "I cannot help but think of it. I understand the queen's decision, she has so much to protect," his gaze shifted to Glimmer for a moment at that. "It is selfish of me to ask her to act so swiftly, but even still… Entrapta is like a daughter to me… Perhaps that was the problem…" his face looked haunted and gaunt, already pale skin sickly.

"Maybe we sheltered her too much, making it easy for the Horde agent to trick her? I can only imagine what she's going through right now and Dryl, the people?" A sharp choking sound escaped his throat.

"I'm sorry," he said, shaking his head, "I shouldn't be bothering you with this, it is out of our hands until Queen Angella has her reports."

"I'm sorry my mother isn't taking this more seriously," Glimmer sighed. Trying to inject some hope into her voice she added, "But I'm sure once she sees how serious the threat is, we'll move in hard and fast and no one is faster than me!" she said, pointing to herself and grinning as she teleported to the foreman's other side.

"Yeah Glimmer's great for getting out of hairy situations," bow cheered. Flicking one of his arrows, he added, "I'm more of a tech whizz, but that means when the time comes I will be able to help with Entrapta's traps, so we can get to her quickly."

Stanly's eyes were wide and for a moment, he looked hopeful and short of breath. "With those skills you two alone could

probably save her-" he clasped his own hand over his mouth before slowly pulling it away.

"Sorry, I shouldn't have let that thought runaway with me. But you're right, I thank you in advance for helping save our princess and our kingdom." He looked away, unsure for a moment, "Assuming she's still there in a few weeks time- ah, sorry, my mind is wandering to unpleasant places. Please ignore me and have a lovely night."

Bowing he said, "Thank you for your time, princess Glimmer, young master Bow." Before slowly striding away, shoulder hanging lower and steps growing more like a shuffle with each second.

Glimmer looked at Bow.

Bow looked back at her.

Both cast their gaze to where they knew Dryl lay and then down to the camp where Stanely's refugees were already setting up shop.

"Tonight?"

"Tonight."

Stanley half feigned a tired sigh, that became a wholly faked state of blubbering confusion as the princess and her friend both looked at him from, eyes wide.

"Shhh, we want to help," Bow said.

"What are you- You can't mean to invade Dryl alone? I can't let you no matter how much I wish it to be," he said hastily, keeping his voice low.

"We're not going to attack, we just need to get in and get the princess out right?" Glimmer reasoned, playing right into his hand by going for the saner option than the one he presented.

"Right," her friend added, "if we have Entrapta we can explain everything to her, and the Horde won't try very hard to hold onto Dryl without her there."

"Not when the entire Rebellion marches on their walls," the princess half cheered, fist pumping into the air.

"I… See," Eyes flickering from side to side, he ensured no guards had sneaked past his perimeter before brushing back his hair, letting an easy, relieved smile formed on his face.

"I really shouldn't be doing this, but if you can save my princess…" he trailed off, sliding around them and flicking open a chest and snatching up the collection of maps and notes Entrapta had given him for her palace.

"This is a map and a list of all the traps and codes in Entrapta's palace. I don't know how much will have changed in a week, but with your powers and your skill," he said, smiling at each of them. "I am sure you can make use of it. They will want to make Dryl an unassailable fortress before moving Entrapta back to the Frightzone and with a week already over since we were banished, they'll likely be nearing the end of the planning stage, and will have no reason to keep Entrapta there."

"Please," he said, clutching their arms, "Please bring her back to me safely?"

Each put a hand on his own and smiled with firm resolve, "Don't worry sir, we'll save the princess and be back before breakfast."

With that, Glimmer and Bow stepped away from him, the princess grabbed her friend and they were gone in a flash.

Once certain they were gone, Stanley smiled, a relieved sigh escaping his lips as he looked at the roof of his well made tent.

'Soon, I'll be back in my plush palace,' he thought.

Looking to the open chest with a grin he thought. 'Those schematics and instructions are months out of date. Recent enough that they'll get through the door, but not much else and given what that beast did to real soldiers…' He shrugged at the thought.

'*Whatever the case, I'd better get into character, perhaps her own child racing into 'Horde' hands after 'stealing' a map from me will compel Angella to action?*'

Rubbing his throat to warm up his vocals he went over his script once again, trying to pick a suitably theatrical cry of shock for the whole camp to hear.

"So do you think the foreboding clouds and harsh winds are because we're on a mountain, or maybe they just come with being conquered by the Horde?" Bow asked, casually vaulting over a large rock, shoes scraping on the rough, sandy mountain path as hey snuck closer and closer to Dryl.

Shivering, Glimmer breathed on her tingly, numb fingers, "I don't know Bow, and I don't care, I just wanna get somewhere where it's warm. Seriously, how are you so lively this early when it is this windy?" With that she teleported to his side tugged her cape around herself as the mountain winds struck against her skin.

Chuckling, Bow answered, "Probably because my heart rate is up thanks to actually walking and climbing ya know?"

Not having a retort Glimmer settled for mocking, mouthing silent words at her best friend and mother hen only to see him freeze.

"You OK?"

"Yeah I am, I just… I think…" Bow looked at the schematics and squinted.

Glimmer peeked over his shoulder, but found the array of lines scribbled notes more confusing than helpful.

“Yeah I think this is the place,” he pointed to the tower's crystal beacon and Glimmer followed his finger downwards. “We need to go right for the centre of that upper chamber. That should put it a little ways away from Entrapta’s room and give us time to scope things out… Though…” he hummed.

“Though?” Glimmer asked, squinting out at the washed out grey and purple city fort, dozens of lights still shone but compared to Brightmoon activity seemed muted at best.

“Well I don’t see any Horde banners or anything, though.. Is that a tank?” He fumbled with his spyglass as Glimmer answered.

“This was a stealth take-over Bow, I doubt they’re rolling out the banners just yet, not until they’re ready at least, which is what we’re here to stop.”

“I guess you’re-” He frowned, “Yeah that’s a tank, it looks active too, but its not… doing anything?”

“Think it’s getting ready to fire some kind of signal shot?” Glimmer wondered, seeking some telltale sign of smoke or fallen trees that signified a Horde army on the march.

“Maybe, could also just be an intimidation tactic to keep the people in line,” Bow said, his voice unusually rough.

“Grr, I wanna smash it,” Magic danced on her fingertips until she clenched her fist and whispered, “But we need to get the princess.”

Clapping her on the shoulder, Bow smiled, “Once we get Entrapta to safety, we’ll come back and save everyone else before the Horde even knows what hit-em. Heck, once we explain the situation to her she may help us right then and there, her bots are meant to be amazing!”

“Yeah, but if she didn’t listen to her own advisers..” Glimmer wondered, boots scuffing in the ground.

"That was a week ago, no way the Horde could keep up a nice act for that long."

A humor-less huff escaped Glimmer as she looked to the tower and began to calculate, "Yeah you're right. Now let's get in there and save the princess."

"Right behind ya."

A shimmering, sparkling aura washed over them and the world fell away in a flurry of flashing particles.

Soundless and subtle, Catra slipped through the vents and across the long pipes of her new residence, the tangy scents of experimental engines, welded metal and baking all mingling.

'*Damn bit better than the Frightzone*,' she mused, face scrunching up at the thought. Her tail lashed sharply, and she traced a single finger across the metal walls in the now familiar pattern of Adora's last message.

'*I should go make sure it's all right-*'

Catra froze as something new, and distant made her fur tingle and her ears twitch.

'*That didn't sound like one of Entrapta's experiments…*' Catra brought her former Horde badge up to her lips and pressed down on the pressure plate.

"Entrapta, you still working on the tank?"

There was a series of metal screeches and tangled tugs of wires on the other end before a panting Entrapta answered back.

"Yes I am, and it is going great! I think-"

"Real quick, is anyone scheduled to be here today beyond the cooks? This is important." Catra was already in the prowl, sliding

through air ducts and pawing her way across piped and the synthetic frameworks that held the high roofs and high tower together.

A series of beeps were her answer for a moment, before Entrapta hummed.

"No, I don't think so, Dhashi and her crew are still out patrolling the mines to reassure everyone and I see nothing else scheduled but… Huh, hey yeah there was a weird energy pulse about a minute ago and now there's two new heat signatures!"

Catra chuckled, chest rumbling as she purred, hearing the intruders trying to whisper about 'maps' and paintings some ways away.

"So I was right, someone's in our house with me."

"Want me to turn activate the Bot Brigade?"

"No, not yet, let's have a little fun with them first and see what they do. You wanted to test out some of your experimental upgrades right?"

She could hear Entrapta gasp excitedly at that and Catra smirked as she scarpered towards Entrapta's lab.

"You mean the-"

"Yep."

"Eeeeeeeeh, yes, a thousand times yes! I wanna see what those babies can do, make sure to record it all right Catra, I'll be coming in to watch soon!"

"Can't wait, princess," Catra purred as she dropped to the floor of Entrapta's lab and spied her prize.

"Can't wait."

“OK, so I guess the tower's been updated since these blueprints were made,” Bow squeaked, as he brushed soot from his shoes.

“Yeah, no kidding” Glimmer snapped, looking at the remnants of her burnt cape. “Who even builds a trap door into an incinerator anyway!?”

“I mean if we hadn’t fallen into it I’d think it was pretty cool, I bet it reduces the heating costs too!” Bow enthused before stilling, as faint vibrations on the ground reached his senses.

“Who cares about heating at a time like this!?” Glimmer argued, glowering at the remnants of their burnt guidelines, “Why do these stupid things have so many drink stains, hasn’t anyone here heard of a coaster!?”

“Your royal upbringing is showing,” Bow joked, as he pressed his back to Glimmer, staring down the sharply curved hallway only for the sensation to suddenly fade.

“You OK?” Glimmer asked, glancing over her shoulder at her taller friend.

“Yeah…” Bow trailed off, “I thought I felt something but I must have imagined it. Maybe it was an engine?”

“In this place, who can say,” Glimmer hummed, reaching to knock on a pipe before freezing and slowly drawing her hand back.

“Yeah, lets not touch anything we don’t know is safe.”

“Right,” Glimmer chuckled.

“Oh but nothing is safe here, not for you intruders,” a dulcet voice purred from the shadowed ceiling.

Instinct and training took over, Glimmer let loose a burst of light with a cry as Bow launched an arrow. Their strikes hurtled through the air sailing well passed the voice as the white shirt-ed,

grey pants wearing figure was already bouncing off the walls with a cackle.

“Hah, nice aim, guessing you two weren’t picked for your combat skills!” Neither noticed Catra’s eyes hanging on the net that Bow’s arrow had let loose as she dangled from the wall, claws embedded in the metal.

“You’re the Horde soldier!” Glimmer shouted, dual orbs of magic pulsating in each hand as Bow leveled an arrow at the feline.

Brown fur, red stripes, mismatched eyes, and wearing two dark metal arm-guards, the feline bared her fangs, tail lashing in the air.

“Am I?” she crooned.

“Yes!” Glimmer roared, launching the magical blasts through the air.

The feline back-flipped over the first, curbed around the second and Bow smirked as he launched his arrow the moment she was left in a free fall.

Only for his arrow to miss as she arched her back and swatted it from the air with her tailed sending the flash-bang arrow careening into a wall as she landed safely on a metal frame, hands on her hips and a smirk on her face.

“Gotta say, whether you two are assassins or thieves, you are really bad at your job; I should probably just leave you to the clean up crew!” With that she leapt over their next shots and vanished atop an air duct.

“Either side!” Glimmer hissed.

Bow shot one way down the hall and Glimmer the other, but a sudden rumbling roar struck their ears. The horde soldier’s ears twitched and she smirked as a monstrous mass of metal rounded the curved halls and barreled towards Bow.

With a scream, Glimmer blinked to Bow's side, grabbed his arm and teleported them passed the robot monstrosity that continued its path down the halls. As their gazes snapped to its retreating form they saw the multitudes of giant brushes attaches to its body.

'*Who builds cleaning robots that big!?*' Glimmer wanted to scream.

"Glimmer!"

The air rushed behind her, but before she could even look behind her pain exploded in her back and the air burst from her lungs as she was kicked to the floor with an '*oof*!'

Jumping back, Bow let loose an arrow, eyes wide as the Horde soldiers didn't even try to dodge. Instead she brought her left arm up and the arm-guard buzzed to life, forming a green shield over her upper body that scattered his trap jelly across the air.

Another arrow, another shield, this time on her right and shaped like a diamond, the pointed tip slashed through the air and sent his net to the floor as he smacked into a wall.

She launched at him with a roar, that turned into a screech as sparkles exploded in her face,

"Forget about me!?" Glimmer huffed.

Hands moving in a blur he let loose another binding arrow that finally struck true, sending the feline rolling to the floor, trapped within a binding net!

"We got her!" They cheered as one.

Only for a snarl to break their joy as the Horde Soldier tore through the mesh, fangs bared, back arched as if she was ready to pounce.

"Entrapta, I hope you got enough data on the shields, because I am done playing with these brats!"

The word ‘what’ was on their lips, but could not be spoken as the feline barreled forward, kicking off from the ground to dodge another arrow shot and flipping over a sparkling beam of magic.

They turned together, Bow bringing his weapon down on the feline and Glimmer unleashing a stream of vibrant flashes only for the shield to spring up between them and their target.

With a snarl the Horde soldier sent Bow’s bow careening from his hands and his vision flooded with familiar pink. He only heard a pained grunt before his eyes cleared to see the cat’s fist buried in Glimmer’s gut before she fell to the ground gagging.

“No!”

His fist lanced towards her face, only to be caught in an iron like grip, claws dug into his hand as she dragged his right arm to the side, sending him off balance and letting her catch his follow up strike with ease before she drove her knee into his gut.

With a violent shove she sent him back, then dragged him in again to crash their heads together. Metal helmet meeting flesh with a clang, Bow’s world became a blur before she launched him at a wall and he went sprawling to the ground.

Glimmer forced herself up with a shriek, magic exploding from her body like a flame.

The Horde soldier yowled as the light flood her eyes, but as Glimmer made to strike sharp claws slashed out on instinct, cutting across her chest.

She teleport to Bow’s side, but was distracted by a new sight, a purple haired, tan woman snatching up sparkles in test tubes, while held high by prehensile hair hands. She was the spitting image of the princess Stanley had described.

“Teleportation!? Fascinaaating.”

Glimer's brain and body froze up as sharp claws tangled in her hair and a snarl reached her ears.

"Never drop your guard, idiot," before her head crashed against the wall. Glimmer's entire world exploded into stinging pain as her vision blurred.

"You get some good info from this Entrapta?" The rough voiced soldier asked as Glimmer's body swayed.

"Hmm? Oh yes, I did, and these magic samples are fascinating too, I wonder if she'll tell me how it works?" Answered the perky princess.

"Doubtful given I just rattled her empty head," the Horde soldier chuckled before hurling Glimmer onto a groaning Bow with a thud.

"Anyway if that means I can be done with these two, I guess I can shove-em in the dungeons? Though keeping a teleporter will be a pain but I'm sure you love a challenge and we need to know who sent them. These aren't exactly Horde assassins but…"

"Actually, I think they're with the rebellion!"

'Horde assassins?' Glimmer's dizzy brain wondered as she tried to force herself up only to fail and flop back onto Bow who grasped her hand tightly.

"Huh, that would explain the incompetence and bright colors. I guess one or maybe both of those twits you fired decided to get their own back."

"Is that bad for us?"

"Hmm, maybe, maybe not, depends if these two are important maybe? Whatever, you said you weren't interested in rebelling and frankly, I don't want to waste our time and resources on people like this. I'll just knock-em out and dump them near whatever patrol I see."

"OK, but ask the pink one if she will tell you about her powers when she's more conscious, and ooh, do you think he'll mind if I borrow some arrows?"

"Go wild, princess, they're intruders after all, so everything of theirs is now yours," the feline chuckled as she squatted down at their side with a vicious smirk.

"Ooh good point there, oh and I meant to tell you, but the tank trials are going great!"

Glimmer clutched Bow tightly, trying to call on her magic, but after a night of teleporting to get to Brightmoon and that last flash she was tapped!

The feline hummed as she brought her hands up to strike, "Good to know, I can't wait for you to show me what you did."

With that, the world went black.

`*Dammit, crap, aaaaag*!' Catra's mind screamed at her as she piloted the Skiff deeper into the woods.

Entrapta's bots had picked up some heat signatures, lots of them, scattered in small groups all likely armed and spread out in what Catra could only interpret as a raiding pattern.

The two intruders who she now knew to be a freaking princess and some honor guard lay unconscious on the Skiff's deck, their wounds having been tended to.

`*OK, the isolated party should be right up- Yep there they go, scurrying away!*'

"I have your princess, you want her back, stop running!" She roared.

Some didn't stop, several did, those had heavier footfalls and smelled of metal and hard leather.

Gently lifting the princess and archer from the Skiff she let them softly flop to the grass, knowing she was being observed, before slowly guiding the Skiff away from the unconscious duo.

"These two trespassed on sovereign territory, Princess Entrapta's own home, seemingly on the words of a traitor to her crown." She wanted to groan at all the pomp and ceremony to all this.

"They were defeated, given medical care and," she waved dismissively, "should be fine. But let this be a warning. Princess Entrapta will not be handing her crown over to that foreman, or the traitorous guard captain and definitely not to the rebellion. Now come and get your wayward idiots and get out of our territory."

Turning her Skiff around she readied to leave, body low and ears twitching just in case, when a voice called out, "The queen won't forgive this." As several armed soldiers stepped out of the bushes and circled around the injured pair with swords and spears drawn.

Huffing, Catra answered, "My Princess won't either, now go home." And with that, she revved the engine and tore off into the woods, faint calls for the attack to be called off ringing in her ears.

'*Good, I didn't want to join their stupid little rebellion anyway.'*

Still her gut churned, with no rebellion to sell weapons to, and possibly being an enemy well… Dryl was only one small kingdom at the end of the day and now Catra had enemies on both sides of the woods.

'*We're gonna have to do something about that,*' she mused, on the ride back to Dryl.

"You tripped on your own ambition, foreman," Angella's words were cold, but shaking with a harsh tinge that spoke of her anger. Magic flooded the war room, her allies and her own guards glares becoming muted as they looked ready to edgy away from the monarch at any moment as she leaned over the crystal table.

Stanley fell to his knees and bowed low, “Your grace, I- I had nothing to do with it, I swear!”

“I allow you into my court, into my home and not only do you put my daughter in danger for your schemes, but even when found out, you have the gall to lie to me about it.”

“But, I-”

“You were seen with them before they left!”

The halls shook, her wings flared, something crashed against his body and Staneley was thrown back as though by a wave!

Angella glared down at the table, princess Spinnerella and Netossaa laying hands upon hers as her wings slowly furled.

“I could ask if you thought me ignorant or merely stupid when I am neither. I could ask what compelled such dangerous audacity, but your greed and ambition is clear as day. I could, but won’t ask if your feel remorse because I cannot trust a word you say.”

She looked at him, eyes that glittered like jewels seemed to pierce him, ripping the breath from his lungs.

“Princess Entrapta was right to banish you, and now I shall do the same. Your followers may remain but you are to never step foot in Brightmoon territory again.”

“I- My queen, I-”

“Remove him,” she instructed, turning away as her guards moved on him.

“Please Angella, I-”

A crackling net snapped around his mouth, “I think you’ve said enough,” Netossa cut in, as she and her wife followed Angella out of the chambers. Their forms growing more distant as he was

dragged from the chambers and with it, any chance he might have had at retaking Dryl.

'Is this how it ends?'

Glimmer awoke with a groan, everything tingled but nothing hurt which was… good, she guessed? She wasn't sure, her thoughts moved like cotton candy and didn't-

Her eyes shot open to the familiar sight of the Runestone and her mother standing at her side.

"Mom!"

She did not notice the small sigh of relief escaping Angella, as her mother kneeled down, half embracing the smaller woman.

"Don't rush, you're still healing-"

"Is Bow OK!? What happened at Dryl!? We, I, I'm- uurrg," The world swayed and soon enough she was leaning against her mother's side hoping the platforms would stop multiplying, her mother's hand running through her hair.

"Bow is fine, he's in the infirmary and already on the way up here, I just happen to have wings," Angella tried to smile, but Glimmer couldn't see it as she tried and failed to push herself up alone.

"Careful, you'll still be a bit delicate, but as to Dryl, its been shown that Stanley was a liar, the 'Horde Soldier' he mentioned delivered you and Bow back to our forces." Her words grew sharp and acidic, "After brutalizing the both of you."

"Yeah that… That fight sucked."

"Do you see why I caution you against racing into battle against the Horde, why I keep you from the front?" angella pressed, only to stall as she felt Glimmer growing tense and pulling away from

her and instantly regretting her words as the gap between them grew.

"I get it, we screwed up!"

Biting back a retort, Angella, ran a hand through her hair and spoke as gently as she could, "You were manipulated by a schemer and sent into an ambush, you'll be happy to know he's since been banished."

"What, but-"

"But nothing," Angella snapped. "He was the one who reported your disappearance to me only an hour after you and Bow had left, clearly thinking himself so clever," a frown marred her normally regal features. "I noticed your disappearance before he had even come to me and it wasn't hard to put together the timing, especially not with testimony from other refugees."

"I guess we weren't that subtle," Glimmer sighed.

Angella could only shrug at that, "What the case-"

"Glimmer!" Bow cried.

Glimmer's face brightened in an instance and with a flash she was gone and Angella could only sigh, wings drooping for but a moment before she took off and glided down to where her daughter and Bow were hugging out their reunion.

"If I might finish?" She cut in when they finally stopped apologizing and insisting the other shouldn't be apologizing.

"Uh, yes," Glimmer answered awkwardly, as Bow gave her a wobbly salute and a mumbled, "Sorry your majesty."

"It's fine Bow," Clasping her hands she sucked in a breath and spoke, calmly, resolutely and with practiced regality.

"It has become clear that while Dryl has not been conquered by the Horde they have taken on a rather brutal and aggressive advisor and seek to retain their isolationist policies. We will continue to observe them from a distance to monitor for any changes but for the time being will leave the princess and her new 'servant' to their own doing, for while their response went well beyond acceptable, they did have some justified pretense in acting defensively.

She held up a hand stilling the two youths words.

"Second, Stanley has been banished from Brightmoon. It has become clear that whatever Princess Entrapta's relationship is with this alleged Horde runaway might be, that she was well justified in removing the two of them from their positions."

Her gaze grew stern as the two looked ready to debate her and she stressed, "This is not up for debate, this matter will be handled by my agents from this point forward. As for the two of you, while I am relieved you are well, you broke ranks, snuck out of the palace and conspired to invade either another monarchs territory or to hurl yourselves 'alone' into a Horde stronghold. For this kind of reckless behaviour I am grounding the both of you for three weeks."

"But moooom!"

"No buts!"

"Can you technically ground me? Because I mean…" Bow trailed off at the sight of her glare.

"Bow, tell me. Who's queen?"

"You are your majesty."

" I hope that addresses your concerns, now let us get you both to the infirmary for another check up," her wings flared up as she ushered them back into the palace.

While all looks peaceful on the surface, the balance of power has begun to shift in Etheria and no one yet realizes it, least of all those most responsible.

Across the land and within the fortress city of Dryl, Entrapta and Catra lay sprawled out over desks, stacks of paper and data-pads cluttering their shared work-space, both looking frayed and frustrated.

Debts and trade deals, mines and farming, transport and security, diplomacy and sales to the Etherium Makers Community, let alone regular weapons trade. All of this and so much more needed to be balanced, calculated and manages and with it came paperwork, came calculations, came bureaucracy.

As the pair looked across the mounting workload, they were of one mind when they announced.

"I hate paperwork!"

Chapter End Notes

> I have wanted to put that "Catra & Entrapta fail at bureaucracy" scene in for like three chapters XD Anyway, as always I would like to thank Roman Around for being a serious champion and editing this chapter, as well as BF110C4 for giving me the idea for this chapter and finally all of you for taking the time to read it!
>
> I consider this chapter something of an interlude, closing moment for the story designed to set up a time skip, finally finish introducing some, up to this point ignored, major players and establish a nominal status quo that can be expanded going forward, while also cleaning out some lingering issues like Stanley and Dylayle. Also this chapter serves as a good reminder Catra can be less than diplomatic at time and Entrapta loves her science regardless of consequences! Haha XD

Also Catra's line about someone in their house was a loose reference to the Bartok movie. With the new season coming up I am unsure I'll be able to get another chapter out in time, but I guess we'll see.

Anyway, thanks again for reading, any thoughts, feedback, questions or critique are most welcome.

The Siege of Salineas

Chapter Summary

> Grappling with an escalating war with the Horde, dwindling funds, population and few potential allies, Entrapta and Catra must act quickly if Dryl is to survive.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The quiet hum of the skiff was nearly drowned out by the grinding of Catra's fangs, as Emily scuffed the steel deck with her prongs unwilling to try and 'talk', or spin and play.

Their mood shifted suddenly though, as Emily beeped and whined at the sight of the palace.

As she skidded to a halt, the feline inwardly growled at the sight awaiting her. Dhashi on one side and 'Quill' on the other. One of the former Foreman's assistants who'd remained behind at one of the mines and had been press ganged into the role of 'Grand Secretary' or whatever title they'd pulled out of a hat for the bespeckled satyr.

Paws and metal slapped against synthetic rock as she and Emily hurled themselves from the Skiff and marched towards the doors that opened at Catra flicking her hand over one of the silver gauntlets running up her forearm.

"Ah, Advisor Catra-" Quill started, robes ruffling as they hastened to catch up with her.

"Commander Catra-" Dhashi started.

"Both of you, walk with me," She snapped, tugging at her new thick white turtleneck, another reminder of her new station -or

stations- as well as of the fact that as someone with fur she did not get nearly as cold as other mountain dwellers.

Dhashi gave off a wet, sickly laugh and the spiked, purple woman leaned in and said, “Take it your work in Plumeria went belly up then? Such a surprise with your charming personality.”

“Bah, I could have been the nicest idiot on the planet and those freaks would still refuse to trade with us. They don’t fight, Dhashi, they don’t even defend themselves. Have you ever heard anything so stupid!?”

“Landlubbers are a strangle lot,” she shrugged.

“Well actually, most people don’t like fighting if they can avoid it, the Horde is the exception not the rule-”

“Yeah and look where that got everyone outside the Horde,” Catra countered, before hissing in annoyance. “Not the worst of it though, oh no. They have this ridiculous story carved into a tree that says some magical warrior,” she wavered her arms dramatically at the thought. “Is going to come back and make everybody play nice with them. Idiots.”

“No argument here, but still we need to discuss a-”

“Catra!” Entrapta cheered as the doors to her chamber opened. The purple princess’s hair extremities were all over the lab as she hung herself before the many monitors before spinning and hurling herself towards Catra.

Catra braced herself as Entrapta sped towards her and let the princess envelop her in a hug, while the princess used her hair to pat Emily before the bot raced off to join her siblings.

“So, how’d things go?” She asked cheerily, pulling away and lazily swaying her way around the room.

“Waste of time,” Catra huffed, “How about you, the Etherium Makers Community any use?”

Entrapta stilled and Catra wanted to groan as the princess turned around, head down and prodded her fingers together.

“Uh, I mean, we sold a few things buuuuut.” She looked helplessly to Quill who bowed and cut in.

“Most did not want to trade with us, suspicion of uh-”

“Me. Carry on.”

“You,” he nodded, “and concern about us holding back the best inventions apparently played a part in them being rather, inhospitable to our efforts.”

“Excuses, excuses,” Catra grumbled.

“Yeah they probably just want to force Dryl into a submissive trading position,” Dhashi said, dropping down onto a nearby couch and patting her little sea monsters’ heads as they loafed on her lap.

“How rude,” Entrapta answered absently, as Catra pawed her forehead.

“Quill, send me the most recent treasury sheet,” she instructed, and with a few taps of their data-pad she felt her arm buzz. With a flick, she brought up a hologram of numbers and figures streamlined into something not horribly hard to read for her convenience.

“You still have enough to pay my crew and I right?” Dhashi called.

“That depends on whether you’re still doing your job,” Catra snipped.

Hearing Dhashi snort and Quill shuffle back as though expecting a fight when the fish woman’s pets started hissing, which even caught Entrapta and the bot’s attention Catra sighed.

“You said you had a report for us, right?”

“Not much to say, some refugees came through from a little way outside Dryl towards Brightmoon but it seems like it was just one of those roving kill-squads and not a concentrated march. That or it got repelled by these weird forests.”

“Wait,” Catra bristled and marched to the console before freezing and looking at Entrapta. “Mind if I bring up a map?”

A relieved sigh escaped the princess and she nodded.

With a quick flick and a click, a map of the Whispering Woods, in so much as there could be a map, was displayed on the screen and with it, glowing colored outlines indicating territory.

“Just as I thought, Brightmoon’s territory isn’t anywhere near ours, why aren’t they travelling to their own kingdom's capital?”

The room was silent for a moment before Dhashi chuckled, “I forget you’re not from these parts.”

“Explain it then,” Catra huffed, leaning against the console and glaring back at the fish woman.

“Not much to say,” the captain shrugged. “The war's been going on so long lots of royals have lost their territory or full on up and died and left their villages behind. Most of them fall under Rebellion control by proxy cos no one else is looking out for them when they have their own to worry about. I mean, I’m pretty sure Seaworthy used to be owned by some royal bint but who knows anymore, or cares.”

The gears in Catra’s head were turning, and then everything fell into place.

“I have the solution to all our problems.”

All eyes turned to her and she just smirked.

“We’re going to take over the world.”

Catra was inordinately amused by hearing Dhashi put out and whining as the taller woman trailed behind her.

"Can I do anything else besides seek out Seahawk? Please."

“No and no,” Catra answered jauntily, “You know the ports and crews well enough to assess things, just remember what we discussed and focus on the princess, then report back. The Horde will go for Salineas by habit soon enough and I want to know how well they’re holding out, and if they’d be interested in some heavy ordinance.”

What followed was a tired gurgling hiss as the pirate captain marched away with her orders.

‘Now that that’s handled,’ Catra mused only to catch a familiar scent on the air.

“Entrapta?”

“You got me so early!” she called from some far away vent.

“Well I do have good senses,” Catra answered, surprised that the instinct for some quippy rejoinder didn’t even occur to her as she waited for the princess to thump and bump her way through the vents and out of the grating.

Plopping out on her hair in front of her, Entrapta’s eyes glowed like gemstones as she leaned in grinning excitedly.

“Let me guess, First One’s tech?” She asked.

“Yes! That is correct! Good deductive reasoning!”

“I do my best,” Catra hummed.

Spiraling around, Entrapta waved a Data-pad before her and Catra’s well trained eyes followed it despite the swaying as Entrapta, too excited to really talk, let worlds just overflow.

“So, I’ve been trying to triangulate some First One Signals in my spare time, but they can be so finicky and self-scrambling! Grrr,” she thrashed around for a moment, teeth grit before continuing. “But the bots have been so good for this, cos of those spy drones you suggested I make, and they’ve been able to just take recordings of everything and thanks to them I’ve located a First One Ruin!”

“Great,” Catra answered, “But with no signal, doesn’t that mean its empty?”

“Maybe, possibly but even then, it may have maps and other information, or its could just be hiding the signal, or the machines could be off and so not signaling, the possibilities are, well, I mean, not endless, but there’s lots!” She froze up and then leaned forward, “So uh could…”

“Yes, I’ll investigate it on the way there, or back and bring you something nice," she gently cupped Entrapta’s cheek and fluttered her eyes, “Sound good princess?”

Entrapta swallowed and smiled, “Yeah, uh, that sounds great!” she cheered, blurring forward to hug her before shooting into the air and back into the vents with faintly flushed cheeks.

No stray thoughts filled Catra’s mind as she watched her go.

Not until she caught the reflection of her white top in some glass and found her head flooding with images of her and Adora in their bed together.

Only Catra heard glass shatter.

The town hall was brightly lit with candles and strange glowing mushrooms that cast everything in a faint, pink light. It was all round edges and doughy clay, with vines growing up walls and a horrendous number of beads.

Dozens of ‘elders’ and townsfolk were scattered around on worn pillows and stools, watching Catra as she circled her ‘foe’ in this ‘arena’ at the center of the hall.

Her foe, some bunny ears fop, spoke, gesturing grandly as he did so, blue robes flowing.

“This outsider does not offer aid freely my kin, she comes with schemes and deals, weapons and people who know how to fight. They stink of blood I say, is this what we want for our children? To see us taking aid from thugs who have no regard for royalty or sovereignty. We cannot welcome such dangers into our home, cannot insult our dear princess Peeka-Blue like this!”

Lowering his arms, he ran a hand over his ears, seemingly pleased with himself.

Catra just tisked, “Nice of you to avoid any details while you were making stuff up, is this what passes for debate? Shameful.” Not that she disapproved but lying was so… weak.

With a wave of her hand she simply said, “You all know what my offer is, so I see no reason to be dramatic about it or try and trick you. Either you ignore that pride and loyalty won’t keep you safe when the Horde advance or you take up my offer of a three lazer sentry and pay rent on it with food. Either way this offer remains open if you reject it, but I have stuff to do, so make it snappy, aye?”

And with that she made it look as though she was making to leave, only to freeze when someone shouted, “Wait!”

Catra held back a smirk.

“Honestly,” Catra hummed, spinning here Data-Pad on a claw, “it went better than expected.”

She caught the device in her hand and lazily snapped a picture of some weird engravings showing lines leading out from the ground

and air into rock or something before pushing further into the underground chamber.

"So, they all agreed?" Dhashi asked from the other side of her Data-Pad.

Catra hummed as she mulled around the dark halls, unperturbed even as guards closer to the entrance whine about the dark and tried to set up lights. Honestly, she'd be done before they even got in at this rate; with that thought she snapped another picture, this time of an empty Data-Crystal holster on the wall that the weird First One's script flowed into.

"Not as many as we hoped but more than expected, once the prospect of safety starts walking out the door, people tend to make snap decisions. If we can extend this to some more villages, we'll have a free source of food coming in for minimal work. That should address our most major concern, though I'm sure Quill will talk my ear off about some competitive market crap."

Another flick of the claw another picture, this time of a 'mural' of many light beans going into a person who vaguely resembled a much more ornate version of the wood scratching's Perfuma had showed her.

"Well I'm glad one of us has good news, cos I think you sent me to a sinking ship and I'd rather bail out now thanks," Dhashi responded.

That… drew Catra up short. All she had heard about Salineas painted it as a stubbornly defensive and powerful kingdom that had withstood dozens of Horde attacks, always frustrating Shadow Weaver and leading to her… moods.

Catra forced her bristling fur to stand down and unclenched her jaw and answered, "Care to explain that?"

Dhashi made some spitting noise that Catra knew was the fish person equivalent of a huff.

“Not much to say, the cities population is shrinking by the day as people pick up and move inland to escape the oncoming Horde.”

“What is there some big troop movement I haven’t heard about?” Catra scoffed. The Horde was many things, but subtle was not one of them.

“Nothing major, though they’re apparently expecting a raid any day, they’re like clockwork apparently.”

That did line up with what Catra had guessed based on years of angry ranting and screeching.

“So, then what’s changed? You said no one ever got passed the gate.”

Dhashi sucked in a wet breath and answered, “The gates' getting weaker apparently, they have no idea why, but a few more months and the whole thing's expected to fall.”

That drew a faint growl from Catra; she had needed Salineas! Notoriously unfriendly to outsiders and on the frontlines of the war but not affiliated with the rebellion it would have make an ideal ally to garner some legitimacy and fill their coffers. But if that was the case…

“Wait then why don’t they just repair it? Can’t be that hard if they built the stupid thing.”

“They don’t know how, its some ancient First One’s magic-tech crap. Its just always been here and under the control of the royal family, but according to Seahawk in a ‘Tragedy beyond measure’,” the fish woman gagged. “The gate's been getting weaker every year even before Mermista took the throne. Apparently, they hoped changing heads of state would fix it somehow cos of Runestones or whatever, I don’t know magic is weird.”

“These Runestones, those are the things the princesses use to juice up their magic, right?” She vaguely recalled some chatter

along those lines from when the Brightmoon Princess and her toady popped by.

Catra could practically hear Dhashi shrug, "I guess? Though when I mentioned the charge up thing, Mermista apparently found it hilarious a princess needed to charge her magic, so I don't know. Can I leave yet? I've had to listen to three of Seahwk's shanties before the princess kicked him out for the night."

"Stay there for now, if the Seagate is falling, we may be able to-"

She had to stop herself from saying "pressure them into working for us" because she had no idea who might be listening and so instead said.

"To help them defend their kingdom, but if not… Hey you said their gate was old First One's tech, right?"

Catra's brows furrowed as she began to flick through recent pictures, watching intently as images flashed of swirling energies, she guessed were magic flowed out, or maybe into a stone and-

"Yeah what's that got to do with it?"

"Book a meeting with the princess, Entrapta and me, if what you said about the gate and attack is true then it's time to change tracks."

"Uh, sure thing, I mean yes Commodore," Dhashi answered before hanging up.

Catra wasted no time in dialing the next number and was greeted with an excited, familiar keen of "Hiii Catra!"

"Hey Entrapta," Catra purred, "Tell me, how'd you like to get a firsthand look at functional First One's tech, save a city and secure us some allies all in one?"

Entrapta's exciting squeal filled the chamber before she cried, "I can do all that!?"

Catra just smirked, “If we play this right, yes, I’m gonna send you some carvings, and I recommend going over all your notes and left over tech, if all goes well, we’ll be in Salineas by week’s end and you can tinker all you like~”

“You’re the best Catra, this is the best, yes I’ll get started right away!”

“Good luck,” she whispered, hitting send on the Data-Pad, listening to Entrapta’s excited chatter as she made her way towards the exit with a smile so faint, she didn’t even notice it.

The quiet hum of the Skiff beneath Catra’s paws was matched in volume but not in tone by Entrapta’s own cheerful little hum. The princess was sprawled out atop the machines deck mulling over notes on a Data-Pad, that was normal, unusually she was wearing a flowing suit and pants in Dryl’s greys, pinks and purples that looked very nice.

It had been a suggestion from Quill, and one Catra agreed with given they were trying to present themselves officially. She’d even gotten her turtleneck fully adorned with some shoulder-plates and now bore a sash. However, unlike her, Entrapta had brought her overalls along and was wearing her usual white shirt beneath her jacket, just one of the one’s without an oil stain.

Salt air tickled her nose and she grumbled, ‘I hate water.’

“Hey Entrapta, we’ll be arriving soon.”

“Oh, I should go over my notes then, right?” She asked, already flicking through the Data-Pad.

“Probably a good idea,” Catra hummed, “Dhashi said her scouts reported a Horde Siege Ship was some ways away, plus some Skiffs. She’s not sure if they’re just in the area though but even if they don’t attack the threat of them will probably make the princess more open to what we want.”

“That’s nice,” Entrapta tapped the screen and began scrolling through text boxes, lips pursed cutely before she groaned, “All this prim stuff can be fascinating to watch, but actually having to do it and not getting is baaaaad.”

Catra’s laugh surprised even herself, before she added, “I get you, really I do. But people love to dress up and strut around like they’re special, and a special set of rules for them is just another way to demonstrate that.”

“Oh, is that how it works?” Entrapta asked, casually taking notes, and leaving Catra suddenly unsure if her advice was even good.

“Uh, I mean, I think so at least. The less you need to fake around someone the more equal you are, the more honest,” her chest suddenly ached, only to flutter when she felt Entrapta rest her head on her arm.

They stood like that for a time, in silence, and Catra’s foul mood faded, she glanced down at Entrapta and purred, drawing a blush from the princess who began to chatter.

“So, uh the First One ruins you explored were great, a lot of interesting lore for me to go over there, thanks!”

“It wasn’t exactly hard without any guardian robots this time.”

Entrapta just groaned, “I know, how much does that suck?! I mean more lore is great and we might find some more tech, but I need more data crystals.”

Catra was caught off guard when Entrapta hummed thoughtfully though, hair hands tapping at her chin as a regular hand tapped at her cheek. “Though ya know, if we wanted, we could maybe build a research station around some of these ruins, maybe build settlements on top of them or even in them once we have all we need.”

“I think we’d need more people for that, princess.”

“We could take in refugees like Brightmoon does, you said they have looooads of people, right?”

“Huh, that idea does have potential and we can dip into two separate budgets to fund it too, ugh Quill, always making things complicated.”

“I think that’s their job,” Entrapta said without guile.

“Yeah you’re right and- oh, here we are,” She hummed, as the ocean came into view upon the pale rocky shore and with it the city of Salineas. A rising city of elegant woven pearl towers that spiraled into the air in soft domes, that shone with a rainbow hue in the waves that gently crashed against the shore.

“I was told Salineas is the most beautiful city in the world,” Entrapta whispered, leaning forward, a wide grin on her face as the wind ruffled her hair and she glanced back at Catra as if reminding her to look.

But Catra was having trouble dragging her gaze from Entrapta as she mumbled, “Yeah… beautiful.”

“So, these are the people you two have been talking up?” Princess Mermista asked with a faintly disbelieving scoff.

Catra’s hackles were up, claws flexing as Dhashi looked unsure what to say and Entrapta was too busy staring intently at a mural within Memrista’s circular throne room to care.

Seahawk however did find his voice, assuming he could even lose it.

“Indeed, they are my dear Mermista!” Sliding forward he slipped between them and clapped his hands upon their shoulders. “This is the fierce Catra and the brilliant Entrapta!”

Entrapta seemed indifferent to his presence, while Catra slapped his hands away faster than he could blink.

Not missing a bit, he brought his fist up high and bellowed, "Together along with a band of rowdy raiders we sallied forth across the scorching deserts, danger at every turn and-"

Mermista's hand shot forward and quelled Seahawk to silence as she pinched the bridge of her nose.

"I know, Seahawk, you've told that story at every formal event since I let you back in."

"And each time the audience is riveted," he chuckled, puffing out his chest.

Mermista groaned at that, "I knoooooww…. But we've heard it, or lived it, so can we just focus on," she waved her hand "Whatever this is… What's the purple princess doing?"

Catra's eyes flickered to Entrapta and noticed she'd pulled out a Data-Pad, images of notes and pictures flashed across the screen as she mumbled to herself.

"She's working," Catra scoffed, "And you know why we're here."

"I know why your pirate said you were here, not whether or not you could actually do it, or if I trusted you to mess around with the Sea Gate or dump a bunch of death machines on my doorstep."

"Weeellllll," Entrapta intoned, sounding only like she was half listening as she paced and skipped around the chamber in wide, exaggerated steps. "We could do both, or neither, or just one based on everything Catra and I have said to each other."

Gloved hand over her heart she grinned, hair ripping like the waves, "I personally want to fix your Sea Gate, a fully preserved First One's Artifacts is too precious to lose." She leaned towards Mermista, strands steadily angling for her trident, "First One's artifacts like your staff could be a source of unparalleled data!"

Slapping her hand hands away, Mermista turned to Catra and said, “OK, I’m gonna speak to you, over the geek.”

Catra bared her fangs just a little but was met with a bored yawn; turning to Entrapta and saying, “Maybe we shouldn’t rush taking apart their sacred artifact. Even if it’s to save their city from the Horde; after all, we aren’t the one’s on a timer here.”

Entrapta nodded and shuffled back to her side, “I suppose, it's so exciting though, right? And it helps everyone so it’s the right move, I think.”

Mermista just huffed, cutting off Seahawk, “I call kelp crap, you two wouldn’t be here if you didn’t need something you’re struggling to get elsewhere.”

Catra shrugged, while Entrapta answered, “Well I do want to study the Sea Gate, and your fish halls would be good for us, plus Catra said your Sea Gate keeps the Horde landlocked, which is good for us, so yeah, helping you helps us but we can work something out without you, this is just easier and nicer.”

That seemed to stop Mermista short for a moment as she blinked before folding her arms, “Blunt, aren’t you?”

“That’s what I’m told,” Entrapta chirped, lazily making another grab for the trident and being casually waved off.

Catra used the chance to cut in, “Everything Princess Entrapta said is true, helping you helps us, but we aren’t in any hurry. We chose to come to you sooner rather than later.” She forced every drop of false earnestness she could into her words.

It didn’t seem to find much purchase with the princess, who just groaned and ambled towards her throne. “You can take a look at the Pearl and Sea Gate but-”

She was cut off by a loud cheer from Entrapta that itself was cut off as she smacked her trident to the floor.

“But,” she stressed, “I’ll have some people watching and if the Sea Gate falls… Well, the Horde will attack and then everybody dies, so… Yeah… Whatever.”

“Fear not my dear Mermsita for if the Horde attacks, I alone shall be enough to scare them to the other side of the sea!” Seahawk boomed before plopping himself down at the side of her throne.

“Sure, if you say so,” She waved to her staff, “Can you bring us some snacks.”

“At once princess!”

“Ooh will they be small?”

“Most food here is,” Mermista answered, drawing a squeal of delight from Entrapta.

“They have tiny food!”

Catra smirked, “Can’t wait to try it. Need help unloading your equipment first though?”

“Oh yes!” Entrapta answered.

“Great, Dhashi, Emily, get on it, we’re on a snack break!”

A sigh of both annoyance and relief escaped Dhashi, at finally being liberated from Seahawk, while Emily beep booped and spun its way down the halls.

“When uh… When did C2 start doing that?” Catra whispered.

“Oh, she likes how smooth the floors are here,” Entrapta answered.

“Aah.”

What ensued was hours of work and brief snack breaks.

Catra kept a close eye on Entrapta and everything surrounding her as she took scans, notes and fiddled with what she was allowed to touch before going back to her various machines. There were already several small engines or transistors being cobbled together, including from parts of their own Skiff, which didn't bode well if they needed to leave in a hurry.

'Still, what are the chances they'll attack today?' She thought, casting her gaze over the throne room and passed Mermista as the princess lounged on her throne, only half watching Entrapta.

'This place is worse than Dryl,' She thought with a grunt. Few guards, no generals or lesser leaders, not even an assassin or spy in sight or scent and the salt couldn't hide such from Catra's senses. There was just no one, no schemers, no plots, no backstabbing. Even for a city with a dwindling population this was absurd to her, and yet here it seemed to be, a chamber of power without a hint of skullduggery.

'Which begs the question…'

"So, where's your courtiers or whatever, and the other hangers on I keep hearing princesses have?"

Mermista just shrugged, "Gone I guess." Her gaze sharpened as she added, "But who knows where?"

Catra just offered a lazy roll of her neck, purring as she answered, "I was just thinking, if they are gone, and we empower the gate and they come running back. Well, you'd be the princess who stayed, and if you had our cannons, well… You could definitely make use of that."

"You aren't as subtle as you think you are." Mermista countered.

Catra chuckled, "Was I trying to be, though?"

"I think I have it!" Entrapta cheer, leaping to her feet and then lifting herself into the air by her hair and crossing her legs as she turned around to grin at the rest of the room's occupants.

The room fell into silence long enough that she worried she'd said the wrong thing or interrupted something, but Catra was the first to come back, eyes only on her and her work as she purred. "So, what have you found out?"

"OK, OK, so see, I've been theorizing for a while about the nature and origins of magic and how it intersects with First One's tech!" She held up her Data-Pad and started flicking through notes and images.

"I have reason to believe that the First One's drew magic from the planet through their technology, and I am now thinking that the Runestones might by like, engines, I suppose. They gather and super charge the energy I think!"

Mermista spoke next with a lazy wave, "Uh, so you're saying all magic is just like the Horde's tech?"

"Oh no, no, no!" Entrapta chanted, head shaking so fast the world blurred. "I mean, kind of but not quite, I mean magic and science are kind of the same disciplines if you look at it the right way but magic as an energy source and how its tapped into is radically different from Horde tech, but!" she added, dropping down and patting Emily on the head, "They can be retro-fitted together, because once something reaches a sufficient level of advancement well," she waved her arms looking for words. "They're, they're just kind of the same!"

Several uncomprehending gazes met her, before her words wholly sunk in and Mermista leaned forward on her throne.

"OK, so does that mean you can fix the Sea Gate?"

"Maybe, possibly, it is definitely within the realms of probability and slightly higher than the toast landing butter side up. I checked," she added in a mumbled aside to Catra who just nodded.

Entrapta trailed around the throne room and continued.

“See I think the Sea Gate has been running on, I guess, back up and ambient power, but its connection to you or the pearl, or maybe the outside world is degrading because of the attacks. It can’t recoup its energies fast enough to remain stable, probably a lack of maintenance, because it wasn’t designed to just passively recharge it needs an external power source.”

“So, should I plug my yachts engine in it, the staff ooorrr?” Mermista drolled.

“That!” Entrapta froze. “I am less sure of. But I think I can rig together a power convertor, I’ve already mixed First One’ Crystals that passively recharge with my own bots and with Horde bots, so I know its possible but it may take some time and I can’t be distracted-“

“PRINCESS!”

Entrapta groaned, Catra’s claws flexed and Mermista looked very, very tired.

“What?” she snapped, as Seahawk threw himself to his feet, hand on his fire-sabers hilt.

The guards stumbled over their words, “The Horde, a whole battle force! Our scouts reported three Siege Ships and a hundred support Skiffs sailing on our position right now!”

Mermista stilled as she clenched her trident tightly.

“Princess if they lay siege…”

“We’re all dead.” She answered, before turning to her and Catra. “So, what are you two gonna do?”

“Uuuhh…” Entrapta looked to Catra who refused to speak, she always did this when an important decision came up, she said it was to show she wasn’t trying to control her. But decision making like this could either be really easy or really hard and who knew

what response would end in problems, Entrapta wasn't used to planning that far ahead but…

"I can try and juice up the Sea Gate, but it might flicker or not hold out anyway."

Catra hummed, "If they're sending that kind of force, they must be getting desperate, probably my fault for trashing so many of their bases, they want to open up a new port offensive. If you don't have an admiral, I can take them out for you."

"Really?" Mermista answered, clicking her finger "Like that?"

"Well," Catra purred, "It might take a few minutes, and I'll need Seahawk."

That left the room quiet again, save Seahawk who was squealing with excitement.

Mermista looked to her, then Catra, then Seahawk and sighed, "Fine, let's try this. Not like any of my commanders stuck around anyway when they could be off skulking in their swamp fortresses."

Throwing herself to her feet she slammed her trident against the floor making Entrapta tense and lurch away, before Catra shuffled up near her.

"Get the ships, all of them and the wall guards, have some take up positions in the towers though in case the Horde break through." Her head snapped to Catra and the two exchanged sharp nods before she added, "Marshal at the dock, and provided her plan isn't too stupid, follow it."

Catra patted her shoulder and purred, "Good luck," before signaling for Dhashi and Seahawk to follow her out the window as she hurled herself towards the docks.

"Fight well!" Entrapta called after her.

‘Three Siege Ships, fifteen Skiffs each side for speed and covering fire, all laid out in one row after the other.’ It was a weird line to her, but it didn’t take long to figure it out even over the sound of chaos surrounding her at the docks.

‘They must be worried about running out of power or getting worn down, they’ll swap their forward force out for the second, then the third, while each one behind takes a break to recharge. Good a way as any to lay siege to a place with a central point for its defense I suppose.’ But it was predictable, typical Horde thinking really, attack, attack, attack, and thus it was something Catra could handle.

She dropped the spy glass with a smirk which faded instantly as she bothered to take in her blue tinged surroundings.

The docks were filled with mewling and shouting, nervousness and wounded pride, coming together in a confusing mass of garbled words and mis-matched orders and complaints.

Catra had never been known for her patience, nor for hiding her displeasure.

Throwing her head back and sucking in a breath until her chest swelled so much it felt ready to crack, she snapped forward, fangs and claws bared, roaring.

“ENOUGH!”

It did, at least, bring silence, as dozens of scale armored soldiers all turned to glare at her with some mix of anger and trepidation.

Catra didn’t give them the chance to think, as her tone flicked to one of pure business.

“All right, your princess has given me temporary charge here so this is what will happen. You will stop whining, get in order and array your ships in a triangle formation!”

Claw snapping to Dhashi she added, “Dhashi’s vessel is the strongest so she’d up front as vanguard. Your people on the walls will lay down suppressing fire on the Skiffs and only the Skiffs once they’re in range.”

She turned to Mermista watching over them with a bored expression but sharp, focused eyes. “Your princess will lower the Sea Gate at my signal to let your vessels loose on the enemy. Tear right through them. Divide their attack force and make it impossible for them to isolate you!”

She slapped Seahwk’s shoulder and said, “Seahawk you’re with me on my Skiff, we’re out before the gate lowers, I want you to land us on the closest Siege Ship and try to crash the Skiff into the middle Siege ship. Can you do that?”

“Hah! Can I!? You’re talking to the captain who-”

“Got it.” She cut in, shoving him towards the Skiff.

“Uh general, what’s the signal?” Dhashi called.

“Trust me, you’ll know it when you see it,” Catra answered, leaping onto the idling Skiff.

“And if we don’t!?” One particularly offended sailor shouted.

“Then I’ll finish the battle myself!” She cackled back with a confidence she did not quite feel.

Seahawk took up the controls and locked his feet into place. Catra’s claws cut into the metal and she said, “Aim us up so we jump the Sea Gate, Mermista will open a hole for us; rev up, and hit the pink switch when they come into range,” they were here. “Now!”

“Now?”

“NOW!”

The engine screamed, gravity hung heavy on her spine as the ship angled back and the wind crashed against her like a flurry of blows as the world blurred out of sight and they burst into the sky.

It was strange how speed and the sudden howling wind growing so loud if leaves one deaf can make the world almost slow down.

For as they went into a spiral so fast Catra could barely make out the world, nor hear sound she could discern, all that ran through her head was.

‘Oh right. I hate the ocean.’

Then she felt, or more sensed the ship stilling for just an instant, upside down and still in the air and she kicked off, the world bleeding back into the view as the Skiff tore through the air behind them and plasma blasts soared well over them as the dark green ship and its crew quickly approached.

The air behind her was rocked with an explosion Catra could only half see, but her Skiff was left hurling shrapnel into the sky as the explosion tried and failed to catch them.

“Crap!?” She howled, clanging against the Siege Ship's steering bay, sending vibrations across the tortured steel that rang out like a gong, quickly followed by Seahawk’s own landing.

Tasers charged but Catra didn’t wait. Blurring forward she headbutted the nearest soldier off the captain’s nest and flipped over the next shot.

Seahawk’s sword blazed to life and he cut through a blaster and decked the squeaking soldier with a cheer.

“Take the lower deck!” she ordered.

“Righty-o!” and he jumped into the air and skidded down the railing, jumping off and kicking the nearest soldier in the head while they tried to process his actions.

Catra was hardly idle, weaving around twin shots from either side, she made sure the soldiers had to aim carefully or hit each other, and once she closed in, she lashed out. Claws screeching across steel and a fist impacting against the visor with a crackle of glass that left the soldier screaming and staggering back, holding his face.

A blast shot rang out and she weaved below it, her foe flinging himself over the railing to avoid the blast before she charged at the driver's last guard.

Only for the air to rush, as a faintly familiar roar hit hear ears. Metal rang out as four tentacles wrapped around the metal railing and hoisted the one and only Force Captain Octavia into the air with such force that when she came hurtling down, she dented the floor Catra had barely escaped by her scruff.

A sick rasp broke her lips, before she froze and smirked, “How lucky, I thought Shadow Weaver put you down, but now I can.”

Catra drew herself up, smiled and chipperly asked, “Hey Octavia. How’s the eye?”

In a flash Octavia’s smirk vanished and her tendrils were launched at Catra with a roar as they flared around her smaller frame to trap and encircle.

Catra knew this trick, had fallen for it before thinking claws and fangs would save her.

She’d learnt since them.

Catra kicked off the floor and barreled straight at Octavia.

Squawking, the Force Captain drew back and tried to slam her tentacles together. Only for Catra to jump, spinning over them and hitting the floor with a twirl.

Octavia spun to try and catch her with tendrils or arms and Catra jumped over the strike and delivered a sharp kick to the warrior’s

head with a crack!

Catra hit the floor and ducked below the retaliatory swing and flashed up to clap her hands on either side of Octavia's head, temples and ear drums ringing with the strike that left the woman's eyes bulging!

Catra hurled herself back to avoid being crushed in her arms only to trip over the thrashing tendrils.

She managed to roll out of grappling range only to hear soldiers rallying on the deck, as Skiff riders began readying their taser batons.

'Not bloody likely!'

Catra rolled off the Captain's nest and onto the main deck. Weaving around a Skiff riders taser shot, she backhanded the nearest soldiers into the wall before dragging them in front of her to take the next shot, their armor barely saving them.

Octavia bellowed and leapt onto the deck, and Catra smirked at the way she moved, rolling out of the way and kicking off into a run, she was soon at the front of the ship where the cannon was.

"She's after the cannon!" Octavia roared, stomping after her.

Near the tail end of the vessel, Seahawk had taken up a defeated Horde soldier's shield to guard against skiff Rider fire, but still couldn't deny some relief when some of the soldiers advancing on him turned to race for the cannons.

With a bully cheer, he deflected a plasma blast at one of his attackers and caught another taser mace with his blade.

"Fool, you face Seahawk!" He cheered.

The forward Skiffs had started returning fire on the walls, but the Siege Ships were stuck holding fast, at least since Catra had decked the cannoneer and turned the deck into a brawl.

She danced on a knife's edge ducking and weaving around fist, shots and tentacles; getting as close to Octavia as she could or ensuring the Force Captain was in line of the shot to keep the soldiers off balance and leave the amphibian as weighed down by her own soldiers as Catra was by them!

More than a few burns scuffed her armor, clothes and even fur, but so far, her luck and speed were holding true.

She landed against the steel deck and bit back a hiss of pain. 'OK, not holding that well!'

The scent of blood was in the air and Octavia was snarling mad, cuts dancing seemingly at random across her thick flesh.

"Is that the best you can do cat!?" She barreled towards her and Catra found herself hopping backwards to stay out of reach.

"Better than you!" She taunted, only for a tendril to slap against her shoulder and sending her rolling to her back.

Dark blurs swarmed around her and Catra made a snap decision.

She rolled off the ship.

And as she drove her claws into the side of the ship, she flung her head back and let her crimson helmet fall into the sea with a loud splash.

The Skiffs couldn't report on her clinging to the side of the vessel, not while being under fire from pressurized water bullets.

So Octavtia was totally unsuspecting as she raced to the railing snarling her name, only for Catra to tear at the steel and fling herself upwards like a blur.

Paws and claws grasping the steel railing she flung her head forward and felt it ring as a crack filled the air and she nearly tumbled into the sea for real!

Octavia staggered back though and Catra shook it off just a little faster.

'Not the worst blow to the head I've ever had,' even if she struggled to remember much from those times.

Vaulting off the railing, taser shots soaring around her, Catra snagged the railing for the captain's nest and heard a "no!" from down below. Before swiping out with her legs and delivering a mighty kick to the steering wheel and cackling as the ship heaved and careened left to the right.

Soldiers fell to the ground, Octavia and Catra being the only ones to keep their footing, as she cackled madly, and watched as soldiers shouted in shock, Skiffs we scuttled or scattered and even the driver toppled over the nests edge.

Just as the wheel began to slow its spin she flipped off and slapped down in front of the cannon, Octacia's furious roar not stilling her for even a second as she slammed down on the auto-fire.

Catra could hear the other ship's crew screaming as they dashed off deck, and Octavia barreled towards her.

Catra pivoted and crashed against her, bones screaming from the impact as they both snapped back in shock, and the blast was let loose, tearing into the other Siege Ship and obliterating the captain's nest, while cleaving off the top half of its phaser cannon.

Octavia stood numbly as jagged burning metal rain from the sky, and Catra's ears twitched. She turned just in time to see the Sea Gates drop and for her own forces to come spilling out.

Unfortunately, this meant she was unprepared for the rear ship to show some unexpected initiative and open fire. Her eyes began to sting as she saw the pulsing green bolt hurtling right towards the palace and-

"ENTRAPTA!"

Only for a blue tinged bolt of energy to explode from the castle, subsuming the phaser in a flash. Catra could almost hear Entrapta's gleeful cackle and sagged with relief.

And then she felt Octavia's tendrils wrap around her wrists and ankles, hoisting her into the air and crashing down on the metal so tightly her bones creaked!

"I'll kill you… I'll rip out your throat and then… I'll blitz the city!"

"Bored now." Catra flicked her wrists and ankles just right and hummed. Parameters met, her shield generators hummed to life and Octavia's tendrils were forced away with an ugly snap.

Hurtling down she drove her knees into Octavia's face with a crack that slammed the older woman into the floor and let Catra bounce off her chest to kick one of the remaining soldiers right off the vessel and into the increasingly chaotic sea before racing to the cannon.

"Seahawk, wheel!"

"I have it!" he howled, bruised and a bit bloody, he snatched up the wheel and steadied the ship just in time, for Catra to charge up another shot.

"Haha, feel the wrath of Seahawk's Voracious Vagabonds!" he cheered.

"We don't have a team name," she called back, as the shot was fired, shaking the ship with its thunderous passage before it blitzed through its final counterpart, scattering melted steel to the seas.

The deck shook and thundered beneath her feet, and Catra's ears pressed to her head at the howling snarl that barreled towards her.

A half glance over her shoulder was all she needed to weave out of the way of Octavia's clumsy blow, her gnarled hands ripping

into the control panel and leaving the cannon sputtering as she stared at it with wide eyes.

“Oh no, that was your last one too,” Catra cooed, “Guess the invasions off-”

Octavia’s tentacles lashed out and Catra simply leaned out of their way, swaying aside again as Octavia raced to punch her and struck steel instead, gills spewing water, chest heaving as she sputtered.

“How… You… So fast!?”

Catra snorted, batting aside the tentacles as she stomped forward and, in a blur, buried her fist into Octavia’s kidney.

Blood spewed from her fanged maw and she collapsed to her knees, only for Catra to catch her chin and hoist her head up, making sure Octavia met her gaze as she spoke.

“I’ve always been fast, but this, isn’t that,” she dug her claws into scales, not even bothering to resist as Octacvia’s hands clasped her shoulders, shaking as she hissed.

“Did you think I was just slashing randomly? Really?” she scoffed, “No. Those hits were all to vital areas, and each blow to your skull was to rattle your empty head so you wouldn’t even feel the cuts.”

Octavia gaped, finally understanding as she tried to draw back but Catra pulled her closer.

“That’s right, I’ve been bleeding you out this entire fight. You’re dying on your feet, Octavia so tell me, Force Captain,” she asked with a hiss as Octavia’s eyes began to fade and flicker.

“How do you feel?”

Catra let Octavia fall to the floor with a thud as the last dregs of her strength vanished. Turning to the battlefield she was greeted

by Skiffs screaming out of sight burning vessels and cheering soldiers.

Her breaths were shaky, something like a purr and a growl rumbling in her chest as she began to chuckle and finally laugh.

"I won. I can win. Against all of them!" she threw her head back and roared with laughter, "I'm the strongest!"

Her cackle filled the air as the soldiers hooted and hollered their victory, only a slightly wide eyed Saehawk hearing her proclamation. But as the invasion fleet lay in ruins, the truth was clear for all to see, so that none could deny it.

She had won.

Shadow Weaver had known something was wrong the moment she hadn't received a report from Salineas.

But as she drifted towards the eternally electric humming doors of Hordak's domain, a familiar, bitter rage and dread caught in her throat.

'Isolated from my subordinates, summoned like a slave!' Her claws dug into the palm of her hands for but a moment, a brief crackle of crimson lightning running across her palm sealing the wounds before they could bleed, and she breathed.

'This is nothing. A minor obstacle that I can wipe away.' Even still, offence burned in her throat at the none too subtle reminder of her "place" beneath the 'leader' of the Horde who only concerned himself with the army when there was something to rage about.

The chamber doors hissed shut behind her, and Shadow Weaver drifted into the dark domain of Hordak. Thick wires and clear tubes pumping power and sickening concoctions all around her. The chamber hummed with an alien energy she had never been able to place but she knew came from a realm beyond Etheria.

Her eyes widened at the sight of his throne, only Hordak's vicious little imp lounging upon it looking mockingly down at her as it toyed with its tail. Another reminder of her place!

A shudder of anger flowed through her and stopped cold when the air shifted, and she heard metal clang against metal.

Eyes widening, they snapped to the side but saw nothing, only for a hissing breath to drift across her back.

"Shadow Weaver."

He strode by her, cape billowing, not even turning back and she knew better than not to follow in his wake, teeth grinding her tongue to bile at how her heart had jumped in terror for but a moment.

"You wanted to speak with me, Lord Hordak?" She plied, as gently as she could.

"Yes… I did," he murmured as if already bored with their conversation and looking to other matters. Refusing to face her, he instead strode up his throne, idling patting Imp's head as the creature cooed.

"Tell me, Shadow Weaver, what do you remember of your past ward, Catra, I believe it was?"

'What has that ingrate done!? I knew I should have sent my shadows after her. When I find her I will-'

"Focus," Hordak snapped, drawing Shadow Weaver from her cathartic reverie.

Quickly she answered, "I recall a Catra, one of many youths under my command, lazy, stupid and rebellious-"

Hordak turned, cape billowing as screens lit up all around her, as he seethed, "Rebellious… Yes, that much at least is true!"

His gnarled metal clad arms spread widely to show off the screens and Shadow Weaver found herself instinctively step back, just an inch as she tried to take it in, tried to comprehend the madness before her.

Catra was on every screen, in some she was barking and snarling orders that pirates and armored soldiers raced to obey.

In others she stood preening atop decimated Horde bases as soldiers ran for their lives and crowds cheered her name.

And worst of all, was her standing on the bow of a Siege Ship, cackling madly as she loomed over Force Captain Octavia with a pristine and unharmed Salineas looming behind her.

'That was her? It has been her all along!?'

"This is the result of your carelessness and incompetence, Shadow Weaver," the sanctum shook as his cold, dead voice reverberated across the metal, echoing even though he never spoke above a hateful rasp.

"My lord, I couldn't-"

"No excuse, Shadow Weaver. You will eliminate this threat now before it could rise to challenge my Horde, or all that you have, shall once again be mine," he looked to the monitors and huffed, "And perhaps be given to someone more worthy."

"You can't!"

Imp screeched and metal wailed as he dragged a single claw down his throne.

Shadow Weaver bowed, "Please forgive me my lord, I shall-"

"Go. Now, fix this or die in the attempt. I am done with you."

Shoulders shaking with unspent rage, the shadows inside her churning, demanding she lash out, consume and destroy and

yet…

She bowed low and whispered, "As you wish Lord Hordak."

'Catra, I will make you suffer for this indignity!'

Catra stood before the open oval windows of her guest chambers in Mermista's palace, idly toying with a medallion in the shape of a shell she'd been awarded while looking upon the rising sun.

Following their victory, things had been hectic. Capturing Skiffs, saving the Siege Ships and binding troops that couldn't make it out proved to be messy time-consuming work.

By the time she'd made it back to the city proper, Catra had been exhausted and her wounds were finally catching up to her. That hadn't stopped her from hugging Entrapta back and drinking in her scent, when the princess threw herself at Catra.

Nor had her lingering and half treated aches and pains stopped her from attending a banquet in their honor, and in honor of the new alliance between their kingdoms.

Catra had worn what she expected to become her new 'official' outfit. Purple grey boots that let her claws be bared, grey white pants, thick but light, metallic braces on her arms and ankles, with a light pink undershirt matching Entrapta's hair and a thick purple jacket with long coattails and a wide neck. Without her helmet, her mane was wild, but it had mattered little for the "hero of the day."

As Mermista's dignitaries, nobles, and wealthy folks flooded the city to join the celebration, she and Sea hawk had been the most honored, though all the soldiers were given rewards in a way Catra could tell was done to assure their loyalty.

'once the new cannons and remodeled Siege Ships arrive, those soldiers will be given command of them, even the novices, that's a good way to secure power,' Catra thought appreciatively.

Seahwaek for his part had spent the whole night hanging off Mermista's arm, telling grandiose, though be it only slightly exaggerated stories of his heroism, to an adoring audience.

Catra had done much the same only with less shouting and a lot more subtle prying question to assess the people she was speaking to.

Also, she's kept one arm wrapped around Entrapta's back the entire party, and her tail had coiled in and through her hair on instinct.

'Which is probably why we got the same room and only one bed,' Catra mused, turning from her reverie to look upon Entrapta. Lying on the bed, Data-Pad held over her face, the screens light shining down upon her.

Catra felt a tug, more than one, too many in too many different directions to say.

She knew where some were coming from but had no idea what to do with them. She couldn't even understand or identify others, and some part of her didn't want to, to understand those confused, coiling feelings inside her… She didn't want to. Didn't know what she wanted to do about any of it, her future, her plans, everything was in disarray and she'd been flying blindfolded this whole time!

She ached for Adora, and yet, when that blast had been hurtling towards Entrapta…

Catra growled, slapping down the medal and marching over to Entrapta who hummed.

"I think I have some new design schematics for a replacement helmet ready if you wanna see?'

Catra didn't know what to do about all the thoughts swirling in her head, but she knew this much.

She did not want to lose Entrapta.

And so she gently placed her hand on the Data-Pad and guided it to Entrapta’s lap.

“That’s great, I’d love to see it, but for a minute, can you look to me?” Her voice was gentle, oddly so, even to her.

Entrapta must have noticed because she perked up and rolled forward.

They were barely inches apart.

Catra placed a single hand on her cheek, cradling her face and watched as Entrapta blushed.

She leaned forward until their foreheads pressed together and the tips of their noses touched.

Their eyes remained focused on one another, unbroken, Entrapta’s breathing was growing more intense, or maybe that was Catara’s own, she wasn’t sure, she was flushing to though, she could feel it.

She let the familiar tension roll out of her body and slowly, so slowly, closed her eyes.

Chapter End Notes

> Apologies this has taken so long, I've been working on other projects, plus study and I was grappling with how to get from point A, to B and so in in this chapter as I knew the general beats I wanted to hit but not the surrounding details. I hope I pulled it off though!
>
> Catra closing her eyes like that was actually inspired by real life cats who do it to show trust and love by making themselves vulnerable and I felt it worked well.

Also I took the suggested advice with Entrapta and Catra getting advisers to help them run things, Quill is sort of the face of their various bureaucrats, the current system is pretty ad-hock though, hence Catra's varying titles and the fluid command structure, also Catra's new outfit has finally be donned, she just needs the helmet and she's set!

I may have gotten the idea of Entrapta boosting the Sea Gate from the fic that initially inspired this idea I confess.

As always thanks to Roman Around for editing.

Anyway that's all I can think to say, sorry for being absent and as always feedback, questions or new ideas are always welcome!

EDIT:

Catra's new outfit was drawn by the amazing https://ko-fi.com/foxtrtter and can be found here:

https://twitter.com/foxtrtter/status/1158771388817256451

New link, due to the ic being lost to the Twitter-verse >< https://imgur.com/a/J04X5Ar

A Shadow over Dryl

Chapter Summary

> Warning:
> This chapter will have a section dealing with and showing abuse, in case that content may be triggering for an audience members I will mark the areas it starts and ends.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The forest was sparkly as usual, but a rather brighter shade of green and brown compared to the more common lavenders and pale ivy of the Whispering Woods.

At Catra's paws lay broken stonework, and crumbling, crystal constructions loomed overhead, shattered and weathered down to a nub compared to what might have once been.

Still, they had found some interesting loot in the basement.

Catra rolled her head, feeling her neck crack as she resisted the urge to yawn, "All right, let's get these last relics loaded up and move on out."

It would make a good spot for a settlement soon enough, strong foundations, or so the experts said. 'Maybe a fort?' Catra purred idly at the thought.

She glanced down at the tiny model Etheria, its moons and sun locked inside a glass ball they'd recovered from a well-preserved chest that, besides some dust, was remarkably well preserved.

Catra idly wobbled it in her hands and watched as the ball of light that was its sun split into dozens of little stars that slowly began to reform.

‘Cute.’

Steel rasped and hackles raised, Catra tossed the orb into the air, claws bared and fangs grit as she spun and fell into a fighting stance, tail lashing and-

Saw her soldiers looking at her very confusedly, not one even close enough to have tried to stab her.

“General?” One asked, even as others fell into combat stances, eyeing the ruins warily.

Catra’s glared at the soldiers around her, most were of Dryl’s security force, or Security Soldiers, as Catra called them. Inexperienced as they were, she’d wanted to drag them into the field more. But as she investigated the forest, ears twitching she heard nothing to note until the faint whistle of the falling model struck her ears.

Snatching it from the air in a quick spin she muttered, “Just keeping you on your toes, let's move.”

As she bordered her Skiff and heard EM-c2 beep nervously at her, Catra lazily patted the bot, unable to shake the feeling that someone was watching her.

‘It's just this wretched forest,’ she told herself.

If only she could believe it.

The purple steel doors opened with a hissing hum and Catra jauntily opened her arms as she stepped into Entrapta’s lab.

“Oh Entrapta, I’m home~” she sang, drawing an excited gasp from the princess, who tore herself away from the monitors instantly and blurred towards her.

“Catra, welcome back!” Entrapta cheered, arms and hair coiling around the feline’s muscular form. Pulling away she rubbed her

gloved hands together and grinned, “I saw the report you sent, the stuff you found looks really interesting!”

“It is,” She slipped behind Entrapta and chuckled, “But there was something I left out of the report.

Catra slipped her arm around Entrapta’s and held up the trapped Etheria model and shook it, enjoying how Entrapa’s eyes went wide when she gasped and marveled.

“That’s amazing, they must have magnetized the energized particles towards a specific spot and made them stack on each other to increase their shine the closer they are together!”

Catra purred and rested a hand on Entrapta’s hip, “I’m glad you like it. I think I’ll give you the real one too,” she whispered into her princesses ear drawing a blush from her Entrapta.

“I think I’ll give you the lands, the moon and star,” Catra continued, holding the orb before Entrapta’s sparkling eyes. “It’ll all be ours, how does that sound? Ours to shake up,” she shook the orb, “Shake down, and rule as we please. Every one of Etheria’s secrets will be yours and mine alone.”

Catra had found herself entranced by her own words and the strange feeling and images of a future she had never imagined possible flickering before her, her Entrapta and-

“That’s very sweet Catra,” Entrapta said, taking the relic and nuzzling her cheek, “But I really don’t need all that, I like what we have here and now!”

Now Catra was blushing, fur standing on end before she slicked it down and chuckled, “Me too.”

“Then come on, I wanna show you my most recent work before I start looking into the presents you brought me.”

“Sure, but I have training with the security scrubs in half an hour and if I’m late-“

“The entire chain of command breaks down,” Entrapta finished with a smile. “This will be quick, I promise!” she said, tugging Catra along.

Catra followed happily.

Catra lazily weaved out of the flame sword’s path, delivering a sharp kick to the offending soldier's back leg and leaving them wobbling before she slapped her on the back of the head and sent them tumbling to the floor face first with a metal clang.

“Your footwork needs improvement, you kept them too close for such a broad attack,” two more guards rushed her from behind.

Catra ducked low, listening to the whistle of the wind and hopped at the last second, half curled into a ball for but a moment before the blades passed below and above her and she touched the floor again.

Kicking off she launched forward as expected and the soldiers spun to try and catch her off guard.

Only for Catra to sail between their blades again and delivering a kick to their backs as she passed and flipping onto her hands before coming to a stop, mane of hair flowing freely in the mountain breeze.

“Attacks relying on predicting your opponent, rely on them not figuring out that’s what you’re doing, don’t try to be too clever or you’ll just trip yourselves up, like now.”

Rolling her shoulders, Catra bellowed, “All right all of you form up for inspection, we’re gonna do some more drills!”

As the soldiers raced into place, Catra’s ears twitched.

“When’s Entrapta gonna get rid of her mangy pet.”

Fangs gnashing, she lashed around and snapped, "Who mouthed off?!"

The soldiers froze, eyes flicking to one another guiltily.

"General… No one- "

"Shut up." She ordered.

'What's wrong with you Catra?' She sighed.

"Change of plans, I need to go check on some things, perform the standard practice drills and I'll be back in a bit."

Catra disappeared into the tower, before leaping into the shadows and crawling along the walls to the nearest window overlooking the courtyard.

"What was that about?"

"Who knows with someone like her."

"Yeah, you really can't trust beasts to keep their head."

Catra roared, "I can still hear you troglodytes, fifty laps!"

She watched them startle and glared from the window as they began racing around the palace, eyes lingering on each and every one of them.

Catra walked down the dimly lit halls, the faint familiar buzzing of toxic lights sending tingles down her spine.

She barely noticed it though, fangs gnashing and claws scraping on the synthetic floor.

"Entrapta. Entrapta come in. I need every soldier ID, now!"

No answer, not uncommon if the princess had fallen asleep working but it just left Catra snarling.

“What is wrong with these yokels, I’m the only reason this stupid city is still standing, and they think they can talk about me like that!?”

“Well that’s not right, Catra.” Entrapta said over the communicator.

“You heard that?” Catra gasped.

The princess's voice came from behind this time.

“I heard everything,” she drawled, arms folded behind her back as she strutted around her on her hair tendrils.

“I mean... Besides that, I didn’t say much,” Catra chuckled, as Entrapta casually encircled her and she found herself shuffling back.

“Oh Catra, Catra, you really do think too much of yourself if you thought you were that important,” The princess loomed over her, goggles glowing as the lights dimmed and Catra felt very, very small.

“You’re only important because I made you important. Your insider knowledge of the Horde helped, but really, its my technology, my weapons, my rank that got Dryl to where it is. You’re just, well like a pet who’s very quickly wearing out her welcome.”

Catra rolled back on her feet and swayed forward to the princess’s surprise.

“Wow, you didn’t do proper reconnaissance on Entrapta at all, did you Shadow Weaver?”

A series of confused beep and boops hit Entrapta’s ears and she quickly turned to see what had upset Emily, only to find her bots motioning towards the monitors.

“Did you detect something sweetie?” Entrapa gently patted the bot as she began to flick through the castle security sequences.

‘Nothing, nothing, nothing,”

“Catra, come in… Catra?”

Emily let out a distressed shriek and Entrapta’s hands and hair flew across the keyboard, security footage flooded the screens and recorded energy emissions and-

“There, floor seven!”

She flicked on the security cameras.

Only to be greeted with pure darkness.

“Oh, that can’t be good.”

Warning for abusive behavior

Shadows coiled and weaved around her. Catra could barely make out the hall around her, only Shadow Weaver's burning white eyes and crimson jewel were clear.

Instinct took over as Shadow Weaver loomed and Catra hissed as her claws tore through what felt like mist!

“You’re just shadows, you can’t do anything here but annoy me!” She tried to smirk, but it felt fake.

The chuckle that echoed around her resounded and battered its way into her skull, and a lancing electric strike struck her ankle and left her yelping and leaping to the side, only for the Shadows to dime further as Shadow Weaver coiled around her tighter.

‘Her scent, the Fright Zone, I can’t breathe!’

“Always so bold, right until you have to make good on your bluster!” Shadow Weaver snarled, lancing out, and causing Catra

to cry out as a familiar sting burned on her skin, and the scent of blood filled her nose as her cheek bled.

She spun, lashing out with a hiss only for her movements to be sluggish and limp, like moving through water.

She could guess where it was coming from and so the next strike left only the tiniest cut as she weaved around it Shadow Weaver's darkness flaring and hungry eyes filled Catra's mind.

"Even now you defy your better!"

Hands over her head, Catra called up her shields and watched as their light was subsumed in the darkness, even though she could feel their presence.

"Hiding behind her toys, pathetic!"

"You're the pathetic one, you wouldn't be here if I hadn't scared you witless- aaah!"

Another shock struck her feet and Catra hurled herself away, claws bared as she dug them into the synthetic floor and roared.

"There it is," Shadow Weaver hummed, growing larger and looming over her as Catra looked up from the pitch-black floor and into her eyes. "There's the frightened little beast that lurks behind the mask."

Another cut, another shock, and Catra's claws tore into the floor she couldn't see as the darkness grew.

"You can put on new clothes and beg for new toys, but I know what you are inside, Catra, what you've always been." Something struck the back of her head, too heavy and hard, her skull struck the floor and her yowl was swallowed by the darkness as Shadow Weaver roared.

"You're an animal!"

“I’m not!” She screeched, thrashing against the darkness as the tendrils coiled around her. “I- I’m the one-“

“You are doing nothing like always!” Shadow Weaver hissed. “Leeching off this princess for weapons and soldiers just like you did me in the Horde. You may snarl and roar and thrash, but you know deep down you’ll never be anything more than Adora’s forgotten little pet.”

“Shut up!” Another swipe, more shadows, her eyes were burning, a choked sob escaping her.

Shadow Weaver’s laugh hurt the most, even now, knowing the woman ‘wanted’ to hurt her, hurt the most.

“Deny it all you want but it’s the truth; you are forgotten, by your squad, by Adora, and even by me until you made a nuisance of yourself and soon enough your ‘companions’ will forget you as well.”

“She wouldn’t!” Catra’s mind was swimming, mingled memories and thoughts washing over her shaking form.

“Oh, but she has, we all have, and soon no one else will remember you at all.”

Shadow Weaver coiled around her, claws digging into her back in a twisted embrace as the world faded away into darkness, her cries were swallowed by the abyss.

Shadow Weaver’s spectral form hovered over Catra, an orb of shadows encasing the little beast's shaking, sobbing form, claws, fans and shocks building and lancing across her body.

‘I don’t want to miss a moment of this.’ She thought with a sigh, a familiar sense of relief and comfort coming from finally having been able to punish her again.

“Stop… Please…” a whimpering little voice begged, so familiar, reminding her of years ago when Adora had been so small.

‘I should have dealt with you then you little wretch!’

“Stop?” she hissed, releasing a weak pulse of magic into the floor and drawing forth another shock that made Catra scream, curling in on herself more and more.

“Why would I stop? You, stupid little creature.”

Another cut and a yelp.

“This is what you deserve!”

Another shock.

“You thought you could be anything without me!?”

Shadow unscrewed another light globe and it crashed against Catra’s head.

“You are nothing, stupid, worthless, ungrateful and-“

<u>Abusive section over</u>

“SHUT UP!”

Shadow Weaver’s eyes tore through her form and out the back of her head to glare at the intruder kicking her way out of the vents and landing on the floor, crystalline eyes meeting hers… without… fear!

“You dare-“

“I just told you to shut up! This is our house, so you do it!” The princess snapped. “You don’t know anything about Catra so stop spouting unsubstantiated rubbish!”

Shadow Weaver let her shadows unfold from Catra, flaring around the princess like a gaping maw ready to bite down, only for the

nearest tendril to be brushed aside by the princess's pink hair.

“I grabbed a sample already,” she said coldly, hands shaking, teeth biting into her lip as she looked passed Shadow Weaver at Catra, still trapped in the throes of panic. “You made me watch and listen, and now I’m gonna make you hurt.”

Shadow Weaver drew back, for just a moment, before she chuckled and then began to laugh, cackling madly at the absurdity of it all.

“You!? What can you and your toys do to me, brat!?”

“This!” Hair tendrils lanced into her shadowy chest and snapped back just as fast.

“Is that it?” Shadow Weaver drolled.

Then she heard it, a hum and metal clanking and beeping akin to Horde Droids.

“No,” the princess answered, and Shadow Weaver looked down to see a faint blue crystal chip floating and drifting up through her shadows as faintly blue lights shone through the walls like X-rays and guided it to her head.

“What is this thing?” She snapped, coiling her shadowing around it when-

“First One’s tech!” The Princess threw herself back and an electrical prod was unfurled from her hair and an energy blast surged forward.

Shadow Weaver tried to move but even as she dodged the lights through the walls turned into beams as the Droids with crystals adorning their cannons unleashed the glowing blue and red energy.

She dodged all but one, and then the alien yet terribly familiar energies of Etheria’s magic and something unknown to her began

to blister and crackle and sing. Energy lanced through her shadows, glowing bright, so bright it stung her senses and spreading through her shadows like wires, tearing into her red crest and flashing lights filled her senses.

The droids stepped closer, the princess unfurled dozens of glowing energy sources and soon the entire room was bathed in light, the alien energies growing like a disease tearing its way through her veins!

“No, you can’t! You don’t have this kind of power!”

“You don't know anything about us.” The princess answered as the blistering light engulfed Shadow Weaver’s senses and tore its way into her mind, arcane energies disrupting and screeching as her screams echoed through her sanctum and the connection was shattered as the last shadow was subsumed in the light.

Shadow Weaver struck the floor of her sanctum, the last sound she heard being Imp’s gleeful giggle before an all too familiar darkness swallowed her whole.

The miasma vanished and the screams disappeared, Entrapta’s bots let out a ping to say the unknown energy was gone and she was moving before even then.

Racing to Catra she dropped to her side, finding her wide eyed and breathing hard, pupils dilating and tail lashing as she looked uncomprehending out at the world.

“Catra, Catra can you hear me?” she asked, placing a hand over her, and a gentle hair tendril on her back.

Catra’s head snapped to her, their eyes locked before Catra lurched forward and buried her face in Entrapta’s chest, strong arms knocking the breath out of her as the warrior hugged her tightly.

“Its- Its OK now,” she gasped, cradling Catra’s head.

“You…” she heaved, “You saved me?”

Entrapta didn’t understand why it was a question, but she answered all the same.

“I did, they’re gone,” she promised.

Catra stilled and quickly pulled away, bristling and shaking her head, low growls rumbling as she ground out, “Something else is wrong, what?”

Entrapta swallowed and pulled out her Data-Pad, projecting a map of a battlefield with two battle lines, one much larger than the other tearing through the forests towards the smaller one as laser cannons flared and fired.

“The Horde started a big push towards us. I sent Dhashi but she says there’s too many and I called our allies-“

“We can’t rely on them,” Catra spat, taking up the Data-Pad in shaky paws.

“We can fall back I think, Dryl’s hard to invade,” Entrapta ventured, even though the idea of doing so and breaking all those promises felt wrong.

Catra just lurched to her feet with a snarl, “No! No she does not get to win again. We’re fixing this now.”

“We are!?” Entrapts cheered.

“We are, leave the bots here in case they send a strike force, we need a Skiff and any bombs you have lying around.”

Dhashi rasped as the ground rumbled beneath her feet at the Horde’s advance, their cannon fire met by her own forces and leaving sparks of green and purple energy and fire raining down on the forests turning it into a blistering nightmare.

“You’d think the fire would slow the bastards down, but the droids just keep coming,” she spat.

“Hey captain, remember when you said this contract would be safe and profitable?” Some idiot in her crew asked.

“No, but I remember telling you to be useful and flapping your gums isn’t, return fire and someone contact Dryl again dammit!”

Bluster aside, Dhashi knew they were in trouble, the Horde lines were three times larger than her own and their tanks outnumbered hers by the dozen, she could barely even stall their advance!

‘They’re gonna encircle us and turn this into a massacre, I need to fall back, but if we break and run they’ll charge us and mow us down!’

A sudden hum rang out from her wrist and Catra’s rough voice cut through the din.

“Dhashi, speak to me!”

“Catra!? Where have you been!?”

“The Horde had a secret strike force infiltrate the tower, they cut off communications, we’re on our way now.”

“Do you have some secret weapon on you?” She whispered.

“Something better,” Catra hissed with a cruel delight. “Announce that Shadow Weaver was defeated and that Catra is coming. Then divide your forces in half, slowly, and create a path down the middle for the Horde, that way if they try to encircle you, you can hold off those strikes and leave the main body to me.”

“That’s uh, that’s your plan?”

“Yeah, it’s a good plan,” she chuckled, hair whipping her mane as her newly minted lavender-grey helm with the weird First One’s

Scripts and the gem in the center glowed.

“Sure, hope you know what you’re doing,” Dhashi murmured, before saluting.

“All right landlubbers we got our orders, someone get me the foghorn!”

The mobile command center was a massive, boxy mobile fortress, to heavy to even float, it used the hover engines to reduce weight as it rolled across the forest floors, adorned with half a dozen turrets and armored to the nines it was imposing.

It was also in utter chaos. Ever since the words:

“Shadow Weaver has been defeated, Princess Entrapta and General Catra now march on the Horde!” boomed across the open channels to the cackling cheers of the rebels.

Force Captains were shouting into communication consoles and demanding answers as each sought a solution.

“Is Shadow Weaver really down?” One hissed.

“We can’t make contact; we’re only getting static from her chambers!” another bellowed for what must have been the third time.

“Maybe we should hold our position and wait them out?” Another suggested.

“We should fall back, if they took out Shadow Weaver who knows what they can do?” Another cried.

“Cowards!”

All froze.

“If these rebels somehow defeated Shadow Weaver then ending them here is our only choice or they’ll only come back stronger. Split the remainder of our forces into three major war parties, use the outer two to encircle the enemy, if it lets them scatter by not being a perfect encirclement fine, we can hunt the renegades down later, but we will break through and march on Dryl.”

“But what about the third force?” One hastened to ask.

Palm smashing against the holo-map. “Keep the Command Center here in case we need a rallying point and concentrate our central forces into a triangle formation and push forward as fast as possible. We’ll smash right through their line and scatter them for the flankers and march on Dryl. Destroy everything in our path!”

“Force Captain, where are you going!?”

Adora answered without a second thought.

“To lead from the front!”

It was bad, Catra knew, her body was still aching, she couldn’t get her breathing under control and Entrapta’s worried stare was burning holes in her back.

“It’ll be fine,” she said, scanning the maps and barking out instructions as they went.

“I know,” Entrapta answered, as the Skiff zoomed across the forests towards the raging fires and flashing lights over the hills.

‘They divided their forces faster than expected, we can still trap their main force in a firing line, but maybe that’s their plan, to lure us in and then strike from both sides, surrounding our forces as we did theirs?’

“We’re almost there!” Entrapta called as they began screeching up the hill.

“OK,” Catra fasted the grenades to her vest and growled, “Change of plans, I need to stall their advance, you know what to do.”

It wasn’t a great plan, in fact she’d just floated it as a last-ditch effort on the way, but here she was, throwing herself into the belly of the beast yet again.

“Just come back to me, OK?” Entrapta asked, sending a shiver down Catra’s spine as she turned to her worried princess and smiled.

Taking in a calm, deep breath she answered, “Of course.”

Entrapta smiled, hit the booster and the world bled away as Catra crouched down and just as they passed the peak Entrapta threw it into reverse.

Catra jumped a second before she did, letting the machine throw herself, her jump leaving dents in the steel as the forward momentum sent her sailing over her forces, the forests and into the Horde forces below.

Droids detected her path and stalled their march to aim at the skies and fire, each one missing her by a mile as she howled with laughter and began to fall.

Claws clasped the twin belt buckles that criss crossed her chest and with a flick she unfurled the grenade bedecked strips of leather as he threw herself into a violent somersault. A switch was flicked as the air howled and Catra let them crack against the air like a whip and unleashed twenty plasma grenades across the Hordes front as she sailed by them and into the Horde's heavy infantry.

Her helmet hummed and Catra cackled as her leg guards responded to the mental command, unleashing a pulse of energy that she used to fling herself around a plasma cannon blast.

She crashed against the tank's hull, claws tearing into metal as she skidded to a halt.

“Open fire!” Someone bellowed.

Catra just smirked and raised her arm, a domed energy shield encompassing her frame and sending the green bolts careening off to the soldier’s shock.

Using their surprise, she flipped through the air and clanged against the driver’s chamber and delivered a vicious backhand and followed it with a claw strike, sending the driver's guard flying out of the nest.

More shots were fired, but she just brought up her shields and let the blasts bounce harmlessly off her while clapping the soldier on either side of the head and dragging him down into her knee. The crack of glass was followed by a scream.

“Fire on the tank you idiots!” Someone shouted.

Catra howled with laughter as they attacked the tank, aiming for the fuel chambers, as she vaulted from the diver's chamber. Arms spinning wildly as she deflected more shots and heard the tank explode behind her, energy flaring like lightning, striking other tanks as the shock wave sent soldiers hurtling to the floor.

‘Your forces are too close for that, idiots!’

Landing on the railing to another driver's chamber she gripped it tight and spun herself upside down, kicking the twin pilots off and flipping into the chamber in a flash. She barely even stopped, as she kicked the cannon down and slammed the auto-fire switch, leaping away as it unleashed a toxic plasma blast into the troops.

Spiraling through the air Catra smirked as her helmet hummed. Crossing her arms over her chest, the crystals adorning her gauntlets, legs and helm began to shine. A pulsing pink light building on the jewel in the center and conjuried a domed field around her that pulsed with power.

Just as a tank let loose a plasma blast towards her Catra let the beam fly.

The Horde's blast was thrashing, rough and roiling like fire and lightning.

Her own was sharp, crisp and clean, like a spear of pure energy it tore through the plasma fire and pierced the tank in an instant.

Catra felt the heat wash over her frame before she hit the ground in a roll and raced deeper into the Horde lines, explosions and screaming following in her wake.

"She's tearing through their rear lines!" Dhashi announced to the cheers of her soldiers and crew.

Entrapta sat at her back directing little flying drones that were dropping grenades from above, so far she'd lost half but the Horde's formation was falling apart, their bots were in ruins, their tanks being blitzed and the soldiers just couldn't match Catra!

"Captain we have a problem!" someone called.

'Shit.'

"Well spit it out!"

"Their right flank is heading for the center, they're heading for Catra!"

"We can open fire on them and whittle them down!" she barked.

"But their left flank is gonna fall on us at any minute!"

"How did they move so fast?" someone asked.

'Shit we're gonna be trapped in a freaking coral chain of gunfire at this rate!'

"Ready the rear guns, get those Skiffs humming and- What is that noise!?"

The grunts of the soldiers beneath her paw were drowned out by the sudden wave of screams for retreat and general terror that Catra was pleased to hear.

But also found strange… Catra was sure she shouldn't have brought about that terror quite this fast.

"Catra, up above!" Entrapta screamed over the communicator and Catra's eyes flew wide at the dozens of blazing plasma lasts hurtling towards her from the command center.

Falling to one knee, Catra raised her right shield high and her left shield low, forming a dome around her as the blasts hit and all she could hear was roaring fires.

'They're bombarding their own troops!?'

She wanted to scream, of course they were, they were the Horde!

As the flames and shrapnel faded, Catra left out a Smokey cough as the toxic flames and smog left her lungs burning, her gaze turning to the command center as they readied another volley.

'Can I make a run for it, can I- What's that!?'

Her communicator buzzed and all Catra heard besides flames was a cry of "Adventure!"

Catra's tail stood on end as a ship came sailing out of the clouds, sparkling flames surrounding its frame before it crashed nose first into the command center and in a spectacular display of fireworks ripped through the armored roof and exploded.

The blast tearing into the command center and sending blasts of flames throughout the halls, sending soldiers on turrets leaping off to safety as the flames roared across the steel.

"Seahawk!?"

Catra's gaze snapped to the left flank and she wanted to cackle at the sight of a river rising up beneath the horde ranks tipping over tanks and droids as Memrista and her boytoy surfed the waters high above the Horde.

Her Communicator buzzed to life and she heard, the princess's droll tone.

"I guess I owed you one, so yeah… Even now," she said, with a hint of amusement.

"Mermista, what does this timely arrival make us!?" Seahawk called.

With an amused sigh she answered, "Big dang heroes?"

Scoffing, Catra rose to her feet in the ruins of the battlefield to the sight of some of Mermista's skipper vessels sailing over the hills to take the Hordes left flank from behind.

"Well I guess I'll just have to return the favor again, next time," she said, already breaking off into a run towards Entrapta and her forces on the hill, as the left flank and they engaged in an intense firefight that was sending rubble and dust clouds hurtling into the sky.

The voice was shouting at her, the battle was raging, something inside her wept, but Adora pushed forward. Shadow Weaver's training, the memory of her mentor and the blessings she'd bestowed upon her kept Adora's will fastened like iron as she marched towards the enemy encampment.

'Close, so close…. What's… That noise?'

"ADORA!" someone, Lonnie, screamed!

Adora's snapped around, "Where am I... Lonnie what happened!?"

“You don’t-” Lonnie shook her head, “The Command Centre tried to wipe out the enemies leader, they fired on our own troops!”

“They WHAT!?”

“And now they’re all dead, some lunatic crashed a ship into the command center, it’s a sparking wreck and another princess arrived and took our left flank by surprise and their secret weapon is heading straight for us!”

‘So close, we were so close-‘

“Lonnie, you’re in charge of the retreat,” she could see a flash of purple racing towards the enemy encampment and drew back her sword.

“But Adora-“

“I’ll cover you, now go!”

“Yes, Force Captain, all forces retreat!”

Adora heard those words and the cheers of their foes as the furthest of her tanks began to fall back, teeth gnashing together as she choked the handle of her found blade.

‘We were so close!’ Adora drew the blade back with a roar and slammed it down, unleashing a cascading wave of destruction that tore clean through the forests like a cannon made of air!

There was a hiss of energy and Adora hissed as a massive circular shield of purple energy sprung up in her attack's wake, diverting the forces into the forests, creating a hailstorm of wood chips and rocks.

The shields shrunk and the purple and grey bedecked feline stood to her full, unimpressive height, mismatched eyes meeting Adora’s own as she languidly said,

“Hey~”

Adora did not dignify the creature with a response, merely tightening her grip on the blade.

"Since when did the Horde start recruiting princesses," she cackled.

Adora flashed the pulsing blade, her eyes flickering red and blue as she stared at her own reflections and spat, "The Horde will use whatever tools are necessary to bring order to Etheria, surrender and I will treat you mercifully."

The feline offered a crooked grin, "Your heart really is not in that promise, but maybe that's just cos your troops are already running."

Adora drew back her blade and the enemy soldiers bared her claws, "But if you wanna fight, lets go, princess!"

With that they raced at one another with dual roars of fury.

"Can't you help her?!" Entrapta snapped, as another explosive wave of force tore up from the battlefield.

"I'd lose my head trying, that's princess power she's slinging around, I don't even know how Catra's still standing!" Dhashi shouted.

Catra could half hear them through her communicator but she was far more focused right now on her hulking brute of an opponent!

The ground around them was cracked and torn, great wounds dug into the dirt by her opponents swings or Catra's own lasers.

'Less places for me to jump around, but her footwork isn't so smooth anymore, call it even,' Catra mused as she danced out of the way of another blow.

Ducking below another swing and racing forward, Catra lashed out, only to have her claws block by the damn golden bracelets.

The brute tried to grab her but Catra kicked off their leg, tickling their nose with her tail as she somersaulted around them.

"You have Horde training," The giant ground out. "Why would you betray us!?"

Catra chuckled and let loose another blast that was deftly deflected, "Them opening fire on their own troops not a clear enough example?"

"That's not how the Horde should behave!" The giant swung her sword and Catra kicked off the ground as the air tore through the ground.

"You are a dupe," she cheered, kicking off a fallen tree to deliver a kick when something faint and familiar occurred to her and she instead brought up her shield just in time to blow an uppercut that rebounded of the energy shield.

Spinning she landed on her back and used the princesses surprise at her sudden flop to hook her legs around the princess's heels and dragged them back.

As if struck by luck itself, the giant blonde, managed to snake one of her legs free and bring it crashing down behind her to stabilize herself as Catra rolled to her feet, claws flexing.

"You have good instincts," They both snapped as one, before drawing back, shared grimaces on their faces when the princess snapped and Catra matched her:

"Shut your mouth," the princess growled and Catra smirked as they continued, "I said shut up!"

Catra leapt back with a giggle as the princess barreled towards her, 'predictable,' she hummed, even as something tugged at her

as she weaved around the next swipe only to see her counterattack blocked without the blonde even having to look!

“Force Captain Adora, we need to fallback!” a familiar force cried.

“Lonnie?” The blonde giant was Adora, her Adora?

Lonnie let out a cry as several laser rounds began to hail down towards her and the blonde tore off, Catra too stunned to move as she watched them scoop Lonnie up and leave a crater in the earth as they leapt into the forests and out of sight.

“Adora…”

The battle was over and with the injured being tended to it was time for the remaining soldiers and drivers to come and drag away the remains of the Horde vehicles for scrap materials and salvage weapons.

As the people outside were engrossed in their work, the central hub of the mobile fortress had whatever remained of the Force Captains removed and its burnt walls were now hosting only Catra, Mermista, Seahawk, Dhashi and Entrapta.

Contrary to the former Horde soldier’s usual cocky glee after a victory, Catra was in a state few could describe. She stalked the chamber, teeth grit, a low rumblings growl echoing across the walls with every breath, tail lashing and mane wild as Entrapta worked tirelessly at the crackling consoles when-

“I got it!” She cheered, Catra blurring to her side, fingers flying over the keyboard.

“This is it; this is all of it, the entire troop roster and their records?” She asked sharply.

“Uh, well, I think so. It’s all the files that were here on them, but… I could only find one Adora…” Entrapta mumbled, leaning

out of Catra's way as the warriors practically devoured the information on screen.

There were bright flashes of a tall woman with blonde hair in a ponytail in a red jacket with a calm and cheery smirk that spoke confidence but not of cruelty. Alongside her were statistics, squad information and a small collection of image files showing her alongside some lesser Horde soldiers who looked to her with respect and fondness.

"I'm not here," Catra muttered, shoulders slacking, head hanging low.

"Well yeah, didn't you like leave?" Mermista asked.

"I mean I'm not in their fucking records!" Catra snarled, throwing herself up, body shaking with unspent rage, as her clothes seemed to strain under the swelling of her muscles, weapons beginning to hum and hiss.

"She erased me, she erased me from the records, from her- She. She…"

Catra's eyes zeroed in on the chamber's occupants and she snarled, "Leave. Now."

"Right…" Mermista said with a subtle step back, as Dhashi and Seahawk tugged at Entrapta's hair who remained motionless.

"I said-"

"I'm not leaving you alone," Entrapta said simply, even as the rooms other occupants had stepped outside and were watching with wide eyes.

"I told you-"

"You're not my boss," The princess countered, voice oddly calm, "You're in pain, I don't know how to fix it, but I'm not leaving you alone to suffer, so that's that."

Catra’s head snapped back as if struck before she stomped right passed the princess and smashed the door buttons and they ground closed with a pained screech.

The instant the door sealed a ferocious roar tore through the steel, like a dying animal screaming its last before leaping at its killer, Catra’s cry echoed like an explosion. She did not even stop to breathe as she moved, the sound of metal tearing and breaking beneath her fury making those outside wince and cringe.

“We should go in there,” Seahawk murmured as something glass shattered and a new wave of screeching filled the air.

“We need to get Entrapta out, you mean,” Mermista countered as Dhashi gulped at the door.

“I doubt she’d hurt the princess-“

Metal howled as fists impacted against it and tore right through, followed by claw shaped dents bursting from the walls as if trying to strike them.

It was hard to count how long it went on for, Catra’s cries of fury echoing across the battlefield leaving those working watching the command center with shared dread and confusion before finally a deafening silence dominated the burnt and charred land.

Mermista was the first to move, thumping at the door switch and the metal screeched and wailed weakly as the ruined doors shuttered open to reveal utter devastation.

The walls, the floors, even the ceiling and every screen had been torn, had been struck, had been warped and ripped to shreds by Catra’s own hand, leaving nothing but twisted metal.

All save for one neat, perfect circle surrounding princess Entrapta, who knelt on the floor, Catra’s hands in hers as she tried to bandage the bleeding claws as the warriors hissed and wretched.

“She stole my past… I’m going… I’m going to take everything from her…”

Entrapta just continued to tend to her partner's wounds in silence, as at a loss for words as those watching who quickly left the pair to grant them some privacy.

It was some time before they returned to the field, and neither spoke of what transpired in that room when they did, returning to Dryl in utter silence.

Shadow Weaver couldn’t breathe.

She was bound on her hands and knees, shock bindings sending violent waves of lightning into her skin at every subtle pulse of arcane energy. Her mask lay confiscated, her insides churning in agony and humiliation as her former subordinate’s looked down on her!

Hordak’s metal feet stomped around her, swift and terrible as he hissed.

“An entire invasion force put into retreat.”

Another shock.

“Three of four Force captains, dead.”

The energy tubes binding her cuffs and leg bracers shot out leaving her to slam into the floor, stretching out her muscles and bones until they wanted to scream.

“And worst of all,” another peel of lightning!

“You failed to even accomplish your mission!”

Just as Shadow Weaver expected the boot to come down upon her skull, the sanctum began to buzz and screech and something distant and powerful tore its way into her mind.

The door was torn from the wall as an all too familiar voice cried, “Please Lord Hordak, I beg you, show mercy!”

Adora fell to her knees at Shadow Weaver's side, head pressed to the floor, a runic sword attached to her back.

“Please Lord Hordak, we all failed, the enemy was dishonorable and cunning, but, ah, it wasn’t a complete loss, I claimed this powerful relic.”

Shadow Weaver squinted through the pain to see her Adora almost grappling with herself to offer the sword to Hordak who now loomed over her, crimson eyes no longer burning with fury but curiosity.

“And what, pray tell, is his?” he asked, almost gently.

Adora fumbled, “I… I’m not sure my lord, but it is a weapon of great power, it told me, I mean, I think it has some form of AI, and it may hold the secret to defeating the princess's magic.”

She bowed low, holding the sword above her head, “I don’t know why it works for me, but I submit myself and this weapon to your wise judgement, but beg you show Shadow Weaver mercy, for her years of loyal service if nothing else.”

Shadow Weaver could see the cruel smirk upon her master’s lips as he delicately ran a claw across the blade and drew it back like lightning as it began to crackle with power that left his own machines humming and screeching in confusion.

“Fascinating…” He murmured, gesturing to a nearby lab table, “Place it over there, Force Captain Adora.”

Adora looked to her uncertainty, but obediently complied as Hordak continued to pace around the chamber.

“It was you who led the invasion from the front, was it not, Force Captain?”

“It was my lord,” she answered obediently, turning around and saluting.

“And it was you who were moments away from delivering a crushing blow to the enemy before their ‘secret weapon’,” he glared down at her, “The soldier Shadow Weaver threw away, intervened?”

“… I do not know the traitor’s history Lord Hordak, but yes, I was; their stolen tech was… impressive.”

Hordak scoffed, “What those savages call magic mingling with my technology, how abhorrent, but,” he hummed, “interesting.”

He strode towards his throne and then flared his cape dramatically.

“As a reward for your skilled service, Force Captain Adora, I award you Shadow Weaver's former position as my second in command.”

Gasps of shock and excitement at her fall filled the chamber as Shadow Weaver groaned, trying and failing to force herself up.

As Adora tried to speak, Hordak proclaimed.

“In honor of the gift you have brought me, I shall remit Shadow Weaver to your custody. She is yours to do with what you wish, provided she serves the Horde well.”

She could feel his gaze burning into her skull as he added. “But make no mistake, Shadow Weaver, the ice has been broken, and you are sinking fast. Attempt to undermine my authority or that of the Force Captain and I shall use other methods to harness the magic you are so proud of. Am I understood?”

“Crystal… Lord Hordak,” she whispered, pressing her head to the floor flecked with her own blood.

“Then begone from my sight. Force Captain Adora, I leave our next operation in your hands; do not disappoint me.”

Even as he spoke, he was already striding towards the Rune-Sword with obvious interest, barely acknowledging Adora or the other Force Captains as they saluted and proclaimed their loyalty to the Horde before scurrying out of his chambers, Shadow Weaver barely kept steady by Adora's hands.

'This isn't… over…' her inner mind hissed, 'I won't let it end… like this!'

As they got into the hallway, Adora whispered, "Come on, let's get you healed up."

Shadow Weaver dug her nails into Adora's shoulder as she whispered, "Did you see her, the traitor?" She had feared the spells limits, but it seemed-

Adora nodded, "I did... Her fighting style was strange, but I could preempt it... However she could do the same to mine, like she'd fought me before. Do you… Know anything about her Shadow Weaver?"

For the first time since she had awoken, Shadow Weaver smiled.

Chapter End Notes

> So my editor got this back to me super fast, thanks as always Romanaround, you rock!
>
> I hope the content of this chapter was engaging and had some twists, the scene where Catra reacts to the realization was one of the first one's I came up with and had been longing to write for aaaages.
>
> If you are wondering how Entrapta did what she did, basically the First One's Crystal have magical energy from Etheria in them and Entrapta briefly super charged them and turned them into beams, overwhelming and basically burning out Shadow Weaver's shadows. And yes, this was mostly a shot in the dark on her part, XD

Also the big beam Catra fires was inspired by a DBZ movie villain's attack, namely one from "Plan to eradicate the Sayians" as I thought it was a cool attack and it worked well with Catra's gauntlets and helmet.

Also the semi evil world conquest flirting is something else I've wanted to do for awhile cos I find it fun, even more-so cos Entrapta is so nonplussed by it, had that dialogue exchange in my head for months!

Thanks for reading and please feel free to leave a review with any feedback or questions you might have!

A Night to Remember

Chapter Summary

> Sooo, everyone recovered from Season 4? Ready for a fun, wholesome chapter where nothing surprising happens? Gooooooood :D
>
> The battle was won, but the fallout remains. Catra grows sharp and distant, as Entrapta seeks a means to reforge their bond while her fellow princesses watch Dryl with a burning intensity. But all the while the Horde schemes.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The faint sound of crystal-clear running water was almost as familiar to Glimmer as the sensation of breathing. The same was true for the faint glittering sparkles that drifted across her palace home, the gentle breeze, soft pastel walls, and silver armored guards.

Despite that, she couldn't say she was terribly familiar with this particular hallway or these particular doors. Perhaps that shouldn't be a surprise, or maybe it should be, given that they led to her mother's study.

Repressing a gulp, she glanced at the duo of guards who said and did nothing, still as statues before her.

"Can I uh… just…" she pointed at the door and mimed knocking. Neither objected and so she tepidly tapped on the large ornate door once before her mother's voice called out.

"Enter, Glimmer."

Huffing, Glimmer turned herself into a wave of sparkles and reformed within the dimly lit chamber where upon she ignored the

rows of lore, oddly firm chairs and swaying lights or ornate pillars to fold her arms and scowl.

“If you knew I was there, why didn’t you just say so?”

“A little patience never hurt anyone,” her mother answered, plucking a scroll from her desk and pursuing it with a sort of casual, regal interest Glimmer couldn’t even affect.

“Now then, you needed something I take it, or is this a social visit?” her mother asked, with a faint smile.

Sighing, Glimmer bowed, missing her mothers’ frown as she spoke, “My queen, as one of your commanders, I would like to… highlight a concern.”

“And might I ask why you didn’t do this in today’s strategy meeting?” her mother asked.

Glimmer stood back up and rubbed the back of her head.

“It's been so busy with all these dignitaries lately and I didn’t want to give them a spectacle if we had a fight.”

“Hmm, well my court will certainly miss the entertainment, but I appreciate the consideration.” Her mother's wings flared as she dropped into her chair and hummed, “Things have been rather hectic of late.”

“I know,” Glimmer enthused, “Dignitaries and officers from so many kingdoms coming to visit, I mean, I know it's not the rebirth of the princess alliance. yet,” she muttered. “but it is a big change!”

“It is rather encouraging, and it helped us address many resources concerns, with that in mind, I can only assume you have one of two problems,” she held up a finger. “One, us not going on the attack against the Horde.”

Glimmer nodded, “Always but not today.”

“Two, Dryl I take it?”

Glimmer bowed her head, “It is… Look, I know THAT Bow and I messed up.”

“Good, because you did.” her mother quietly chastised.

“And,” Glimmer stressed, “I’m not exactly thrilled with the prospect of some former Horde agent running wild, but you’ve seen the same reports I have. Dryl has delivered a huge series of blows to the Horde, so why aren’t we even discussing the idea of fighting with them? As it is, half the dignitaries seem more concerned with Dryl than they do the Horde!”

Her mother just hummed, tapping her cheek, “Yes, they do rather have their own goals and priorities here that have little to do with the Horde. As it is, many of them find Drly more disturbing than they do the Horde.”

“But… Why?”

“A fine question, and one I’m glad to see you asking.” her mother opened one of the drawers on her desk and pulled out a Data-pad.

A few button presses later and it was in Glimmer’s hands and she was greeted by the intense mix eyed stare of the former Horde soldier that had beaten her and Bow up. She hit play and watched as the feline fighter demolished a crew of her own soldiers, before barking harsh orders and advice at them.

The screen flicked to another video where Droids could be seen patrolling the streets and then before and then securing a perimeter around a First One’s ruin.

Another showed the beginnings of construction for what looked like a fort or maybe a town?

Another showed a newly built factory.

Another a mine.

Finally an image flashed of Seaworthy now baring flags where before there had been none, overseen by the former Horde soldier, and some purple, spiked fish folk.

“How did you get all this?” She gasped.

“Thankfully for all their skills in warfare and technology, the ‘Iron Federation of Dryl’ is not terribly experienced with spy craft; it’s been even easier since they hired a sorcerer from Mystacor to ward their fortifications.”

“But why are we all spying on them?”

Her mother took back the Data-Pad and waved it, “I will answer your question when you answer mine, Glimmer. Tell me, what did you see on that screen?”

Glimmer pouted for a time before shrugging, “Soldiers, droids, factories I guess?”

Her mother shook her head, “That is what was on the screens, but not what so many of our contemporaries are seeing when they look at the same information. What they see is another Horde under a new name and perhaps with a more subtle touch.”

“But that’s crazy the Horde are monsters, this is just,” she waved her hand, “People.”

Her mother sighed, “All our enemies are people Glimmer, that’s why war is such a tragic thing.” Shaking off whatever had overtaken her, the queen rose to her feet, hands folded behind her back, scroll clasped tightly in her hands.

“What our contemporaries see is the same rampant industrialization of their lands that the Horde brings, so disturbed by it is Princess Perfuma that she has rejoined the Alliance out of sheer dread. What they see is an army being recruited in mass numbers and trained in the same techniques as the Horde. Using

the same equipment and methods, only compounded by our guerrilla warfare skills. What they see are pirates being awarded high ranks, and villages falling under the federations sway by bribery, the threat of being left to the Horde, or even selfish ambition."

Her mother turned to face her, sharp and stern as she said, "What they see Glimmer, is the erosion of our way of life, traditions and culture, of kingdoms and borders. They wonder, if we join this federation and defeat the Horde, will we not just be trading an enemy that attacks us openly and in a way we find familiar, for one that is more subtle and harder to defeat?"

"That… I mean… I don't know, at least we'd win, and Dryl doesn't exactly seem bad," Glimmer offered lamely, realizing only now that she didn't know what life in Dryl was like, merely of their military victories.

"If we lose what makes us who we are," her mother said gently, but firmly, "Our lands, our rank, our kingdoms, did we really win Glimmer?"

Glimmer's head sunk, before she shook off the uncomfortable feelings. "OK, so maybe that's a concern, but that's no reason to write Dryl off entirely, right?"

"I agree."

"And another thing-… Wait what?"

Her mother chuckled, "I said I agree Glimmer. We need to see more, not through a spyglass but in person, thus I have managed to convince our allies and acquaintances to aid in a little scheme of mine."

She offered Glimmer the Scroll she'd taken up since she had entered the room.

"Tell me what you think."

Taking it, Glimmer unrolled the Scroll and read it, eyes wide as she gasped.

Entrapta sat nestled in her hair, projects half neglected as she prodded at her keyboard and looked up at the displays laid before her.

Quill and Dhashi were holding steady, Mermista and Seahawk rising up and as always, her bots were second to only one in terms of companionship.

Or at least, they had been.

She looked forlornly at Catra's rating and saw the algorithm bump her down another percentile and the princess let out a sigh.

She then startled and screeched as the doors hissed open and Dhashi called, "Yo princess, I couldn't find Catra so… What's ah, what's all this?"

Twirling around to face the fish folk, Entrapta answered, "It's just a social and companionship analysis algorithm."

The former pirate turned commander leaned around her, looked at her own rating, then to the princess and then to the bots who booped disinterestedly before she murmured, "OooooKaaaay. Well, one of my crews picked up some messengers from Brightmoon, they had that pink princess with them so we know its legit."

"Oh, did she give you a sample of her teleportation energies?" Entrapta asked, pushing herself out of her daze a little.

Only to be shoved right back in when Dhashi answered, "Nope, sorry, just gave us this and said it needed to be sent right to ya. Well you or Catra but I figured you'd be busy so I tried to find her but she's pulling another disappearing act."

“I’m not busy anyway,” Entrapta said, taking the offered scroll, but at Dhashi’s salute she called after her. “Um, can I ask for some advice?” At the fish folks questioning gaze she added, “It's just that you have a crew and lots of people like you so I thought you might be able to give me some advice.”

“This would be cos of Catra’s moodiness I take it?” She asked, cracking her neck, words sounding like a sigh.

“I wouldn’t say moodiness,” Entrapta ventured.

“Ya that’s fair, moodiness implies more than one mood, but she’s been perpetually pissed since the battle and won’t let up.” Seeing the princess’s sour face, Dhashi quickly changed tracks. “Look here princess, I’ve not ever had much interest in the kind of relationships you and Catra seem to have, not with anyone nowhere.”

Rolling her shoulders, her dual pets trilling as they clambered for a purchase she added, “Maybe it be better if you seek out someone more in line with what you’re seeking, like that Mermista or Sea…”

Dhashi cut herself off, remembering Mermista had the emotional capacity of a becalmed galleon, and Seahawk was, well. Seahawk-

“Actually,” she mumbled, instantly giving Entrapta her full attention, “I think I might just be the best person available to advise ya.” She squared her shoulders and marched the princess towards a nearby couch and sat her down before snatching up a roller chair and spinning it around to rest her arms on the back she spoke.

“All right princess, lay it on me.”

Entrapta shuffled nervously under her gaze, so Dhashi leaned back, not quite meeting her eyes and instead staring at the roof as she waited for Entrapta to order her thoughts.

“I mean, its just… Before the battle, before the Adora event, Catra and I were close, affection ratings were through the roof!” She

enthused before sagging, “But now she doesn’t talk to me much, or at all really, she still sends me First One’s and Horde tech but that’s it.”

Dhashi gurgled and spat on the floor, “That one has always had a temper, and she’s been sharp tongued and quick to the draw with anyone that gets on her bad side these days. I think she’s tryna keep you from seeing that side of her or being hurt by it.”

“That’s nice of her, but I want to help her fix it so she can be happy again and I can’t do that if she won’t talk to me. I don't even fully understand what’s wrong; I tried to assess the situation, but my conclusions feel… inadequate.”

Entrapta watched Dhashi dropped her chin onto her arms, rocking her head from side to side, her cute pets wobbling alongside in motion from her shoulders.

“This is cos that Adora bird forgot her, ain’t it?”

“Yeah, though from what Catra, uh, implied, I think it goes a bit beyond forgetting.”

“Forgetting, forced to forget, memory erasure,” Dhashi grumbled, “Whatever you do if you bet on the Horde being terrible you can be sure to win.”

“That tells me the problem, but not the solution,” Entrapta said, hands clutching at her pants, her bots nudging up around her to offer comfort.

‘I did not sign up for this buuuuut.’

Tearing her gaze from the floor and looking half to Entrapta, Dhashi pulled on her experience as a captain of ruthless cutthroats to guide her to a solution.

“Look here princess, you can’t fix what the Horde did to her old fling, but what you can do is provide the bolster she needs to at least ease off the stress. What I mean is, if you’ve been holding

back something important ya wanna say or do for her to show what she means to ya, then do it now, it might just shock her into listening to ya, savvy?"

"Savvy… Yeah, I think I have an idea, Dhashi, thanks!"

"Perfect, anyway I have work to do, and I better go make sure Quill hasn't drowned in scrolls again before they sign my next paycheck," popping her back muscles she added, "Oh and take a look at that Scroll will ya, seemed important."

"I will get right on doing that Captain Dhashi!"

As Entrapta waved the captain offer and gave each of her wonderful bots a pat or a stroke, she finally turned her attention to the scroll and unfurled it, eyes going wide at the contents.

Catra hastily tried to brush her bristling fur down before reaching the doors to Entrapta's lab, eschewing the vents or other fun ways to get in, as the mood had long since left her. Deep bags under her eyes, hidden by fur, coming from nights of nightmares and long stretches of staring at the scrap metal Adora had given her before she escaped.

'I should have known, should have seen this coming!'

Catra wasn't entirely sure what she should have seen coming, but she knew it was her fault. She hadn't been strong enough, smart enough or prepared enough. She hadn't tried to sneak Adora out with her, she hadn't prepared the soldiers enough to fight without her, and if not for Entrapta she'd have been dead!

'And I'm going to make sure nothing like that ever happens again!'

The doors opened with a hiss and Catra was greeted by the sight of Entrapta jerking back from the door with a screech.

"Eavesdrop much?" Catra groused without heat, helping the other woman to her feet.

“Sorry, I wanted to know when you arrived. You’re very quiet,” she said, patting the floor with her hair softly to demonstrate the point.

“I learnt to tread lightly, why did you need me, I have a lot of work to do,” Catra huffed before biting her cheek at the sight of Entrapta looking wounded by her tone.

Before she could force out something in the range of an apology Entrapa steeled herself and clutched a scroll tightly in her hands.

“I wanted to talk about… us,” she said slowly.

“What," her gaze shifted to everything but Entrapta, "about us?” Catra didn’t like the feeling in her chest or Entrapta's tone.

“Well,” Entrapta frowned, “us and you… OK, this isn’t working. Listen,” she grasped Catra’s shoulders, not harshly and met her gaze, a rare thing for Entrapta and it stilled Catra instantly.

“You’ve been in a kind of nebulous position, constantly shifting titles, ranks, and I think that’s true our relationship as well and all the recent… stuff, has just made things less certain.”

Catra drew herself back and Entrapta, mercifully let her get some distance.

“I don’t know how to fix everything like I do my bots, but I want to make things clear for you, between us and everyone else and I think this,” she held up the scroll, “is the best time to do it.”

Cautiously, Catra took the scroll and unfurled just a little, ears twitching in confusion.

“What’s the All Princess Ball?”

Adora walked at Shadow Weaver’s side as her mentor and guardian composed herself after a none to subtle and very embarrassing ‘troop inspection’; done expressly to humble

Shadow Weaver and establish Adora as her superior. She hated this kind of embarrassing punishment, even if she understood why they were necessary.

“Shadow Weaver, please, we’ve been dancing around this since your recovery. You keep plying me for what I know about the traitor and the sword, but I'm the one who needs information on this Catra person.”

Shadow Weaver let loose a theatrical sigh, “I had hoped to not have to discuss that ‘failure’ with you Adora but it seems I must, please, if we might retire to my old sanctum?”

Another dagger twisted in Adora’s back in what she had indirectly taken from her mentor and Adora, despite her screaming disquiet at the Black Garnet chamber, agreed.

When they returned, Adora found herself standing at attention as Shadow Weaver took a seat and composed herself, slowly.

“Catra… Had a history with me, and with you, or more, she wishes she had one with you…”

“Shadow Weaver I’m… Not sure what that means.”

She chuckled, humorlessly, “That may be for the best. Catra was one of my wards, I thought her to have some talent, though none like your own, and so I took her under my wing. I cared for her, raised her, trained her, but perhaps… Yes, I indulged her too much, allowed too much and so she grew greedy, power hungry and entitled. Seeking personal power for herself rather than to benefit the Horde.”

“That’s awful!”

“I know dear, but it does not end there,” shadow Weaver sighed, “You see... She also developed an intense obsession with you. She watched you in secret, she both hated you for occupying my attention and yet I believe wanted to possess you, even deluding

herself into thinking you two had a relationship when you'd never met."

"That's how she knew to predict my movements, she'd spied on my training right!?"

"Yes, exactly Adora, excellent deduction," Shadow Weaver commended, making Adora flush with pride. Shadow Weaver rung her hands and Adora had never seen her mentor so vulnerable.

Crouching down she took Shadow Weaver's hand into her own and asked, "Please, you can trust me, tell me what went wrong?"

Shadow Weaver gently pressed her forehead to Adora's own and sighed, "She went too far, sought to remove me from my position and claim it for herself. She planned to use her new power to claim you as her own and likely plotted to supplant Hordak. I defeated her, sent her running but… I could not kill her, or even bring myself to capture her. I was too weak, Adora, and now everyone else is paying the price for my softness."

"But who could blame you?" Adora whispered, clasping Shadow Weaver's hands tightly and smiling, "We'll fix this, I promise."

"You are kind to an old woman, more than she deserves Adora, thank you." Shadow Weaver offered her a gently embrace before pulling away and waving towards the rear entrance. "If you'll entertain an idea from your old mentor, I think I may have a… creative way to use Catra's obsession with you to our advantage."

"Enter."

Adora was greeted by the sight of a towering, mass of muscles and carapace, short white hair, a handsome square jaw that made her blush a little and a scroll clutched in a single red claw.

"Adora, meet Force Captain Scorpia."

Adora's hand shot out as she robotically said, "It's a pleasure!"

Scorpia smiled, “You too, warning though,” she blurred forward and pulled Adora into the warmest hug she ever remembered, “I’m a hugger!”

Shadow Weaver coughed, none to subtly and Scorpia put her back down and Adora got her hair back in order, using it as a chance to hide her blush.

Shadow Weaver gestured to Scorpia and the scroll.

“Tell me Adora, do you know the history of Scorpia’s family?”

“Of course, its covered in Force Captain orientation. When Lord Hordak and his retinue arrive, the royal family welcomed them. They heard of Hordak’s goal to unify and empower Etheria and found it noble, offering him the Black Garnet, their eternal friendship and fealty in exchange as thanks for the marvelous technology he offered the people.”

“Very good,” Shadow Weaver hummed, “What you may not know is that for all their barbarism and reckless, selfish use of magic, the princesses do have some rules. Such as the traditional ‘All Princess Ball’ of which Scorpia naturally does not attend due to her loyalty to the Horde but receives an invitation to nonetheless.”

Scorpia scratched the back of her head and mumbled, “Plus the other princesses never really liked me,” she clamped her pincers, “They’re more into hands than stingers and claws.”

Adora gently patted the taller woman’s claw, “That’s awful, I’m sorry Scorpia, but hey, at least you’re accepted where it counts,” she smiled and was pleased to receive on in turn.

“Well said, Adora, and I believe this is an ideal opportunity for us.” She pointed to the Scroll and said, “You will accompany Scorpia as her plus one to the All Princess Ball.”

As the plan unfolded and was perfected Adora inwardly grinned.

‘This time I won’t lose, Catra!’

When Mermista's pleasure cruiser pulled up to Dryl and she stepped onto the too dry, too windy and altogether too purple city, it had been… Exactly as she suspected.

Too much of many things she didn't like along with quietly anxious yet excited as people raced through the streets stopping to gape or bow at her passage as she and Seahawk strode through the streets.

Chatter filled the air along with the sounds of industry which were still alien to her ears despite the new factories on her lands.

The guards didn't even bother trying to bar her way, though she could feel them watching her from behind, ready to strike if she did start something, while bots patrolled the streets, scanning her own pet security droid, done up in her own colors.

"Your buddies know why we're here?" She asked it.

It beeped in what Mermista was learning to be affirmation and she nodded, pushing on towards Dryl's central tower and the growing sound of familiar voices echoing out the open doors.

"Do we need fog machines!? I have fog machines!" Dhashi cried.

"Why do you even have those and yes of course!" Catra yelled back from somewhere.

"Everyone has a garage band phase!"

Mermista glanced at Seahawk who suddenly refused to meet her eyes, whistling noncommittally.

"Aaaah, I don't know if the throne will be ready in time!" Some nervous satyr called out, staggering through the central hall half drowning in scrolls.

"Maybe we shouldn't have tried to include the lasers?" Entrapta called from near the middle of the room, standing on a dais and

surrounded by tailors even as her hair tendrils coiled their way through the chamber holding different tools and data-pads.

“Hello maties!” Seahawk saluted.

The chamber froze, everyone mid panic looking to the doorway.

“Is this like, a bad time?” she half joked.

Entrapta acted first, “Mermista!” she cheered, only for the tailors to shoot up shouting, “Please don’t run off again!” stalling the greeting

Catra was second, moving like a blur she appeared before Seahawk and dumped a crate in his hands, “Perfect, you need to go help the pyrotechnics crew, follow Dhashi.”

Seeing the ecstatic grin on his face, Mermista rolled her eyes and waved him off, to go and chase down his fellow pirate already booking it out the door.

“Don’t blow up anything you’re not supposed to,” she and Catra Drawled as one.

Their eyes met and there was a flash of challenge on Catra’s sharp features before she drew herself back and nodded, “You’re a bit early for the party.”

Mermista shrugged, “I only got word of the change in venues like this morning. Figured I’d swing by and see how you were coping with this stupid hazing ritual.”

“We're just fine,” Catra answered tightly.

“We really aren’t though,” Entrapta added, “So unfair I was looking forward to studying social engagements and dancing at this ball, now I have to just follow a script all night.”

“Yeah, these functions are dull as dishwater. Still, I figured you might be rushing, and I want a good kelp bar, mind if I bring in

my caterers to help out?”

“Really, thanks Mermista!” Entrapta cheered.

“Why?” Catra scowled, folding her arms, and tapping her ‘foot’ impatiently.

Mermista shrugged, “Why not, besides, now you owe me,” she joked.

“Pfft, at best we’re even, I helped you corral your simpering nobles and merchants, this is easily on the same level,” Catra countered.

“We can do a tally later if you really care,” Mermista said, strolling around the chamber, “Still though dumb as trapping you like this is, the ball is a big deal. If you two pull it off, all those kingdoms aligning to counter you are liable to… ease up.”

“Or just try harder to shake us up.”

“Maybe, but better to not give them an excuse I figure, it's why I always bother to turn up.”

Catra just groaned, “Princess politics is just as petty as Horde politics…”

That drew a few gasps, but Mermista just rolled her neck, “Might wanna keep those kinda thoughts to yourself.”

“Oh, I will, I’m not letting anyone screw this up for us.” Catra cracked her knuckles and smirked, “Now you mention something about caterers?”

The night had arrived, and Glimmer found herself in the company of Bow, Netossa and Spinerella as they crossed the threshold into the courtyard of the ‘Dryl Tower’ home to princess Entrapta.

“For only being given two days warning they pulled this together pretty well,” Netossa mused at their backs, arm snaked around her wife’s waist as they approached the gate.

Glimmer and Bow nodded in agreement. There was a lot to be said for the spectacle of it all, gently flashing lasers painted patterns in the sky before forming an aurora style rainbow pattern. Fog machines spilled a faintly scented mist into the air that wafted across the floors, while musicians performed atop a balcony to an adoring audience.

It was an open-air party, with princess Entrapta and her Horde turncoat standing side by side upon the steps leading into Dryl’s tower greeting the guests. Glimmer recognized the Horde soldiers’ uniform as the one she’d been wearing during the last intelligence reports; but it had been gussied up with a sash and some medals. Entrapta meanwhile wore a sharply elegant, double breasted purple and pink pantsuit-dress with Dryl’s symbol woven across the top and shining blue-ish jewelry that was filled with oddly patterned crystals adorning her frame.

‘Those crystals patterns…’ She thought looking at Bow,

“They look like First One’s tech,” Bow agreed.

Glimmer looked down at the sound of a faint whirring noise and saw it at the same time Bow did given his excited gasp as a small metallic… thing, with googly eyes and a butler's suit rolled in on a single wheel before coming to a stop before them.

Saluting it announced in a cheer synthetic voice, “Greeting, I am the Butler Bot, welcome to Dryl, a land of innovation!” It then performed a dramatic little spinning bow.

“Oh my gosh it has a little suit and tie, its so cute!” Bow enthused.

The butler bot looked up at him and the lights that flashed with it spoke formed a smile, as it answered, “You have excellent taste, I like you!”

Bow grabbed her shoulder, shaking her, “It likes me, and it responds to external prompts, this is amazing!”

“I am amazing indeed, thank you! While you wait to be greeted can I fetch you any refreshments?”

“We’re fine, thank you,” Spinnerella answered with a gentle wave.

“Very well, please just wave to me or one of the attendant drones if you change your mind!” it said cheerily before turning and rolling its way down the line.

“I suppose all that technology is good for something other than fighting the Horde,” Glimmer mused.

“True, but look carefully, some of the chefs and like are clearly from Princess Mermista’s kingdom,” Netossa pointed out as they got closer to the main hall. The fierce fighter rubbing her chin mused, “This may be a sign of her kingdom being under Dryl’s sway as a subject state.”

“Or,” her wife countered, “This could be a sign she’s trying to signal she has influence in Dryl and that Dryl relies on her as well.”

“Or,” Bow cut in, “Maybe they decided to help out because they're friends and friendly friends and good people help each other out?”

Neither older champions of the Rebellion seemed to think much of that take given their shared arched brows of elegant disbelief.

Glimmer herself couldn’t say and was far more interested in watching the ongoing greetings as the fiercely isolationist Frosta who had given up the chance to host the event to allow this… ‘test’ to take place.

‘Judging by her expression I don’t think she’s very happy about this.’

Entrapta's back was getting sore from standing so stiffly. Apparently she couldn't even use her hair to take a load off without looking 'less than regal'.

Still, she kept a smile on her face as she greeted the long line of guests, already having calculated when she'd be free to at least slouch a little.

A pleased thrill ran up her spine when she felt Catra's tail press against her sore back, gently rubbing circles out of anyone's view.

Before she could even offer a subtle thanks, the next guest stepped up, this one accompanied by a bodyguard, and who was very, very small.

Entrapta looked down and accepted the stiff bow from Princess Frosta with a subtle nod of her own.

"Princess Frosta, we welcome you to Dryl."

The princess's tone was clipped, "Thank you, Princess Entrapta, I confess I was surprised at the change in venue for this years ball, but you seem to have met the expectations of hostess marvelously."

Catra offered a polite, subtle bow, and said, "We were honored to be chosen and are so pleased you find the festivities to your liking, princess Frosta."

"I was speaking to the princess, not the help," Frosta answered curtly, drawing amusement from the crowd.

But they'd prepared for this.

Entrapta slipped one arm around Catra's and they leaned against one another as she said, "Actually, Catra is my majordomo, meaning anything said to her is addressed to me."

Catra rested her free hand on Entrapta's, gently patting the gloved hand as she added, "Anything Entrapta proclaims is spoken with

two voices.”

They spoke together, “We are in essence, one.”

Now it was Frosta reeling, gaze snapping to those behind her as she tried to rally and offered a second stiff bow, “My apologies… I was unaware that your relationship had taken such an official form.”

“It's no problem,” Catra soothed, “you’re still young after all.”

The princess quickly shuffled off as Catra did a good job of masking her amusement at another win; well, good to anyone who didn’t know how mirthful Catra could be.

‘*Not that I mind~*’ Entrapta hummed in her own head as they turned to their next guests.

Catra thought the night was going well, despite the fact the laser throne hadn’t been finished on time. Everything looked good, the guests seemed unable to express discontent openly which she counted as a win and Entrapta was proving too fetching to keep her eyes off half the time.

‘*I even got to mess with the twit twins*,’ she thought. Recalling how she’d feigned not remembering fighting the pink sparkle and her foppish friends much to the smaller one’s embarrassed frustration at her overly friendly manner.

Resting a hand on Entrapta’s hip she whispered, “Should we go get some tiny food and ‘mingle’?”

“I’d love to, but I think we still have one guest, a late arrival, then we can snack,” her princess grinned.

Catra smirked even as her mind concocted theories, ‘Late arrivals, so either incompetent or a power play-‘

Adora stepped into the courtyard. Her hair was done up with a pointed crimson metal ‘comb’. She wore the Horde symbol proudly on her lapel and her lean athletic form was a snug fit not the black and crimson silk suit that evoked Shadow Weaver’s favored colors with ever smooth sway and motion.

At her side was some tall women in a black dress with a bejeweled belt and pincers Catra barely even acknowledged.

Only Entrapta’s hand on hers stopped Catra from lurching forward, fangs grinding, claws aching, mind screaming and yet all she could do was let out a strangled gasp.

“That’s princess Scorpia, her family never comes, but they’re protected under the treaty,” Entrapta said, hastily and as if by wrote.

Tail lashing, breath barely under control, Catra forced herself to still as Adora approached her, expression radiating nothing but suspicion and jamming a dagger into her chest with every step closer.

‘Why are you here!?’ She wanted to cry but there’d be no answer.

Adora had felt those mis-matched eyes locked onto her from the moment she stepped into the garish foyer on Scorpia’s arm.

“You OK?” Scorpia whispered, earning a brief nod and appreciative pat on the claw for her concern.

Scorpia was everything a Force Captain should be in Adora’s measure and she was relieved to have her on side. The taller woman’s warm presence a comfort, especially under the predatory gaze of the traitor in her own den.

‘*We just need to pull this off and everything will be back on track*,’ the traitors gaze followed her closely as they approached the steps. *‘Catra, why are you doing this!?’* Something in her cried before vanishing entirely.

'I know why she's doing this,' squaring her shoulders and offering a confident grin, she and Scorpia bowed as one, "Greeting, princess of Dryl, general Catra."

"Adora," the traitor said with a sort of intense desperate need one who was starving to death might have when begging for food.

Clutching her general's hand the princess grinned weakly and said, "Princess Scorpia, Force Captain Adora, my Majordomo and I are surprised by your presence. I imagine it must have been quite a trip from the Frightzone to Dryl."

"Oh yeah, took forever even in my personal ship, and finding parking, haha, wow, way harder than you'd expect, Adora even had to redo my eye-shadow," Scorpia slacked her claws cheerfully and added, "She did great as you can tell."

"Sorry, ah about the parking, mountain cities don't leave a lot of space for that," the princesses' eyes were flickering to the traitor's and between with obvious concern.

"Adora," The traitor whispered again, almost pleading, "Do you… not remember me?"

Adora fought off a tingling running across her skin and shook her head, "Sorry Majordomo, but no," disliking the way the traitor's gaze made her stomach churn, Adora turned back to the princess and fought off a scowl for some reason.

"Whatever the differences between our factions, I hope we can all enjoy a pleasant night," she said, bowing once more and waiting to be dismissed.

Swallowing, the princess, weakly waved them on with a, "I hope so too," that trailed after them as they disappeared into the crowd.

A whisper echoed in her ear.

“She took the bait,” and sure enough, caught in a reflective bit of polymer, Adora saw Catra slip away from the princess to begin trailing after her at a distance.

Patting Scorpia’s claw, they exchanged a quick nod and split off.

Catra’s gaze never leaving Adora’s back for even an instant.

Catra hadn’t been watching the clock, but she knew she’s been following Adora for something like half an hour, maybe longer. She was never able to get her alone, never able to quite force herself to interact with her, wary of what she might do but like a moth and a flame unable to drag herself away.

Which was why when Adora mouthed “We need to talk” Catra had found her heart racing and guided her to the second-floor balcony without a second thought.

Now that she was here though, with Adora again after so long, she couldn’t even find the words.

Adora had no such problems.

“You seem to have done well for yourself,” Adora said curtly.

Turning from the party to face her, Catra found herself stammering, “Ah, well, yeah I guess I have. I didn’t exactly plan on it, but it worked out well so far.”

That drew a displeased glare from the blonde that Catra was unaccustomed to.

“What? Don’t look at me like that, we can’t all be Shadow Weaver’s favorites, some of us have to work for a living.”

“You were one of her favorites before you turned on her,” snapped Adora.

“Oh, don’t start with that, she never cared about me like she did you!”

“You might think that, but I was told how much she let you slide on things.”

“She never let things slide, if I got away with anything it was cos she wasn’t paying attention, nothing more!”

“You’d like me to believe that, but I know what you really are, a traitor!”

They’d closed the distance and Catra found herself staring into Adora’s deep blue eyes and the flame in her chest fading fast as she sagged. She almost leaned in for a hug when Adora slipped back just out of reach and Catra bit her tongue.

“Adora… Adora is this really how you want things to be between us?”

Adora shrugged, “I wouldn’t know, you never gave me any choice, but I know I’m loyal to the Horde.”

“What do you mean never gave you any choice?”

Adora turned away from her, hand running through her hair.

“Does it really matter Catra, whatever you wanted between us, it's in the past now.”

Keeping up conversations without Catra was proving difficult; it seemed like everyone wanted to talk but no one wanted to say anything and as host Entrapta knew she had to ‘make the rounds.’

But without Catra to slip in an excuse and subtle inflection here and there, Entrapta was finding herself surrounded by an increasing crowd all of whom wanted something different and it was getting overwhelming and stressful and-

A familiar presence appeared at her back as the music grew quiet.

Entrapta turned and there was Catra, offering her hand, “My Princess, the slow dance is about to begin, would you do me the honor of your company?”

Flushed with relief and heart beating so fast it hurt, Entrapta placed her hand in Catra’s and they strode towards the center of the courtyard.

“All right, you regal royals, we’re gonna slow things down a bit and bring in some classical music this night, for the slooowww dance.”

Catra’s hand on her hip, another with fingers intertwining with her own and tail tracing up and down her side, Entrapta followed the practiced steps as the music started up, following Catra’s firm but gentle leader as the world faded to just them.

Soon enough she was brought into a tighter embrace, head resting against Carta’s fluffy collar and feeling her strong firm encircling her protectively.

“I’m sorry for leaving your side,” Catra whispered.

“Its OK, I understand this is… complicated,” Entrapa answered.

“Maybe, but Adora is the past,” Catra hummed, “and you are my future.”

“This… isn’t right…” Catra murmured, mind racing over their conversations and Adora’s behavior.

“What do you mean?” Adora asked, suddenly sounding off balance.

“You keep swinging between acting like you know me and only ever heard of me and-“

A faint whirring distracted her as the butler bot rolled onto the balcony.

“Please, guests are not permitted on the second floor.” Its eyes flickered and it turned its attention to her and said. “Catra, your slow dance with Entrapta is scheduled for now.” It buzzed. “But you are already dancing. Carry on- Danger!”

Catra was turning before it spoke and barely brought her guard up in time to block Adora’s sai; the tri-pointed dagger shattered the crystals of her armguard, a red crystal thrumming with eldritch energy on the tip.

Catra yanked her arm back but Adora struck her across the face with her free hand and sent her spiraling.

The blonde charged her and Catra ducked low, before pouncing, crashing against Adora and launching them both over the balcony's edge.

“**ENTRAPTA!**”

Entrapta knew right away to tear herself away from the false Catra only for shadowy tendrils to embrace her as fur gave way to darkness and subsumed her.

“The Horde broke the treaty, open fire!” Dhashi howled, drawing her sword.

The last thing Entrapta saw before the darkness swallowed her whole was Catra’s terrified screaming face.

Then.

Nothing.

“Oof!” Adora huffed in her arms, Scorpia catching the smaller woman easily in her arms.

“Its OK, I got ya, I got ya.”

“Thanks,” Adora said, moving like a blur and tearing Scorpia’s crystal belt off her waste and hurling it into the air, before pressing a button on her lapel.

“The Horde broke the treaty, open fire!” a fish lady screamed.

Guard droids and butler droids spouted guns and let loose pink shots at the crystals tearing through them but that only muffled the explosives amongst them rather than wiping them out.

“My eyes!”

“Its burns!”

Screams filled the air as the gasses sealed with in flooded the area.

“We need to go!” Scorpia whispered, bashing her way passed guards as Adora remained locked tight in her arms, as if in shock as the gas spread.

“It’s OK, it's not permanent,” Scorpia whispered, leaping over the wall and crushing one of the guard droids beneath her heel.

She let out a yelp as Shadow Weaver’s darkness swirled around them too, scooping them up and dragging them off the cliff face and into the waiting Horde speedster she’d driven here, now piloted by some of Adora’s squad-mates.

Dumping them and the unconscious princess on the floor, Shadow Weaver’s magic formed a protective barrier against the surge of laser fire, as they revved up and sped off into the night sky.

Chapter End Notes

> Hi again, sorry for the wait, but I wanted to make sure everyone had recovered from Season 4 before posting this, hahaha, I hope everyone enjoyed it as much as I did! (I cried

several times, my gosh, feels train) and I hope this chapter too was enjoyable, thanks as always for reading, any comments, questions or feedback are welcome!

When it comes to the loosely affiliated 'anti Dryl', I didn't want to portray them super negatively, but I didn't want their concerns to all be 100% pure either, hence the mixture of concerns between losing distinct kingdoms and power alongside being disturbed by industrialization similar to the Horde's and how generally grabby Dryl is. As it is, the Rebellion and associated kingdoms, while obviously having free thinkers, often feel very staunchly traditional, which makes sense with a foe bent on destroying individuality like the Horde, but it does leave them rather rigid, while Entrapta is like "What are norms and traditions?" and Catra "Don't care, gonna break-em if it serves my interests."

Apologies if the Princess Prom seems predictable, but I've been imagining some of these scenes such as the Majordomo reveal since way early days and I felt it worked well to lead in for a season finale and to highlight some of the drama going on behind the scenes, so I hope that worked! Also figuring out a dress for Entrapta was hard, I got some advice on it thought which helped give me an idea of what I wanted :D

Also Frosta's line was likely something she was advised to say and she went along with cos she was miffed at the change in venue, while for others it was to try and implicitly put Catra down as she's seen as putting on airs by controlling so much and implicitly challenging traditional monarchs with her village deals.

Also this and the next chapter made me hate Shadow Weaver more than ever.

Also, yes, Entrapta did give Memrista a personal assistant/battle bot.

The End

Chapter Summary

This chapter has a section of intense and one sided violence, I will provide a warning for when the scene begins and ends.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

People were still whimpering about their eyes, or coddling each other as Catra stumbled through the din, claws bared, barely able to hear as she looked towards the forest.

'This was my fault.'

Someone was trying to get her attention.

'I left her alone.'

She didn't care about what they had to say.

'I let them toy with me.'

And for what?

A chance at making someone she had loved acknowledge her.

Winning them back?

Understanding what went wrong when Shadow Weaver would never allow such a thing?

'I failed…'

And now all she could imagine was Entrapta in Shadow Weaver's grasp, voice raised high in agony.

Catra's scars burned.

“Majordomo Catra, we need a-“

Catra’s entire body contorted, her spine cracked, her chest swelled as she threw her head back, claws and fangs bared, Catra roared.

She did not notice how the guests clutched their heads or cowered away, she didn’t even care how the rafters shook or her armor screamed, pulsing with power, desperate to let loose her rage upon a target.

A choked hiss tore its way from her throat, echoing in the silent courtyard, before she snapped to attention and snarled.

“Dhashi!?”

“Uh, yes!” The captain saluted, from across the foyer.

“I’m going to get Entrapta, ready me a ship and manage things until we get back.”

“Uh, no,” she countered.

“What?” Catra seethed.

“We,” she stressed, “are going to get the princess back, you’ll need a getaway driver and I’m the best Skiff pilot on contract.”

Severald distressed droids were beeping their protest and Catra shuddered, claws digging into her palms.

“Fine. Ready a medium sized Skiff, Emily, and EM-C2, you two are with us as well, be ready to move out in twenty minutes, I’m getting some grenades.”

“But-“ Quill started.

Catra just shouted, “Dryl override, Grand Bureaucrat Protocols, code-cxnineone!”

The bot’s beep and buzzed for an instant before turning to Quill.

“There,” she snapped, shaking off the Satyr, “You’re in charge so long as Entrapta, Dashi or myself aren’t around, tend to the guests while we go and fight the Horde.”

With that she launched herself over the crowd and raced into the tower.

“Hey, hold up,” Mermista called after her.

“We demand to come with!” Seahawk called as they raced behind her.

In the crowd, Netossa and Spinnerella were looking for Glimmer and Bow, already fearing where the two had gotten too.

Catra could barely even feel the cold night wind battering her form as they raced towards the Frightzone at top speed through the woods.

Mermista and Seahawk were sitting in front of her, the former having had to steal some clothes from Dhashi’s locker, both looked pensive.

At her back was Dhashi, nervousness practically radiating from the pirate, why she wanted to come along Catra didn’t know.

Either side of her were Emily and her sister, eldest of Entrapta’s bots, and both low key looking forlornly at the deck.

“Seahawk, I need your sword.”

“Ah, of course, to stab into the enemy’s territory on the map, yes?”

Taking his sword she ignited the flames and spun it in her hand before pressing it to the deck, “No. Its to stab it into some stowaways if they don’t get out in three, two-“

There was a flash of sparkles and the intruders flopped onto the dock before her, the boy shouting, "No stabbing, no stabbing!'

Catra spun the sword in hand again to get it into proper stabbing position as she hissed, "Why. Are. You. Here?"

The boy answered first, "We want to help save Entrapta, of course."

The girl, perhaps seeing her not lowering the sword clarified with an angry huff, "We also hate the Horde and wanna fight them."

"Well, all right then," she tossed the sword back to Seahawk.

"Wait, just like that?" the boy asked.

"If you two die, I'm not responsible. This is war, this is the Frightzone, there are no guarantees and I'm not one of your subjects, so don't expect me to put you above anyone else on this mission," she said bluntly.

"Uh, boss, you're coming off as a bit cold there," Dhashi murmured.

Catra let her head roll back and all she could feel was the sinking horror of Entrapta engulfed in shadows.

"I'm being honest, don't like it, you're free to leave."

She looked across the assorted crew and while not one looked pleased, no one made to leave.

Unfastening her Data-Pad, Catra brought up the map of the Frightzone.

"Ever since I started thinking that defeating the Horde was more than just a delusion clung to by idiots-"

"Hey!"

“I’ve been tinkering with assault plans on the Frightzone, just ideas mostly, but it means I’ve been going over my memories, our stolen maps and gathered intelligence from Horde soldiers.”

She tapped her finger across a few key factories, “I've been toying with the idea of planting explosives below these places to cause maximum damage.”

The boy raised his hand and squeaked, “Doesn’t that feel a bit um evil-ish?”

“This is war, people die.”

“Yeah but killing them by surprise in their homes,” he mumbled.

“Fortunately for your ease of mind, we’re not here for that.” She tapped the outer junk yards and continued. “We will be planting explosives but here, these junk yards and power rigs will catch fire easily but there’s practically no one around but droids.”

She turned to her bots and added, “The bad kind that don’t think,” earning reassured beeps. “The Horde fire fighters will come, and this distraction will also undercut their security. With their personnel focused on the base's interior, sneaking around in the chaos will be much easier.”

“But how are we getting in?” Glimmer asked, motioning at the wall.

Catra looked to Mermista and then Dhashi and said, “I have a plan for that.”

Entrapta weaved her tools through her hair.

“Ow!” Another shock from one of the glowing crystal orbs ran across her body.

‘I got the torch three times farther than last time… That means that I have determined the range of the electrical sensors, I just

need to be more careful in my movements.'

Entrapta knelt in a large circular chamber, a runestone humming as it loomed over her, and four electrical crystals held up on bronzes stands surrounding her. Each one letting loose a stream of controlled electricity that encircled her arms and hair tendrils respectively and would send coursing electrical pain across her body if she moved too much.

'Glad I do so much heavy lifting in the lab, or my arms would be getting tired,' Entrapta mused as she shuffled her lock picking kit a little further down from the crown of her head towards the floor.

Entrapta's captor pulled her hands away from the Black Garnet with a gasp, the pulsing, thrumming of the artifact quieting as she dusted off her hands. Normally Entrapta would have been enraptured by the chance to see a Runeestone in action, but if she got out, she'd be able to do far more than just watch!

The white eyed figure paced around her, humming with interest, "I would love to take the time to take you apart to understand the odd magic that suffuses your hair. I would ask you to explain, but, well, I assume you are incapable of understanding it yourself."

Wanting to take her apart to understand her was one thing, but Entrapta drew the line at insulting her intelligence.

"You know, I'm not an expert," she hissed at a sharp prickle of lightning on her cheek, "but I don't think announcing your own ignorance then insulting my intelligence really works, as an insult I mean. It's just not structurally sound-aaaaaah!"

Shadow Weaver unclenched her hand and Entrapta sagged a little as the pain faded into a distant burning sensation, just like when she burnt herself on hot coco, really, it was definitely not vastly worse.

"You might want to learn some humility child; it may save your life."

Entrapta looked up at the woman and answered, “I’ve never been given a reason to be humble though- aaaa!”

Shadow Weaver hissed, “How about now?”

Entrapta panted, chest heaving, lock pick having finally reached the floor of the chamber before she answered, “Catra was right, you aren’t very smart-AAAAAAHH!”

The doors opened with a hiss and Shadow Weaver ceased her torment at the intruders shocked gasp, “Shadow Weaver, what are you doing!?”

“I was just defending myself, she threatened me.”

“From on her knees? In a magical cage?” Adora asked, sounding half disbelieving and half unsure.

Shaking off the ringing in her ears, Entrapta spied the blonde and wiggled her head in greeting as much as she could, “Hi, you're Adora right? Catra misses you; clever plan using that by the way, not nice but very effective.”

Both women looked to one another as if unsure what to do with her, or themselves at that statement. Entrapta used to feel uncomfortable in creating that sensation but seeing Catra revel in making people question themselves too much to speak had been a good learning experience for ‘aggressive negotiations’ she felt.

Adora was the first to shake herself to action, “Look, I don’t know what that traitor told you but-“

“Oh that’s easy, she told me all about how Shadow Weaver erased your-“

“Be silent!” Shadow Weave hissed, sending a subtle wave of lighting through her body.

Through grit teeth Entrapta bit out, “Memory.”

Adora looked to Shadow Weaver who just spat, “Lies and delusions concocted by a dangerous mind.”

“Then,” Entrapta heaved, “Why are you so afraid of me talking?”

“Because you rebels are unscrupulous, wicked creatures who might try and play Adora’s better nature against her and those who love her.”

Entrapta arched an eyebrow and answered, “I don’t think you know what love is, but hearing you say it made me feel slimy.”

“Enough of this,” Shadow Weaver groused, massaging her temples, “Adora, what can I do for you?”

Stumbling, Adora answered, “Right, uh, I spoke to Lord Hordak, pleaded with him, but he feels the operation was as much mine as yours and Scorpia’s and…” she rubbed her arm. “He says that he doesn’t think this benefits us enough for him to consider reinstating you. Yet.”

“Its to be expected I suppose, but fortunately,” Shadow Weaver turned to gaze down at her, “I will find a way to ensure this one proves her worth.”

“Will you erase my memory too?” Entrapta asked, affecting an air of mere curiosity by focusing solely on the practical side of things and not what she stood to lose. “Because I don’t think there’s any other way I’d help you before Catra rescues me, or I escape, whichever comes first.”

“Enough of your fanciful tales,” Shadow Weaver hissed, “I will gain all I need from you one way or the other,” she looked to her side and added, “to ensure the safety of the Horde from your malicious attacks.”

“Then you won’t mind Adora staying, will you?” Entrapta asked, her lock picking kit was another foot closer to one of the lightning towers.

At their shared disquieted looks Entrapta smiled.

‘Its just like Catra said when we were talking about diplomacy with the villages. Find out what’s important to someone, keep it in focus and hammer away at it until it works for you!’

Honestly though, Entrapta was very glad that seemed to have worked, because she was just making conversation for much of that.

In the distance, the Frightzone loomed large, jutting out from the ruined mountains like a disease covered blade bursting from the heart of the land.

In the barren wastelands surrounding it, a small party could be found just outside the dying woods, standing around a hole.

“It smells so bad!” Glimmer groused, lurching back from the hole the droids had dug into the earth in disgust alongside the rest of the party.

Catra could smell it worse than any of them but tuned it out.

“Mermista, you can’t back up the Horde’s entire sewer system, can you?”

“No, I don’t have the range for that,” the princess mumbled, looking suspicious at the hole.

“Alright then, just keep it off us and guide us through.”

Mermista looked to her and mimed gagging before jumping down and letting out a shuddering groan before the water began to shift and twist at her will.

“You know, as your getaway driver-” Dhashi started.

Catra just leveled her with a stare and the captain muttered.

“I hate you for making me do this.”

“Duly noted, get in the hole.”

Motioning to the droids she waved for them to follow and jumped into the decaying pipelines.

“Once the maps show us under the scrap yard, Glimmer you’ll teleport up with me and we’ll start planting the explosives.”

“OK, but keep in mind I can only teleport so many times.”

“Still can’t believe you need to recharge your powers,” Mermista chuckled.

“Still mad you got poop water in your mouth?” Glimmer sniped back.

Catra tuned out their squabbling, starting intently into the darkness.

‘Entrapta, hold on.’

A plasma bolt nicked Entrapta’s ear and she bit down a shout of pain.

Adora marched back and forth, sweat pouring down her face, hair frazzled as Shadow Weaver watched from the sidelines, calmly, happily even.

“Do you even understand the damage you rebels cause? While you princesses throw yourselves lavish parties the people beneath you live in anarchy. But when the Horde tries to protect them and establish law and order you use them as weapons against us!”

“Actually, Catra and I are using our technology to better supply and defend villages within and outside the territory of Dryl and facilitating open trade.”

“With technology you stole, by attacking Horde soldiers just doing their jobs, you’re a thief!”

Entrapta tried to shrug, “Maybe? I never thought much about morality to be honest, too much science to do.”

She ignored Adora’s bitter “Of course.”

“But,” she stressed, “If the Horde were so great, I figure people would be eager to join, wouldn’t they?”

“That’s because you stop them from doing so with lies and propaganda!”

They were interrupted by a sudden wave of alarms echoing throughout the halls.

Adora staggered back, “Someone’s breached the outer perimeter. Shadow Weaver I-“

“Go, my dear, I shall guard the prisoner.”

Adora spared her a look before racing out the door.

Entrapta edged the lock picking kit closer to the orbs stand as Shadow Weaver loomed over her.

“Now then, this will be very difficult with that lightning all around you, but I promise, by the time I am through, there won’t be enough of you left to be impertinent!”

‘Catra, hurry!’

The hallways of the Frightzone were filled with a sickly green light that stung the eyes, the uniforms were tight, rough and ill fitting as their party gathered around a terminal. The droids were standing guard either side to shield the last vestiges of their identity.

“Dammit,” Catra hissed, claws tearing down the side of the terminal.

“What’s wrong?” Bow asked softly.

Catra’s claws were already flying over the console again as she spoke, “There’s no sign of Entrapta in any of the prisons, that means they’re keeping her somewhere else.”

“Should we try and spring the prisoners anyway?” Glimmer asked. “I mean, we can’t just leave them.”

“If you’re looking for rebel allies, it’d be a waste of time, those not enslaved or killed are sent to Beast Islands to die there,” Catra said coldly. “The only prisoners the Horde keeps are its own soldiers as examples.”

“Still,” she continued, “We might need to go by there anyway, it’ll depend on where Lonnie is.”

“Who’s Lonnie?” Seahawk asked.

“Yeah do we have spies I don’t know about?” Dhashi asked.

Catra scoffed, “Lonnie’s a consummate soldiers, but she was part of the same platoon as Adora and I and is still working for her now. If I can pull up her schedule and interrogate her, or more likely Kyle, they may have useful information for me on where Entrapta’s being kept. She’d be either In some specialized cells I never saw or with Shadow Weaver, but we don’t have time to waste on false leads and they’re my best bet on an answer.”

“So how are going to find like, three soldiers in the middle of the Frightzone?” Mermista asked.

“Easy, I already said they’re working for Adora, I just signed in under her records and am scanning her squad records.”

“Uuuh, how do you know her passwords?”

“They’re three fold, favourite number, favorite color and the numbers corresponding to her favorite color.”

The group grew quiet before Mermista added, “It's kind of creepy you know that.”

“Don’t blame me, it was Kyle’s idea of a bonding exercise, and Adora,” Catra’s fangs ground, “She doesn’t remember enough to change her passwords, and no one besides us ever knew about it.” Under other circumstances she might have sounded smug, but as it was, Catra’s confidence and mirth were absent, replaced by a pained tension.

“Found them,” she snapped, “Let’s move.”

The path to the prisons was winding and filled with tension, their party split in half and guided by the Droids towards the prison cells where Catra’s former squad mates were on duty.

“All right, you all remember the plan?” Catra hissed into her mic.

“Yes,” everyone chanted as one.

“Then go!” Catra raced forward towards the prison entry-way, Dhashi at her side and as one they buried their fists into the necks of the guards on duty, muffling their cries for help before slamming their heads against the walls, leaving them limp.

Catra’s ears twitched and she slammed the door's switch and they raced inside, Seahawk and Emily at their back.

They were greeted by the sight of water flooding the bottom levels, as Glimmer dueled with a hulking reptile in the security overseers chambers and Bow stood atop it, letting loose arrow after arrow that fused the doors shut with concoctions or electric shocks to short circuit them.

“We need reinforce-”

Seahawk decked the soldiers shouting with a “Ha hah!”

Catra just surveyed the scene, ears twitching until she heard some familiar shrieking and leapt from the third floor to the fifth and landed right before Kyle as he tried to snipe bow making him scream.

“Hey, Kyle,” She snarled, claws coiling around his thin little throat before she hefted him into the air and dangled him over the gap below. She ignored his gasping wheeze to bear her glowing gauntlet at Rogelio and Lonnie who froze at the sight of her weapon and hostage.

“Hey, hey, easy Catra,” Lonnie tried to sooth.

“I am so far beyond done with everything, Lonnie, so don’t start,” she snapped, teeth smacking together as she imagined biting her former bully.

Lonnie’s arm shot out to hold Rogelio back as she looked between the painfully one-sided battle below and Catra, then Kyle, as she said. “Look, we’re losing here, I get that; but come on, its Kyle, he’s harmless, he never even gave you trouble.”

“Oh so you do remember me,” she seethed, loosening her grip and letting Kyle’s feet touch the floor, but making it clear she could send him falling at any moment.

“Yeah, yeah we… We all remember, cept Adora,” she rubbed her arm and chuckled, “Guess we weren’t important enough to wipe.”

Catra snorted, tossing Kyle to the floor before them and watching Rogielio race to the smaller man’s side, helping him up.

“Where’s Entrapta?”

“That’s what you’re here for?”

Catra’s answer was to let loose a bolt of photon fire right over their heads, “Answer the question!”

“She’s with Shadow Weaver in her chambers,” Lonnie answered before Kyle or Rogelio could even speak.

All eyes zeroed in on her and Catra growled, “Why tell me?”

Lonnie looked… unsure before muttering, “Cos no one deserves what she’s gonna do to her.”

Catra’s eyes flew wide, claws shaking and then a powerful boom resounded against one of the doors.

“Surrender in the name of Lord Hordak!” Adora cried from the other side.

“What do we do now?!” Glimmer shouted.

Catra did what she did best, acted. With a massive sweeping kick and the shield generator attached to her leg she sent, the trio before her flying into an open cell and sealed it shut. “We’re even now,” she ground out, before turning away from them and barking her order.

“You lot, carve a way out through like we discussed, Dhashi you and Emily go one way, the rest of you take the low road and meet up at the meeting point!”

“But what are you gonna do!?“

“You know where I’m going,” she muttered as the doors exploded inwards, “Now move!”

Bow let loose twin arrows that spewed smoke into the air as lasers began to fill up the chamber.

Glimmer let loose a monstrous ball of blinding light.

Mermista turned water into spray and Seahawk tossed his last grenade to the deepest level and as it rocked the prisoner chamber, the escapee parties fled in the confusion, while Dhashi shot out the door, still in disguise.

Catra was already gone, the vent grate subtly placed back where it belonged before she slinked into the darkness and towards the bastion of her every childhood nightmare.

'Entrapta, I'm coming!'

Lightning crackled and screamed as Entrapta triggered the blast mechanism and obliterated the stands base, sending the orb falling and freeing her right hair.

"Where were you hiding that!?" Entrapta's hair lashed out and in one fell swoop she sent the stands and their orbs flying across the chamber even as the lightning lanced across her skin.

Shadow Weaver threw herself back, barely missing being struck by the whip like blows. Entrapta launched herself towards the door only to see the path cut off by a wave of electricity she barely dodged. Throwing herself into the air, she curled her hair around the Black Garnet and tried to spin herself out of Shadow Weaver's sight, only for the woman to let loose a howl that shook the chamber. An orb of shadow surrounded her form before she let loose wave after wave of crackling darkness.

Entrapta tried to dodge, weave and duck, but there were too many angles and the speed!

Before long one struck and she found herself bound in a blanket of coiling, crushing energy as a panting Shadow Weaver screeched.

"I am going to tear apart your mind bit by bit you little wretch!"

The sorceress lurched towards the Black Garnet and with a pained hiss grasped the crystal, "You will not defy me, no one will defy me!"

The chill that ran down her spine at the screams hastened Catra forward, blurring on all fours through the vents.

The painfully familiar scent of Shadow Weaver's chamber and the eldritch energies that suffused it was familiar but did not to divert Catra from her path.

Coming to a stop at the wall vents grate she spied Entrapa on her side, wrapped in a web of darkness Catra knew too well. There were burns on her arms as she was forced to contort and coil in on herself to merely limit the pain of the crackling red lightning binding her in place.

A violent throbbing shudder bared her claws as her heart beat and blood boiled so loud it hurt her chest and filled her ears before she raised her leg and kicked the grating in.

A bolt of red magic soared over head as Catra lazily ducked beneath it, Shadow Weaver's startled shout of 'you!' going completely unnoticed as she stalked towards her.

"Still rebelling?" she snarled, letting loose a bolt of magic.

"Always." Catra angled her head to dodge the all too familiar shot and readied to jump.

Shadow Weaver roared and let loose the usual crackling arc that Catra had already leapt over before it left her hand.

Bouncing off the crystal and spiraling another twin contorted arcs of lightning wreathed shadows.

"You learned nothing from me, defiant and stupid to the end!"

Shadow Weaver's shriek as Catra hit the wall and kicked herself off from it was deafening as the sorcerer let loose a wave of darkness that was always too slow to hit, save when Catra wanted it to.

Lashing up pipes and weapons, instruments of torture and metal grating, she howled, "All you learnt to do was hide and dodge while clinging to someone else for power!"

Catra weaved, jumped and dodged her way around each of the instruments “No, I learnt everything from you, how to dodge, resist, to fight back!”

They slammed against walls and floor with deadly force before she ducked behind the crystal and out of view.

She could hear Shadow Weaver stalking towards her, always wanting to get close and personal.

“Your punishments?” Catra hissed, leaping silently into the air and coiling around the Garnet.

Her voice echoed as she planned, and Shadow Weaver blurred around the garnet and was too slow to catch anything as she let loose a bolt at empty air as Catra rounded on her from behind and leapt.

“Those were just practice-“

Shadow Weaver turned, shadows in her grasp, eyes wide.

“For this day!”

Her claws struck true and the crimson crystal scattered at her attack, the magic vanishing from hands as she howled.

“Noooo!”

Shadow Weaver was falling to her knees, Catra landed and raced forward delivering a punch to her gut that sent Shadow Weaver skidding across the floor and collapsing in a heap, bile spewing up from her mouth and spraying across the inside of her mask.

Tail lashing, her gaze snapped to Entrapa just in time to see the princess cheer as the magical restraints fizzled and died.

Seeing Entrapta pushing herself up from the floor, Catra allowed herself a small smile, “I’ll be with you in a second.” Before her

focus returned to Shadow Weaver still sputtering and spewing profanities on the floor.

Violence Start

As her shadow eclipsed her tormentors, Shadow Weaver tried to draw back but Catra caught her by the hair and yanked her up.

Another punch, this time to the kidneys, and Catra felt Shadow Weaver's body shuddering and crumpling under her strength. She spun and yanked Shadow Weaver around, claws weaving through her hair and forced the woman to her knees, back to her and letting Catra drive a kick into her back that left bones cracking.

Before Shadow Weaver's hair and body gave way Catra snatched the top of her mask and let her go free to crash against the floor with a choked screech of pain.

Violent spasms racked her feeble form as Catra stalked around her, watching Shadow Weaver sputtering, begging as she tried to drag herself away.

"Catra… Ple-"

Catra stomped on her hand until she heard bones cracked.

Shadow Weaver tried to tear herself away and Catra let her.

By kicking her in the face and sending her crashing into the metal walls.

"'Please?' Was that it?" she hissed, stalking forward, and watching as Shadow Weaver's eyes grew wide with terror.

"How many times did I say please!?"

Claws racked across Shadow Weaver's face.

"How many times did I beg and cry!?"

Now the right cheek.

“You took everything I loved!”

She stomped on Shadow Weaver’s knee.

“You tried to take everything I love!”

Another body blow that left shadows spewing from Shadow Weavers maw.

Chest heaving, the scent of blood, fear and tears not her own for once filling her senses as she reared back and snarled.

Violence Over

“No more, not again. This time, I take. This time, you fear. This time, I end it!”

Catra’s claws barreled down and froze solid as Shadow Weaver cowered and cringed and a familiar, pink hand of prehensile hair got in her way.

“Entrapta?” She hissed, shuddering and shaking with rage as something sick pressed up against her throat as her princess slowly came to stand at her side.

“Don’t stop me, she deserves this. We need to kill her!”

Entrapta placed gentle hands on her chest and nodded, “You’re right.”

Shadow Weaver recoiled, curling into a ball, sputtering and hyperventilating as she tried to protect her head as Catra so often had!

“Then why?”

“Because you won already, this isn’t a fight anymore, you won, you’re better,” Entrapta cupped her cheeks. “You were always better and always will be better.”

“Are you trying to say killing her makes me as bad as her, after everything she did to us?”

Entrapta shook her head, “No, you’d still be better, but it wouldn’t be good for you. Killing her like this, beating her, that’s just hurting her to feel good. But you don’t need to, you won, you saved me, we’re free,” she stressed.

“She deserves to die!”

Leaning forward she nuzzled against Catra’s neck, “This isn’t about what she deserves, it’s about what’s best for you, if you kill her now, when you’re like this… I don’t think it would be good for you.”

But with that, Entrapta slowly drew back, offered her a smile and stepped out of the way, “But I won’t tell you what to do, and I won’t judge you for following through on this. Its your choice Catra, whatever happens. I’m with you.”

Catra’s gaze snapped to Shadow Weavers cringing form.

In an instant it all came flooding back, the wounds, the fear, the shadows and endless torment and loss.

Catra’s roar shook the chamber as she struck.

Her ears twitched as Entrapta turned to face her, “Ok so-“ Entrapta froze and quite obviously was taking Catra in with some surprised as she hefted the now unconscious Shadow Weaver over her shoulder.

“If I do kill her, it's not when I’m too angry to think straight; but there’s no way I’m leaving her here to cause us more trouble.”

Entrapta’s hug was warm and welcome, Catra almost wanted to pass out in her arms before pulling back and they spoke as one.

“Let’s get out of here.”

They both turned to the vent and a moment later…

The chamber was empty.

The troops were all busy tending to fires and investigating dead ends halfway across the Frightzone, leaving the back alleyways and secret coves Catra knew by heart easy to weave and leap through under the light of the sick, pulsing clouds and toxic street lights.

Tugging Entrapta after her, Shadow Weaver's limp frame bumping against her back, Catra couldn't stop a cheer, "The others are waiting for us outside. Dhashi will swing by and grab us before we blow this place!"

"We're going home," Entrapta said through ragged breaths, hand grasping Catra's as tightly as she could.

A familiar voice called out as they raced down some scaffolding.

"Catra!" Adora howled.

"Catra I know you're here, I- I don't- I… Show yourself!"

She sounded ragged, confused, voice echoing like a dying breath.

'How could she know where I am unless she remembers something of me,' some part of Catra thought. Then she looked back to Entrapta and simply grasped her hand tighter.

'Not today, not again.'

As they dipped into a hidden alcove that led to the sewers, the last thing Catra heard Adora cry was.

"Bring back Shadow Weaver!"

And then.

Silence.

The damage was being repaired, and the guests all returned home.

Shadow Weaver was locked away in a warded cage under a dozen guard droid watchers and four Mystacor sorcerers in the basement.

The chaos had passed, and calm had settled over the kingdom and the rulers of Dryl retired from public view to the privacy of their tower.

It was rare Catra and Entrapta ever slept at the same time, their erratic schedules make such coordination nearly impossible.

This was always exacerbated by Catra retreating to a new place to sleep almost every night.

That was not a problem tonight as they yawned beneath the gentle light of Entrapta's monitors, the only source of light in the lab.

The drowsy princess leaned against Catra as they shuffled towards the plush purple lounge.

Catra's tail curled around Entrapta's hip and she murmured, "I missed out on our slow dance. Do you want to dance now?"

Entrapta's eyes were already closed, as she nuzzled against Catra's side, "I wanna snuggle and snooze with you."

Chuckling, Catra and Entrapta collapsed against the lounge, sinking into the material, coiling their bodies around one another, desperate to not let go.

Catra could feel sleep oncoming.

Entrapta could barely keep her eyes open.

As they nestled together, neither were sue who moved first, but once one did, so too did the other and in an instant their lips met in a quick and gentle kiss.

And like that, wrapped in each other's embrace, they fell asleep.

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epilogue

Adora knelt before her Lordship, head pressed to the cold steel floor as she spoke.

"My Lord, they took Shadow Weaver, they bypassed our security… I have no excuses but… But I beg the chance to redeem myself and take back Shadow Weaver… Despite-"

"Enough, Force Commander, Adora," he answered, almost gently as he reclined upon his throne, the Rune-Sword grasped in his clawed hands and strange new armor adorning his body.

"Rise," he ordered, and Adora did so.

Tapping steel claw against the steel throne he spoke firmly but not harshly. "Shadow Weaver's failures notwithstanding, she is indeed a dangerous asset for the enemy to have," he smiled and added. "And I can see how much her safety means to you. I will approve efforts to reclaim her, but not at the expense of our regular forces, one shouldn't let their personal feelings influence strategy, correct?"

"Wise words, Lord Hordak, thank you. I promise I will figure something out."

"I am sure you will, and in fact in this regard I think I have something to help you."

Rising from his throne he strode down the steps and showed her reflection in the blade, every instinct told her to grab the wretched thing but she restrained herself.

“Lord Hordak?”

“This Rune Sword you gifted me has proven a most valuable resource, I have already had our troops scouring the underground markets and ruins for more of it to make improved weaponry and armor that I shall soon gift to you.”

Adora bowed, “I am not worthy, Lord Hordak.”

“Oh I think you are,” he mused, pleasantly, spinning the sword in his grasp, “In fact, I believe you have gifted me the missing key towards a goal I had long since started to fear was out of reach.”

He beckoned for her to follow and Adora couldn’t stop herself, “Lord Hordak, what is this goal you speak of?”

His laugh was low and dangerous as he revealed to her a strange, alien machine the likes of which she had never seen before and answered.

“Summoning, the True Horde to Etheria.”

Chapter End Notes

> And thus we reach the end of this journey, as usual I'd like to thank my beta Roman Around and shout out to sondrex76 for your aid, and of course to all of you for reading and offering your takes and feedback, it has been wonderful.
>
> Extra special mention goes out to Historyman, happy birthday, I hope you enjoyed this chapter :D
>
> The scene where Catra confronts Shadow Weaver is one have had in my brain since the early days of this idea, but much like the other ideas I lacked the connecting elements, fortunately I did eventually come up with them and here we are XD Suffice to say, Catra spent much of this chapter in a pure cold rage mode, I thought of revising it to have her smashing and breaking stuff, but decided after the initial roar, Catra's is just so angry and so pained she's come full circle

and become coldly, cruelly calm. Also I still love that scene in S1 where Catra decimates Shadow Weaver, and after everything SW did this story, it was fun to do my own rendition XD

Entrapta nearly making an escape wasn't initially part of the plan, but I wanted to avoid making her too passive and she is rather good at escapes which helped XD Her saying the way SW talked about love made her feel slimy was actually inspired by a video I watched analyzing and tearing down "Pick up artistry" where after quoting a section of book the reader said they felt slimy. Also the "Duly noted; was a reference to Red VS Blue. Oh and on Catra & Lonnie, I felt that regardless of whether or not one view Lonnie or Catra as antagonistic, that their relationship had seemed... tense, before season 4, so I tried to translate that a bit.

On Entrapta stopping Catra, this wasn't some heavy moralistic "You have to forgive your abuser" or "Meeting violence with violence makes you as bad as your abuser" and I hope it did not come off like that. Entrapta's decision and why I went with it, was rooted in concern for Catra's mental and emotional well being and health, and rooted in the idea basically brutalizing someone, even SW, to death to vent frustration would, if nothing else, probably weigh on her, especially given it'd partially be rooted in behaviour learnt from said abuser, if done in battle or for other reasons it wouldn't have the same connotations.

Also yes Catra & Entrapta are very much officially together now :D Also SW's spell isn't perfect even if it is holding the memories back, leading to internal conflict, hence Adora knowing where to look for Catra and kind of stressing out when things don't add up. Also I wanted Catra to make the conscious decision 'not' to go to Adora, hence that last scene where they just miss each other, to show that while it hurts she is committed to Entrapta.

And yeah, that's the general set up in case I come back to this idea to write a sequel, Catra & Entrapta are together, SW is down, the Princess Alliance & The Federation are on less frosty terms, but meanwhile Adora is still in the Horde and wants to save her 'mother figure' and Hordak has now informed her of Horde Prime, and plans to make good use of First One's tech given he got to study the ideal example of it in the form of the sword and even plans to make super soldiers via it too.

As it is I have no plans for a sequel, but I wanted to leave the door open for such things while also telling what I hoped to be a full story.

Thank you all for reading and good luck going forward :)

End Notes

Hi there, thanks for reading!

Any thoughts, feedback or critique would be most welcome!

I'd also like to thank my awesome beta reader RomanAround for fixing so many issues, you rock!

Also thanks to IscariotPaladin for the title!

As noted this was inspired by the set up to Shattered Destinies but I am going in a very different direction with it I hope.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!